Brightest Star

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28038405.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Minor Characters

Additional Tags:
Slow Burn, Mutual Pining, Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Fluff, Feelings Realization, Canon Autistic Character, internalized ableism, Ableism, Autistic Entrapta (She-Ra), Religious Guilt, hordak is bad at feelings, Dorks in Love, Falling In Love, Post-Canon, expect lots of hordak being his usual self-loathing self, and expect entrapta NOT standing for this, also, IN SPACE!, because of course these dorks will be going to space later in this fic

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by becki

Summary

After all of the chaos of the war, Hordak is now free. Well, from Horde Prime, that is. The princesses certainly don't think so, and they don't appear too keen on allowing him to be anytime soon.

Except for Entrapta. Through everything, she stays there by his side, remaining as a comforting constant amidst this new and unfamiliar life post war. And Hordak, of course, greatly enjoys her companionship.

...More so than he realizes, it seems.

By His Side

Chapter Notes

taps mic entrapdak fans? hello? y'all still here?

anyways, i still can't get these two out of my head after all these months, so i'm starting a longfic! there's just so many possibilities of their life post canon, and i really want to get my own thoughts out there. plus, i want to write about them falling in love because they both deserve it

i'm hoping to update once a week, but we'll see! :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It doesn't feel real.

Hordak simply stares, eyes wide and jaw dropped open in a state of shock, at the person beside him. The person who, for all those long and lonely months in the Fright Zone without her as he tried to finish the war, he believed had betrayed him for the Rebellion. The person who, for that brief moment before Prime's arrival where the shapeshifter had talked to him, he believed was certainly dead on Beast Island and there was nothing he could do to save her. The person who, for those final moments on Prime's ship before his demise, he had betrayed his god and risked his life for.

The person who he never believed he would be with again.

But here Entrapta is, as real and alive and bubbly as ever.

And it just doesn't feel real.

Both of her arms are wrapped around Hordak's one, and her smile shines brightly as she babbles on and on. Her high pitched voice wavers with ripples of excitement, similarly to how it sounds when talking about her interests, and her ruby red eyes sparkle with

equal amounts of enthusiasm. Her lavender pigtails trail behind her, jolting with movements and other lively mannerisms as she talks. In fact, her entire being as she walks seems to radiate nothing but pure and unfiltered *joy* and *life.*

And all Hordak can do is stare down at her in shock. His mind is a haze, full of echoes of words and jarring recollections of all that had just occurred, and he can't seem to get his jaw to work to speak coherently. He knows he muttered her name at a few points, unable to do much else, and he knows she had said something about being glad he's here and having lots to talk about. However, the rest is a dizzying blur, and all he can focus on is Entrapta and her lively presence beside him.

She's here. She's really here.

He faintly becomes aware through all of this that he's...laughing a bit, is he? Yes, he is, soft chuckles seeming to escape him with his body overwhelmed and relieved and not knowing what else to possibly do. It feels foreign on his lips, foriegn as it escapes him; he can't recall the last time he's truly laughed. The laughter accompanies what must be a smile - a *real* smile, one he hasn't felt on his face in almost forever and feels strange yet pleasant on his lips.

To be honest, *everything* feels strange yet pleasant. His realization that he's free from Prime after all those years (which is honestly something he really doesn't want to think about at the moment), that Etheria is glistening with raw and pure magic once more, that the ongoing war is seemingly over now, that Entrapta is *right here* - it's all so bizarre, all so abnormal, all so frightening, yet it's euphoric and exhilarating all the same.

All of these feelings...well, they're a little overwhelming. *Really* overwhelming, if he's being honest. The world is bright and loud and utter chaos around him, and he has to blink a few times, trying to clear his head.

But through it all, he focuses on Entrapta. In the boisterous and excitable world around him swarming with giddy princesses and their companions, he focuses on her who walks beside him and leads him to who knows where.

Not that he would question it. Wherever she's going, he'll follow.

"...and I made space suits for the whole group, and to be honest, I think they're some of my best work!" Entrapta continues saying, seemingly about some kind of project she was talking about as they walked. He watches as her hands turn into balled up fists, and they shake side-to-side by her face in excitement as she so often does. "I gotta say, I was pretty proud of myself. And I was even able to make them tailored to their personal preferences while still keeping them perfectly functional!"

At Entrapta's words, floods of warmth shoot through Hordak and flutter amidst his insides. His eyes that gaze down at her soften into something fond, and his ears flick down.

He missed this. He missed *her.*

He missed her so much.

All of a sudden, Entrapta gasps, and her eyes dart up to lock with Hordak's. "Ooh! Ooh! Maybe I could make you a suit sometime! And then we could go to space together! Wouldn't that be fun?"

Hordak freezes at first, jaw dropping as he gapes at her question. He hasn't yet said a fully-fleshed out sentence since their reunion, and his brain still seems to be lagging behind amidst all the chaos, still seems unfit to function properly.

He blinks, and he swallows to clear his throat before attempting to croak out, "Yes, it would. I...I would like that."

Entrapta squeals, her fists shaking once again though even more violently this time. It's certainly not a bad kind of violentness, of course - it's just one way she expresses her happiness sometimes.

Hordak quickly learned as such during all their time together in the Fright Zone before everything went down.

And automatically, at the sight of her joy, he smiles down at her. He can't find himself able to do anything else.

"Okay! Well, then I guess we should start planning a trip soon," she says, seeming to calm down from her initial excitement. Well, only by a bit. "Oh, that'll be so thrilling! Imagine all the things we could study and see together! I've already seen some parts of space, but there's just so much more out there that I haven't yet."

For a moment, Hordak imagines Entrapta's first reaction to seeing space with her own eyes. Oh, how much he wishes he was there to see that.

They continue walking, and for the first time since their reunion, it's quiet. They simply walk side-by-side in each other's presence, basking in the pleasant warmth of the sun that blankets Etheria in light and listening to the faraway sound of chattering from the Etherians. They've certainly made it a substantial distance from the original clustered groups of people after all of this walking. The world is a bit quieter out here around the cliffs, and tranquility hovers in the air amidst the faint chittering of birds and scuffling of animals.

And in this pleasant peace and quiet, after all of that initial adrenaline and excitement had worn off, that's when Hordak's body finally decides to catch up with him.

He's in pain.

It's strange that his body took so long to register it, but here the pain is now, finally having appeared after remaining unseen for some time. Well, to be honest, he really shouldn't be that surprised that he hasn't felt any pain until now; after all, he was injected with pain suppressants on the Velvet Glove. Now, of course, they seem to have finally started to wear off, along with the lessening of his initial overwhelming feelings from earlier that

may have distracted him from any pain. All of this walking without his armor surely didn't help, either.

Hordak grimaces as that familiar sensation of discomfort throbs in his limbs and aches in his joints - not sharp, thankfully, for it remains dull. Though, it's still apparent. It ripples under his clothes, making each step increasingly uncomfortable as time passes on, and as Entrapta starts to pipe up again and shatter the silence, Hordak worries that they won't be planning on sitting any time soon.

In his desperation, his mind becomes a mini battlefield on what to do. Interrupt Entrapta and be a nuisance by requesting to sit down, or simply endur walking?

Another throb pulses through him, and he hisses under his breath.

He doesn't really have a choice, does he?

"And then it turned out that the mysterious being on the planet was actually a nice magical creature that Catra befriended-"

"Entrapta?"

"Hm?" Entrapta says, stopping dead in her words and looking up at him.

Hordak tears his eyes away. Her gaze is intense, and he can't help but feel awfully...vulnerable. Weak, even. What sort of war leader can't go for a simple walk without pain?

"May we...sit down?" Hordak asks, words hesitant. "I am...in pain, I'm afraid."

Entrapta's eyes go wide at first, and she glances up and down Hordak's body as if scanning him. Her features are a mixture of confusion and mostly worry at first, but within seconds, something seems to click in her mind. Her arms, for the first time all day, release Hordak from their firm grasp, and she steps back a bit before gazing back up at him with concern swimming in her eyes.

“Oh…You’re not wearing your armor, huh?” she says. She pauses for a moment, seeming deep in thought, before she blurts out, “Wait, how long have you been in pain? You weren’t hurting all that time on the Velvet Glove, were you?”

Hordak shakes his head. “No, not there. I was given pain relievers so I would have no need for my armor. But, they now seem to be...wearing off, I suppose.”

Entrapta hums, her eyes once more scanning Hordak’s tall frame. He knows it’s only the self-loathing voice in his brain, but some part of him feels awfully ashamed and embarrassed as she studies him in these clothes. Without his armor and instead in these white robes, he can’t help but feel awfully out-of-place. After all, Entrapta isn’t used to seeing him in clothes other than his armor, save for that one vulnerable moment back in the Fright Zone where he collapsed in front of her and had to practically be nursed back to health.

He cringes at the memory. She never seemed to mind Hordak’s pathetic state at the time, but still...

“I definitely should make you new armor asap!” she pipes up, a spark of enthusiasm bursting through her at the prospect of a new project. “It’ll be even better! Though, I’ll have to find a new crystal to power it since we lost the last.”

Hordak’s ears perk up. “The crystal?”

Amidst everything, amidst all the chaos, he had forgotten to tell her. He digs in an inner pocket of his robes, his claw blindly searching for the familiar smoothness, until he finally gets a hold of it. He pulls it out, and palm up, he shows her.

It’s the purple crystal she had used to power his armor, now resting in the palm of his hand.

“I still kept a hold of it,” he says.

Entrapta's eyes widen. She reaches out a tendril of hair to take it, and bringing it up closer to her eyes, she squints at it in inspection.

"Oh, wow! I knew you had it on you some time ago when I last saw you, but I didn't think you *still* had it. Well, that's great!" she exclaims. "I'll be able to use this to power new armor then!"

She goes silent at that, her gaze unfocusing and brows furrowing, and once more, she appears deep in thought. It doesn't last long though, for her eyes soon snap up to lock with Hordak's, a brow raised in confusion.

"Wait, I never got to ask, why did you hold onto it? After all this time?"

Hordak's mouth opens, but nothing comes out. To be honest, he doesn't know. He had found it on the ground in the Velvet Glove all that time ago, and ever since then, it had always been on him. It seemed...important to him, for back then, even when he had no memory of her, it still seemed to cause some kind of recollection, some kind of emotion, to flash through him. Since then, it just felt...safe, in a way, to have on him. Not in any way he could ever explain.

"I'm...not entirely sure," he says. "It just felt important to have. I felt better, I suppose, having it with me."

She looks at him for a few moments, her features unreadable. In the end, however, she simply shrugs and plops the crystal back into Hordak's still open palm where it once rested.

"Well, if you'd like, you can hold onto it until I make the armor soon," she says.

Hordak looks down at the crystal in his palms, studying the material and the strange inscriptions engraved into its surface. He was never able to decipher them, despite how much he tried to in the past, though he's not even certain if they're decipherable in the first place. His best guess is that they're only just decorative

designs, or perhaps even some sort of scientific code that Entrapta uses in her research.

Oh well. Perhaps he'll ask her about it someday.

After a few seconds, he closes his palm around the crystal and tucks it back into his pocket where it previously rested.

"Alright!" Entrapta says, straightening up and putting her hands on her hips. "Now, c'mon! Let's go find somewhere to sit down."

With that said, she whips around and begins to walk off.

And Hordak follows. His eyes solely focused on her as they so often are, he follows.

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It doesn't take them long to find a place to sit. Entrapta spots a cluster of rocks resting up against the cliff, all covered with spongy moss and sprinkles of vibrant flowers peaking amidst it. Hordak walks up the large center rock and sits beside it before slowly resting his back against the surface. Thankfully, he finds it to be comfortable enough, for the moss is soft and plush against his back.

Entrapta sits before him, legs criss-crossed and pigtails sprawled around her on the lush grass. And now fully before him and no longer walking by his side, Hordak gets a chance to truly see her face-to-face - she seems to have dawned a new purple bug-eyed mask instead of her old gray one, and while she's still wearing the same outfit, the straps of her overalls are pulled up and over her shoulder. The gloves on her hands are still the same - dirty and worn, though never removed. She seems to find comfort in them, Hordak supposes.

"Does it still hurt? Even when you're sitting?" she asks, gaze soft as she peers cautiously at him.

Hordak shakes his head. It's true; he feels immensely better without putting weight on his muscles. He knows that, soon enough, he'll be dealing with constant pain even during rest. But, at least for now, he can enjoy the leftover effects of the pain relievers.

"Well that's good! We don't have to get up anytime soon if you don't want," Entrapta says. "Take as long as you need."

At Entrapta's words, a sudden realization pops into Hordak's mind. From where they're sitting after all that walking, they're now awfully far from the rest of the princess and others, and they never announced that they were heading away. Not that they *needed* to tell people where they were, but surely, after all that chaos from that war...

"Do you think people will worry where you are if we stay out here too late?" Hordak blurts out. "As in, the other princesses?"

Oddly enough, Entrapta's eyes go wide for a second. Her brows crinkle together, forming a small knot between them, and a slight frown makes way on her lips. It all appears for only a second, before just like that, her face snaps away towards the ground, concealing her expression. She shrugs, subtlety rubbing her hands around each other in front of her.

"Nah, I don't think they'll really care," she says, her tone unreadable. Hordak quirks a brow in confusion; whether she's upset about what she's saying or entirely indifferent, he can't truly tell, but something tells him it's the former.

Though, why she's upset, he isn't certain.

"I thought you were spending more time with them recently," he says. His words are slow, careful even, as if testing the waters to be certain he's saying the correct things. He's well aware that she never felt connected to the princesses in the past, but from what she had been talking about on their previous walk, it seemed that she'd become part of their group once more. "Were you not? You

did mention spending time with them in space and on other planets.”

She shrugs once more. “Well, yeah, but…”

Hordak waits for a few moments, but her words trail off into nothingness, and she doesn’t seem to be planning on finishing that train of thought.

And then it clicks.

“You still feel alienated from them, don’t you?”

His words hang in the air for a moment, hovering uncomfortably between them. He keeps his eyes locked on hers, despite how they remain stuck to the ground as she rubs her hands around each other, again and again and again on an endless loop.

“...Yeah,” she finally answers, voice awfully soft.

With a sigh, she brings her eyes up, and they lock with Hordak’s. The air stills around them, waiting to be shattered in an instant like fragile broken glass, and all Hordak can do is notice the worrying crease between Entrapta’s brows and the way she keeps rubbing her hands around each other.

“I mean, they have been really nice to me lately,” she explains. “And they’re fun to be around. I really do like them, and I think they like me, too! But...Well…”

Her words trail off once more, and yet again, her gaze tumbles back to the ground.

“...Some part of me still can’t help but feel like I’m just...tolerated, in a way?”

Hordak’s heart sinks.

Tolerated?

He simply stares at her for a moment, the words pounding into him. What starts out as sadness, as a feeling of pure sorrow as he gazes upon Entrapta who appears so small, so dejected, suddenly bursts into hot white anger that burns throughout him. His brows furrow, hands clenching by his sides despite the stabs of pain it brings, and that anger deep within him begins to scorch his insides like a newly kindled fire beginning to roar.

Tolerated ? How could those fools simply *tolerate* her? She deserves to be *cherished* , to be-

"And maybe I'm wrong," she blurts out. "I mean, some of them went to Beast Island to look for me, after all. And like, I know you...you would've, and I-I understand not coming with everything going on with the war and since the portal was done and-"

Hordak's blood goes cold.

What?

"-So I'm glad they came, but-"

"Wait, wait, Entrapta," Hordak cuts in, words sharp. In a rising panic, his head pathetically attempts to wrap around her confusing words: 'Not coming with everything going on with the war'? 'Since the portal was done'? 'Would've looked after her'?

What is she talking about?

And as she rambles on, he can't help the concern that pours through him at the way her voice wavers, at the clear pain in her tone that she tries to mask by speaking so quickly. It's all so confusing, it all makes no sense, and Hordak simply gapes at her with a quirked brow and stuttering heart that begins to pound in rising panic.

"-And they talked to me on the island to help me when-"

"Entrapta, wait, what are you talking about?"

Entrapta freezes. She snaps her gaze up to look at him, and she then cocks her head to side innocently, her features expressing genuine confusion.

“Hm?” she asks. “What do you mean?”

“I mean, you mentioned something about how I didn’t come look after you because of everything going on with the war, and how the portal was finished,” he says, words slow and direct. “And how maybe *otherwise* I would’ve come.”

Entrapta doesn’t say anything at first, once again only staring at him with an unreadable expression. One tendril moves up to her mask, almost on instinct to prepare to pull it down, though it simply rests on the tip and rubs up and down on the surface.

“...Well, you know,” she says, her voice terribly meek. Her eyes dart away every few seconds as she continues, “You didn’t...You didn’t come. Which i-is okay! I understand! Everything was hectic and you had bigger plans with Prime and the war and-“

“ *What?”*

And that’s when it all clicks.

With a painful thud in Hordak’s stomach, it all clicks.

She doesn’t know that Catra lied to him about Beast Island.

She thinks he just left her there.

For a moment, Hordak only gapes at her, not knowing what else to possibly do. His heart pounds in his chest, the sound thundering in his ears louder and louder and louder. And that empty thud in his stomach warps into an awful nauseating pit of guilt, for all he can imagine is the utter betrayal Entrapta must’ve felt through all this, believing he had simply ignored her on Beast Island all that time and had never gone for her because the portal was done, and she was no longer useful to him.

Just like how everyone else treats her.

"Huh?" Entrapta says, peering at him. "I'm confused-"

"Did Catra never tell you?" Hordak spits out, voice desperate as panic bubbles more and more within him. "She never told you what happened?"

She quirks a brow. "...No?"

"Entrapta, she…" Hordak words trail off for a moment, his brain too jumbled and throat too tight to get words out quick enough. He swallows, continuing, "...She told me that you betrayed me for the Rebellion, and that's where you were instead of Beast Island. And...that's what I believed. This whole time, that's what I thought."

Entrapta's eyes widen further. Something pained crosses over her features, her jaw dropping and brows creasing further and ruby eyes glossing over with a shiny sheen of fresh tears. That one tendril of hair resting on the mask rubs faster against its surface, ready to flick it down in a moment though still hesitating.

"You...Catra...She lied? To you? You didn't just...leave me there?" she asks. Her unsteady voice cracks at the end, those tears in her eyes resting on the very edge, and that awful pit in Hordak's gut grows tighter.

She looks so pained, so *confused,* and the sight of it completely shatters him.

"Entrapta, of *course* not."

Her lips start to quiver, and those ruby irises in her eyes start to waver beneath the sheen of tears that threaten to spill. And just like that, the tendril of hair flips her mask down, and she turns her head away.

"Oh," she mumbles beneath the mask. "I...I didn't know. I mean, I really *did* understand why you wouldn't…wouldn't come-"

Her shoulders hunch up a bit as her words cut off, and once more, her hands start to fiddle with each other - each gloved hand rubbing around the other, again and again on an endless loop.

Her masked head turns to face his direction once more. And beneath those bugged eyes, Hordak knows that she's staring right at him.

"But...You really didn't know."

For a second, the world around them is completely still, and the air lays thick. Tension seems to cling to their clothes, making Hordak shift a bit in his spot as if he could wrestle away from it as well as the guilt that twists painfully within him. All the while, he stares at nothing but the mask, wishing desperately that he could see her expression beneath, yet knowing this makes her more comfortable and wanting only to respect her.

But oh, how he wishes he could see her face and wipe her tears away. How he wishes he could just do *something* to erase all those months of pain away. The guilt creeps up fast and faster within him, and his body tremblings under the rising wave of emotions, a lump forming in his throat and lips quivering if only a little.

He was such a fool. He was such a fool to believe Catra, and now Entrapta is dealing with the consequences.

And that *breaks* him.

"Entrapta," Hordak says, his words shaking against his will. It shatters the silence, and the tension clinging to them lessens. Just a bit. "Listen to me."

She perks up, bugged eyes pointed directly at him.

"If I had known you were in Beast Island, I *immediately* would've gone to get you. I would *never* leave you there," he says. His quivering voice is low and deep in sincerity, every bit of him wishing so *desperately* that he could express exactly how he feels

yet brain failing to figure out how to word everything. The lump in his throat grows tighter, and he swallows, willing it away. "And when I was finally made aware that you were on Beast Island after all that time, and that Catra lied to me, I..."

Entrapta waits in silence, body unmoving.

"...I attacked her," he says. Memories of that day flash into his brain - the utter anger that coursed through his veins, the pain and despair that seemed to swallow him whole as he imagined Entrapta on that cursed island, every part of him wishing to tear Catra apart - and his own gaze tumbles towards the ground. "I was enraged, and I didn't know how else to cope *except* to attack her. And to think of you on that island, and how you surely were dead-"

Hordak freezes mid-sentence, the rest of his words cut out from him. For all of a sudden, Entrapta's body is practically in his lap, her arms wrapped tightly around him and masked face pressed hard into his chest. Hordak glances down at her with wide eyes, his jaw dropped open in shock. She squeezes tighter, and he feels the slight vibrations of her shuddering body and the thudding of her racing heart against his stomach.

Warm pinpricks of tears form in the corners of his eyes, and that lump in his throat grows only tighter.

"I...wish I knew that before," is all she says, her words a whisper and barely audible beneath the mask. It cracks nonetheless, and her body trembles a bit harder against his own. Her fists bunch around the white material of the robe on his back, as if every part of her needs to hold on tighter, as if he would disappear if she let him go, and her lavender hair begins to wrap around them as well. Whether it was consciously done by her or not, Hordak will never know.

A beat goes by in his initial state of shock. He simply gapes down at her, blinking his tears away. Yet, they keep reforming, keep re-emerging against his will. And before long, they start to trail down

his cheeks. Hot and wet, they trek down his face, and every bubbling emotion within him seems to burst free with the tears.

The guilt, the pain, the loneliness, the fear, *everything.* All it took was this hug, all it took was the sensation of her around him, and it's as if every emotion is now exploding out of him. He bites his quivering lip, and finally, he responds with meek words that he tries to remain steady yet fails badly in doing so.

"...As do I. I'm...I'm so sorry, Entrapta. For everything."

At that, Hordak wraps his own arms around her small frame and embraces her back. It's a foriegn feeling - hugging someone, that is - but something akin to fondness blooms throughout his entire body. She's so warm, so soft in his arms, and her familiar scent of grease and metal and strawberry-scented shampoo in her hair all fill him with a deep sense of comfort that he's never experienced before.

Because she's here, she's safe, and that's all that Hordak could ever ask for.

Several long moments go by, and finally, the tears have run dry on his face and his nerves within him have settled. The same seems to be true for Entrapta, for gradually, she peels her body away and uses her hair to lift her out of his lap. She plops back on her previous spot before him, criss-crossed legs once more, and with a shaky tendril of hair, she lifts her mask up. Her cheeks are still damp and flushed, ruby eyes locked somewhere on the grass, though a small smile lifts the edges of her lips all the same.

"I don't normally like hugs that much," she says as she wipes her cheeks with the back of her hand. Her smile becomes shy, adding, "But, I...I think I like them with you. A lot, actually."

Hordak's heart stutters at her words.

Not in a bad way, he realizes.

She finally looks up at him, and her smile widens the moment their eyes lock - soft green colliding with watery violet. And all Hordak can think, amidst everything, is how lucky he is to see those sparkling eyes again after all that time that he believed he never would.

"I agree," he says without thinking. The words simply roll out of his tongue, unable to stop it; though, he can't help but find that they feel so...natural, and so very *true* as they're spoken . Not in any ways that he will ever understand. "I...enjoy them as well. With you, I mean."

She giggles softly, her eyes crinkling a bit in glee. His heart stutters once more at the sight, and Hordak is about to say something else when the faint pounding of footsteps cuts through the air, cutting off his train of thought. His ears snap up to hear better, and he glances over to the corner of the cliff that their little seating area is hidden behind.

And to his surprise, he finds the She-Ra - Adora, wasn't it? - rounding the corner. Her gaze roams around, seeming to be searching for something. For what, he isn't certain.

However, the moment her eyes find Hordak and Entrapta, she seems to light up. She starts to jog in their direction, and before long, she's mere feet away from them. She offers an amiable wave in greeting.

"Hey, we were wondering where you two ran off," she says. Her gaze darts between both of them, though she mainly directs her attention at Entrapta with the occasional glance at Hordak being nothing short of awkward and hesitant.

He really isn't surprised. Despite their little moment before where he set her free from Prime, and all seemed peaceful between them, he still was her - and the Rebellion's - biggest rival for the last few years, after all. He's well aware that all that tension isn't simply forgotten because of a shared minute of peace between them, and it would be foolish to believe otherwise.

Entrapta jumps up from her spot on the grass. “Oh, we were just catching up!”

“That’s...that’s good!” Adora answers. Hordak can’t help but notice the hesitant way she speaks, though he can’t quite understand why. “I’m glad you two are...Uh, reunited and all that. You know.”

Entrapta doesn’t seem to notice her hesitant way of speaking. She simply smiles at her, as genuine as ever.

Hordak stands up as well, positioning himself next to Entrapta. Now standing, he looms over Adora before him - in her She-Ra form, they’re similar in height, but not as her usual self.

“Well, um, anyways,” Adora says, still refusing to look up at him, “Glimmer is opening her kingdom for all the princesses to stay in - well, princesses and Bow and Micah and Swift Wind and Seahawk, of course. But, yeah, she wants us all to be there for the next several days while everything calms down from the war.”

Entrapta cocks her head to the side. “So...I’m supposed to be staying at Bright Moon? With you all?”

“Yeah, just so we can all figure out where to go from here to rebuild Etheria and all that. As princesses, it’s good to stay as a group to help the common people of Etheria. We’ve already set up camps for many of them, but like I said, Glimmer wants us all together for now.”

“That makes sense, yeah,” Entrapta says. “When are we going? Now?”

Adora nods. “Yeah. Everyone’s already heading there and-“

She stops.

For a brief moment, Hordak is confused why she suddenly stopped. But then, like a ton of bricks hitting him, realization dawns upon him. The air becomes tense around them, and all Hordak does is stare pointlessly at the ground before him.

Because Entrapta is supposed to go to Bright Moon.

And Entrapta is with Hordak.

And Hordak is obviously *not* supposed to go to Bright Moon.

"Adora?" Entrapta prods. breaking the silence.

Adora ignores her. Instead, for the first time since her arrival over here, she looks over at Hordak and maintains direct eye contact. No glancing away, no darting stares, none of that. She only looks at him, eyes wide and awkward smile dawned upon her lips.

"Uh, Lord Hor-...Hordak, um," she says, words subtly wavering, "You...Do you have anywhere? Um, to go?"

Hordak doesn't even have to question that. He knows the wretched state he left the Fright Zone - his only home - in from his fight with Catra. Beams fallen everywhere, rubble piles stacked high in every room, the walls blasted and crumbled to a pathetic nothingness.

In other words...Completely inhabitable.

"To be honest...No, I do not," Hordak says. He shifts side-to-side, and while he tries his hardest to maintain eye contact and remain stoic, his body shudders slightly with nerves. "I mean, I suppose I could find somewhere, or perhaps remain in those camps you mentioned, but-"

"Wait, no!"

At Entrapta's sudden words, Hordak snaps his mouth shut. And he and Adora both stare at Entrapta, brows raised.

"Hordak stays with me," she states. To Hordak's surprise, there's no question in her tone, no room for argument. It's spoken as a statement, all waver absent from her words. Strangely enough, Hordak can't help as a blossom of...warmth, it seems, wells within him at it. Why, he isn't certain.

Adora opens her mouth to speak, yet she quickly snaps it shut before any words get out. Her eyes dance back and forth between her and Hordak, biting her lip all the while in thought.

“I mean...Yeah, yeah! Of course,” Adora sputters, her tone a bit too enthusiastic than seems appropriate. “But, uh...I don’t know if Glimmer, or well, *any* of the others would...Well, you know…”

“Hordak will be with me when we’re there, so it’s not like he’s gonna do anything,” Entrapta rebuttals, and there it is again, that absolute rigidity to her words. She doesn't speak with any anger or harshness, only a clear-cut tone, and once again, Hordak can’t help the feeling of warmth at her words that continues to confuse him.

Adora looks away at the ground. Her brows furrow together, clearly deep in thought for a few moments, until she finally perks up and looks at the two of them.

“Um...Okay. Yeah. I have an idea. How about you guys come with me, and then we can talk more with Glimmer and the others?” she says with that awkward smile present on her lips once more. “Does that sound okay?”

Entrapta nods, seemingly satisfied. “Alright!”

At that, she looks up at Hordak with a soft smile. A strand of hair reaches up and rests on his shoulder, and the sensation of her soft hair sends sudden chills down his arm. He tries his best to ignore it, instead focusing on Entrapta below him.

“Don’t worry, I’m sure it’ll all work out!” she says, her smile brightening.

Hordak smiles as well - small though apparent all the same. Her joy truly is contagious, despite the inner voice that tells him otherwise and wishes only to think the worse.

That everything *won’t* work out.

“Well, we should probably get going! It’s going to be dark soon,” Adora says, breaking off Hordak’s downward spiral of thoughts before they even can start. That said, she turns on her heels and starts to walk away.

Entrapta’s hair then drops off his shoulder so she can follow behind Adora. Hordak begins to walk as well, his steps slow and careful from the dull pain that starts up again. Thankfully, his strides are large enough so that he’s able to keep up - though just barely - with Entrapta’s much smaller strides besides him.

At first, he tries to keep his gait perfectly even despite the faint throbbing, but as they continue on, Hordak feels Entrapta’s stare burning into him. He looks down, only to find her staring at him with a soft, knowing gaze. She slows down just a bit, while still keeping Adora in view for them to follow.

Hordak offers a small smile to her in gratitude. And as he looks down at her, in the golden light of the setting sun, he takes in the sight of her skin that glows and remains vibrant, her eyes that glimmer, and her wide smile that shines up at him despite everything. Something fond stirs within him - fondness that he can’t understand, can’t decipher, yet is pleasant regardless.

All he knows is that if she stays by his side, maybe everything will be okay.

At least, that’s what he hopes.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always super appreciated :)

(come say hi on tumblr! i’m beckkii over there!)

Debatable

Chapter Notes

> this chapter ended up being longer than planned, so i split it into 2! i'm still not finished the second part, though, so it won't be out for a little
>
> but anyways, man, i never realized how hard it is to write with more than 3 characters in a scene. so excuse any forgotten characters in this chapter! i tried my best to fit them all in :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The walk to Bright Moon is on foot, and it takes longer than Hordak would've hoped.

As they walk, the once-shining sun slowly sets on Etheria, basking the world in a dim golden haze. It still continues to sparkle with magic and life after all these hours, probably as an lingering after-effect of She-Ra's release of the stored magic within the Heart of Etheria.

However, despite its beauty, Hordak keeps his eyes on his feet, one foot after another, to try his best to ignore the dull pain that faintly aches in his muscles. Which, thankfully, isn't *too* debilitating. He would've preferred to take a rest every so often during their walk, but he can be content with staying silent and simply enduring it. Better that than calling attention to his one weakness.

Despite keeping his gaze on the ground most of the time, Hordak can't help but still notice some strange sense of...almost eeriness around them. While lots of natural destruction, such as that done in the Whispering Woods, was healed when She-Ra had set the magic of Etheria free, many towns are still left completely uninhabited, for their homes were destroyed and reduced to nothing but rubble. Hordak knows that the princesses had

provided their locals with camps to dwell in for the meantime, but the sights are still unsettling nonetheless.

A month ago, seeing towns in destruction would've filled him with pride. It would've made him feel almost honorable, in a sense. After all, complete destruction meant that Etheria was under his control, and that Prime would be more than proud of him upon his approaching arrival.

Now? Now, the sight of these empty towns leaves him feeling...Well, empty himself. A bit uncomfortable, if he's honest.

What good did destruction truly do?

Prime was never satisfied. After everything, after all of his efforts to control Etheria, Hordak could never please him, and he was never good enough. He never *will* be good enough. All of this destruction, all of this fear - and for what benefit? He's still a defect, a flawed clone, and he had terrorized all of the civilians in his efforts to change that, to be worthy of *something.* But he never will be, he will always be nothing to Prime and-

He shakes his head to himself, stopping those thoughts before they can take true root in his mind, before they grow and nourish into awful weeds that clog up his insides and ensnare him in nothing but lies.

Prime is gone. It's not worth dwelling on, despite how much his brain seems to scream otherwise, despite how much his brain wants to drag him back into a wallowing pit that never seems to want to leave him alone.

He shuts his eyes for a moment, and as if putting up a mental barrier in his mind, he blocks any and all thoughts relating to Prime away. They're still *there* , of course, hidden behind that mental barrier and aching almost painfully to invade his mind, but at least he's protected from them in this moment at least somewhat. Instead, he tries to focus on the sound of nature surrounding him, on the sound of his footsteps that thud against

the dirt ground, on the sound of Entrapta's faint humming beside him.

Better to simply not think about the past right now.

"Alright, looks like we're here!"

Hordak brings his gaze up at Adora's words. There, in the dim orange hue of the setting sun, is Bright Moon. Even from where they stand in the opening of the Whispering Woods, the kingdom's stature is large and clearly visible. The crystal water surrounding the structure laps and ripples gently in the faint wind, sparking with the last slivers of sunlight, and the smooth pearly walls glisten and shine. Even more visible is the one runestone that rests on a surface high up besides the kingdom.

"Wow, it's good that Bright Moon is still standing strong after everything," Entrapta comments.

Adora looks back at her and shrugs. "Prime didn't seem to have as much use for it. He was more focused on the civilians in their towns, and of course the Heart of Etheria."

At the mention of Prime, Adora snaps his gaze over to meet Hordak dead in the eyes. The air suddenly stills around them, and Hordak immediately tears his eyes away, her gaze burning into him and leaving him awfully uncomfortable. Whether her stare was meant to provide some sense of sympathy or to show anger, he isn't sure, but he honestly doesn't wish or care enough to know.

"Well, anyways, c'mon," she says, words stiff. "We should probably get up there since everyone's waiting and all."

Hordak brings his eyes back up in time to watch Adora as she turns around and starts to walk towards Bright Moon on the pathway. He and Entrapta silently follow, side-by-side, though it's not as if they really have any other choice than *to* follow her.

As they walk, Hordak dares to sneak a glance up at the entrance to Bright Moon. And sure enough, as Adora had said, people *are* waiting there. Hordak can't make out all of them, despite how much he tries to, though some of the princesses and a few others are clearly visible.

Hordak's gut twists at the sight. This is certainly *not* going to be easy.

"Hey, don't worry about them."

At Entrapta's sudden words, Hordak glances down at her. She looks up at him, her gaze soft and consoling, and she inches just a bit closer to him so that their bodies are almost touching as they walk. It's almost as if she had heard his thoughts, or perhaps she had seen him looking up at the princesses.

Whatever the reason, Hordak internally thanks her for her support. Outwardly, he offers a small smile, yet it's weak and grim. He's almost certain it isn't coming off as anything resembling happiness.

"They're nice people," Entrapta continues. "If we just talk to them, I'm sure they'll understand."

Hordak wants to point out that these are the same princesses that never seemed to understand Entrapta, but that wouldn't be helpful to say right now, would it?

They near the entrance, closer and closer, as they walk up the grande stairs. All the while, Hordak keeps his gaze stuck on his feet once more, unable to do anything else. And the nearer they get to the top, the more his heart starts to pound in his chest, the obnoxious noise rumbling in his ears. It begins to clog his thoughts and scatter them all away, leaving his mind bouncing and jittery and anything other than calm.

To be honest, some sensible part of him just can't help but feel how *ridiculous* this all is. These are the same princesses who Hordak could crush in a moment if he had his armor on, could

terrify if he so very pleased, could battle against and come out victorious despite being outnumbered-

“Hey, guys! Glad to see you all here!”

Hordak’s thoughts are swiftly cut off by Adora’s chipper greeting to the princesses. And with a final step, he makes it to the top of the staircase, now standing on the platform that beholds the entrance to Bright Moon. He takes one glance up and-

“Hey!”

A sudden strand of tough green material darts out towards him and wraps around his entire body, and in a blur, he’s hurtled towards the ground and grunting in agony as bursts of sharp pain shoot throughout his muscles and tremble within his nerves.

Hordak snaps his eyes open to orient himself, only to see the surface below him followed by several pairs of shoes and legs that stand before him. And before he can even try to move, several more tough strands wrap around every single inch of him, effectively pining him to the ground and sending more sharp stabs of pain throughout him.

In a startled and pained haze, he soon enough realizes that they seem to be vines which hold him in place - magical vines, sparkling with soft green particles of magic and dotted with small vibrantly-colored flowers.

“What’s he doing-!“

“Perfuma! It’s okay! He’s with us!”

Ignoring the pain as best as he can, Hordak turns his head up. There, he sees the princesses all standing before him, with Adora and Entrapta right by his side. Entrapta appears to have jumped closer to him on instinct, looking down at him with wide eyes and worry creasing between her brows, and Adora has stepped closer to the princesses, seeming to be conversing with one of them.

The one she appears to have been conversing with is wearing a long pink dress, and she has blond hair that's sprinkled with flowers and reaches all the way down to her waist. Her one hand is outstretched, and that's when Hordak sees how the fingers are turned upright, as if they're holding onto something. And amidst his confusion in pain, he realizes that *she's* the one holding him in this unmanageable tangle of vines.

The princess - Perfuma, was it? - looks down at Hordak, one brow quirked up in question. Her hand lowers just a bit, though the vines remain wrapped around Hordak, despite how much he grunts and struggles to get out. It really is no use - pain is steadily creeping up on his already sore muscles, and it's not getting any better.

"...With...us?" she questions, looking back up at Adora. "What're you talking about?"

"Okay, okay, I know what you're thinking," Adora begins, and once more, there's that awkward and frantic smile on her lips. "But you told me to get Entrapta, and he was with her, so-"

"No way. There's *no way* I'm hearing you right."

Another voice emerges, and a new princess steps out of the group. Her hair is blue and drapes down her one shoulder, and her clothing is colored a teal hue. The main thing, Hordak notices, is the bitterness clear on her expression. Her brows are furrowed together, a deep frown set on her lips, and her chocolate eyes almost seem to burn with disapproval.

Hordak studies her a second longer, and that's when it clicks - this is the princess of Salineas, isn't it?

The kingdom he last recalls very clearly burning down to rubble.

"We told you to get *Entrapta* ," she bites out. A finger darts out to jab at Hordak on the ground, adding, " *Not* him."

Adora offers a smile again, though fear shines clearly in her eyes. "Okay, well, like I said, Entrapta was with him, so-"

"I don't care! He's not welcome here, whether he's got some weird friend thing going on with Entrapta or not." She sucks in a breath, fists clenching by her side, before she turns around to face the whole group of princesses and others silently standing around them. "Am I, like, crazy for saying this or something? Isn't this just common sense?"

"No, no, trust me, I get where you're coming from," Adora begins. "But I didn't know what to do when he was with her and-"

"Entrapta, listen."

Yet another voice emerges from the group of princesses, and she steps out of the crowd. The princesses - actually, Hordak vaguely recognizes this one. It's the queen, not princess, of Bright Moon. Her gaze is stern, and her fist is tight around the staff she holds upright by her side.

Hordak then catches sight of Entrapta, who's still standing close by his side and almost half-shielding him, as she glances up at the queen at the call of her name.

"I sent Adora out to get *you* , since we need all of the princesses together in this time of crisis," the queen says, each word even and steady. She appears to be on the younger side, but Hordak can't deny the clear authority that rings out in her tone. "I know you and him seem to be...uh, friends, now, but he isn't meant to be here. He's not welcome."

Entrapta looks down for a second, brows furrowed tightly together, and Hordak can practically hear the gears turning in her mind. Within seconds, however, her head snaps back up, and she points at a random person - a younger man, it seems - amidst the group.

"Okay, well, if you're only rounding up the princesses, then why is Seahawk here?"

A groan rings out in the group, loud and drawn out. Hordak looks over at the source and realizes, not with much surprise, that it's coming from the same princesses of Salineas.

"Because *Seahawk* is one of us," the princesses spits out. She stomps forward until she is hovering right over Hordak and right in front of Entrapta, adding, "And he's with *me* ."

Entrapta waves a hand in Hordak's direction, saying, "Well, Hordak's with *me* , so-"

"Entrapta! You're missing the point!"

For the first time since their arrival, Entrapta shrinks back a bit in shame, and something in Hordak's heart shatters at the sight. Seemingly on instinct, he struggles once more in the vines, grunting as pain already begins to grow and pulse in his muscles. However, through his meek attempts, the vines only become tighter.

" *Seahawk* didn't do crimes. *Seahawk* didn't hurt people. *Seahawk* wasn't the guy that we've been after for the past three whole years."

With each sentence the princess barks out, the closer she inches towards Entrapta, and the more Entrapta shrinks back. Her features cross with something full of guilt, and all Hordak can do is watch in a helpless fury from the ground like the pathetic failure he is.

" *Seahawk* ," the princess adds, one finger jabbed into Entrapta's chest, "didn't destroy my home!"

"Wait, wait, that's not fair."

Everyone goes silent at the sound of a new voice emerging within the group. Hordak's ears perk up at the sound, and his heart stutters to a sudden stop - he *knows* that voice. He knows it all too well, and something within him churns at the sound of it. And

before his mind can even register who it is, the owner of the voice steps out of the crowd.

Catra.

And all Hordak can do is stare at her in shock, jaw dropped open slightly and eyes wide. At the very sight of her, some lingering part of him sparks with a surge of bitterness, yet some other part of him finds him immediately grateful for her swift interjection.

And every single part of him remains simply *confused* on why she's doing so.

"I was also a part of that mission to destroy Salineas, you know," she says. "A big part of it, actually. And you don't see me tied down on the ground with Perfuma's vines, do you?"

" *Catra,* " Adora mutters with tight lips, "Are you trying to get yourself in trouble here?"

Catra swiftly raises both hands up in defense. "No, I'm just saying! Now that the war is over and we're trying to, you know, *fix* everything, we have to be fair here - if we're not trusting Hordak because of his crimes, then you also can't trust me, Scorpia, Entrapta-"

"This is *different,* " the sea princesses groans, turning a sharp heel to face Catra. Despite that, Catra doesn't even shrink back - she stares straight forward at her, eyes narrowed and cold as ice all the same.

"Listen, I really do understand you guys," Catra says, "And don't get me wrong, I don't like Hordak either. At all, actually. But, I'm not gonna lie and say you guys are being reasonable here. The war is over, and I think we'd be better off trying to *fix* things than punish certain people who clearly aren't a threat anymore."

At that, for a split second, Catra looks down at Hordak with an unreadable expression.

And all Hordak can do is stare back, not moving a muscle and not knowing how to feel about all this.

Why is she defending him?

"Are you *serious* ?" the sea princess spits out, fists clenched by her sides, "You're making no sense! 'Clearly not a threat anymore'? How is he not a threat? For all we know, if we let him into Bright Moon with Entrapta, he could kill all of us in our sleep for his own benefit and-"

"Okay, okay, *everyone* . Calm down."

The crowd of people falls silent and turns to stare at the sound of the queen's voice. She strides forward until she's standing right before Hordak, and for the first time since his arrival here, she makes eye contact with him and addresses him directly.

"Hordak, we have camps set up for the civilians, but we also have some monitored ones for all of the clones," she says. "We can put you there to stay until further noti-"

"No!"

Hordak glances up in shock at a shout coming from Entrapta who, for the most part, had been silent since the sea princesses' initial attack on her. Everyone's attention darts to her as well, their eyes wide and expressions a bit taken aback at her sudden interjection.

"If Hordak isn't staying with me at Bright Moon," she says, tone fallen back into something more even, "then I'm not staying here, either."

The sea princesses groans once more - is that the only sound she's capable of making?

" *Entrapta* , we *need* you here though," she explains. "All the princesses have to work together right now. You can't just run away and abandon us again to be with your weird new friend or whatever-"

Entrapta's brow furrows together. "I'm not-"

"Okay, you know what?" the queen cuts in, stopping their little quarrel short, "Fine!"

The queen walks up to Entrapta, and with her staff held firmly beside her, she takes proud and rigid strides towards her. While she walks, an archer boy reaches out to her as if to stop her, muttering, "Wait, Glimmer, what're you-"

"You," the queen loudly states as she stops before Entrapta, pointing at her, "are allowed to have Hordak stay in Bright Moon. However, there are some conditions to be made. You are entirely responsible for him, and you are to monitor him and make sure he's kept in line. And if he does *anything* , anything at all that could be deemed suspicious or harmful by any of the princesses, you are equally responsible. Any punishment or call to action made on him will then fall onto you, as well. Understood?"

Entrapta immediately lights up at the queen's words, and she nods eagerly without any hesitation. "Yup! Understood!"

"What? Are you serious?" the sea princess shouts. "Glimmer, you can't be serious."

The other princess - the one who still has Hordak tied up in vines - nods in agreement, cautiously glancing between the queen and the sea princesses. "Yeah, I'm with Mermista on this one. You aren't being logical, Glimmer."

A new princess - one who seems the youngest out of all of them, given her short stature - nods as well, her blue bob shaking at the motion. Also seen amidst the group is Force Captain Scorpia-...Well, *Scorpia* , that is. However, oddly enough, she isn't nodding along. Her gaze simply darts between Hordak's and the other princesses, her claws tapping nervously together.

"Listen, everyone, we're going to put him on trial soon," the queen says, turning around to face all of the princesses. "I'm not just going to let him have free will or anything like that. In a few days

time, here in Bright Moon, he'll be charged appropriately for his crimes. But, until then, this is the only way to keep all princesses together, and I trust Entrapta to watch over him and be held responsible for him."

"Really?" the sea princess says, a hand on her hip, "Because I don't. She'll probably lie to save his skin if he tries something. Shouldn't we have someone like me or Perfuma or Frosta watch over him instead, since we'll actually be *fair*-"

"Mermista, my decision is final. You can agree or disagree, but as queen, I say what goes."

"Glimmer, c'mon," the archer boy from before cuts in, swiftly walking up to the queen. He wraps both his hands around her shoulders, saying, "I want the princesses all together right now, too, and I know letting Hordak be here for Entrapta is the best way to do that. But-"

"Bow, just trust me!" she shouts back. "He'll be on trial as soon as possible like I said. And...And I think Catra also has a point. About being fair. Because I was also *there* in the Galactic Horde, and I *know* what it's like with Prime and...and I just…"

She shakes her head, eyes tumbling to the ground. "...Just, nevermind. It doesn't matter. I'm making the decision to allow him into Bright Moon until his trial, so I think it'd be best if we just all go inside for now, let Entrapta keep watch over him, and leave it at that. Alright? It's getting dark, and I think everyone would rather just head in right now."

The air goes silent around them. Nobody moves a muscle.

"Then it's settled. Perfuma, release him from his vines, and Entrapta, you stay close by his side."

At that, the queen whips around and heads through the double door.

“I can’t believe this…” the sea princess mutters before turning around as well, heading through the double doors and the rest of the crowd trailing in behind her.

However, the one princess - Perfuma? - glances down at Hordak with wide eyes, one hand waving upwards though clearly hesitating. In the end, she sucks in a breath, flicks her wrist, and finally, the vines all fall away around him as if they were never even there in the first place. The immense pressure around his body releases him, and he groans at the immediate pain that scorches throughout his body at the sensation. Though, after a second passes, thankfully enough, it begins to subside and become only a faint pulsing feeling.

Immediately, Entrapta drops down by his side on the ground. He turns to look at her, only to find her ruby eyes wide and worried as they peer at Hordak. One strand of hair loops over his shoulder in a consoling gesture, and something warm bursts into Hordak’s heart at the sensation.

“Are you okay?” she asks, words soft. “The vines didn’t hurt you, did they?”

“...Somewhat, but I am fine, Entrapta.”

She offers a small smile then, yet it falls a bit flat, and it fails to reach her eyes. Hordak doesn’t blame her - that whole past conversation could’ve gone better. And while they were granted what they wanted, everything still seems awfully...grim, somehow.

Hordak isn’t surprised. And he doesn't blame the princesses at all for their feelings on everything. In fact, he honestly expected more backlash from them.

He knows he deserves it.

Deep down, he knows he deserves it and much, much worse.

And there’s that mental barrier in his brain, the one he had used earlier on his walk here to hide himself away from his ensnaring

thoughts like the foolish coward he is, already beginning to chip away against his will and prepare to crumble into nothingness.

Not that he's surprised. It was a feeble attempt to ignore things, wasn't it?

"Are you two...uh, ready to go in?"

Hordak and Entrapta both look up to find Adora standing before them, along with Catra close by her side. Hordak dares to steal a glance at Catra, though she appears to be purposely avoiding his gaze by staring at a random spot on the ground.

"Yup!" Entrapta says as she swiftly stands up. She offers a thick rope of hair to Hordak, and he wraps his hand around it gently. With her help, he's hoisted up and off the ground in seconds.

Now standing, he tries his best to ignore the sudden throbbing wave of pain that doubles over throughout his body. It's better to just not think about it.

"Alright, follow me!"

With that said, Adora and Catra turn around and start to head through the double doors. And right on their tails, Hordak and Entrapta follow.

Chapter End Notes

> you know, when i was writing this, part of me was thinking "well they would never allow hordak into bright moon in real life if this was the aftermath of a real war," but then i remembered that this is a cartoon about magical princesses where the largest kingdom doesn't even have a prison. so, just roll with it ;)
>
> anyways, thanks for reading! kudos and comments are always super appreciated! and come say hi on tumblr - i'm beckkii over there :)

Uncertainty

Chapter Notes

> i'm back with a new chapter! i really liked writing this one, and i hope i did justice. there's just so many aspects to explore in post canon immediately following the end of she ra, and there's some that i really want to touch on involving certain characters and their dynamics with each other.
>
> i hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bright Moon is grandeur and awfully sparkly for Hordak's taste, even in the dim light provided by the streaming moonlight through the windows, though he honestly expected as much from such a place. Various rooms and hallways litter around every single corner, seeming to be never-ending. And to be truthful, it's a bit overwhelming. His last home - if he could even call it that - was the Fright Zone, and it's design was made to be more simple and practical. But here, Hordak bets that half of these rooms aren't even inhabited and are simply there to show off wealth and the ability to afford luxurious decorations.

By the time Hordak and Entrapta have entered, all of the princesses and others seem to have already congregated into their own rooms, leaving the hallways thankfully empty as they walk through them. Adora (since Catra slipped away to her own room at one point, gone unnoticed) leads Hordak and Entrapta to their room. Though, despite how Entrapta is supposed to watch over Hordak, she first asks if they'd prefer to be in their own separate rooms if that would make them more comfortable.

Entrapta immediately denies without any hesitation. And for a moment, Hordak simply stares at her, strange feelings rippling through him at her quick response. They appear to be both fondness and...nerves, perhaps? Anticipation? He doesn't know

why. They're only sharing a room because Entrapta has to monitor him - it's only for logical purposes, and nothing more.

Hordak shakes his head to himself. Why is he making things more complicated than they have to be?

"Okay, you should be all set," Adora says at the entrance of their room. Entrapta and Hordak file in, though she hangs by the door, holding onto the handles as she adds, "Just come see me or Glimmer if you need anything, okay?"

With that said, she shuts the door behind her, and the room falls dark and silent.

Entrapta clicks on a nearby light with a tendril of hair, flooding the place with light, and Hordak blinks in shock as he takes it all in. For starters, it's just as sparkly as the rest of the palace, and it's larger than he expected. The room is a bit bare, probably due to being a guest room, though it's got all of the necessities and more. There's towering dressers probably stocked with spare clothes, a overly-fluffy rug on the floor, bright overhead lights, a built-in master bathroom off to the side, and a king-sized bed in the center with a canopy overhe-

Wait.

Hordak stares at the bed in the center.

There's only one.

And there's two people here.

Entrapta, who's wandering around the room on her pigtails and taking everything in, doesn't seem to notice their little predicament. In fact, she finishes her quick tour by flopping on the bed, her body in a starfish position and hair sprawled out around her. She shuts her eyes and sighs.

"It's weird," she says, pausing midway to yawn, "It's not even that late, but I'm just so *tired* ."

After a beat passes, she blinks open one eye half-way to look at Hordak, adding, "Are you? I mean, you've had a longer day than me and…"

She trails off, a sudden realization seeming to wash over her. She quickly blinks both eyes open and sits straight up, beginning to survey the room that bares only one bed and biting her lip all the while.

"...Oh," she says. "That's...a problem."

Hordak shifts a bit in place. He's not sure what to add onto that, if there even *is* anything to add.

All of a sudden, Entrapta uses her pigtails to jump straight up, standing once more. She looks up at Hordak with her hands planted firmly on her hips and shrugs.

"Well, that's okay! You take the bed."

Hordak immediately frowns. "What? Entrapta, you can not-"

"It's alright," she says, shrugging once more. "I can sleep practically anywhere. And I can use my hair for comfort. It's really no big deal. Honestly, I used to do it all the time at Dryl if I was working in my lab overnight. I'm used to it."

"Entrapta, I'm not making you do that. You deserve the bed."

"No, *you* do. I'm fine on the floor."

"No, that couldn't possibly be comfortable for you."

"Then it wouldn't be comfortable for *you* either."

"It would be fine for me-"

"Hordak, I'm not making you-"

"How about this?" Hordak cuts her off. "You sleep on the bed, but if it makes you feel better about it, I will...go find Adora or the

queen to see if they have a mat of some sort so that remaining on the floor is still comfortable for me. Will that suffice?”

Entrapta looks to the side and taps her chin for a moment, appearing doubtful as she ponders it. “Uh…I don’t know…”

“As a clone, I am even more used to sleeping upright in a pod. This will be more than enough to suffice for me,” Hordak adds.

He doesn't, however, add that his body is currently aching and will certainly not benefit from sleeping on the floor due to the pain relief medication that continues to wear off. She doesn’t need to be made aware of that.

Finally, she throws her hands up in the air and turns on her heels to head back towards the bed.

“Alright, alright, fine. But-“ she cuts off, swiveling around to meet Hordak’s gaze, “-When you come back, and you change your mind, I’ll be more than happy to switch places with you. Actually, I’ll be *happier* to switch places with you. Okay?”

“Okay. Fair enough.”

At that, she hops back on the bed with the use of her pigtails and crawls underneath the large covers and blankets. She then takes her mask off her head and rests it on the ground besides the bed as if preparing to go to sleep; however, after all of this, she remains sitting upright and turns to stare at Hordak.

“I’ll stay awake for you so we can switch places when you get back,” she says.

“ *If* we switch places when I get back,” Hordak adds, offering a small smile.

Entrapta rolls her eyes, though the hint of an amused smile appears on her lips as well.

"Okay, okay. Fine. Alright. *If* we switch spaces when you get back."

That said, after tossing her one more soft smile, Hordak heads to the bedroom door. He flicks off the light switch, opens the door, though he hesitates in the doorway for a moment as he turns around to catch one last look at Entrapta. She's fully snuggling under the covers now, trying to get comfortable though seeming to be frustrated at the sheer fluffiness of the pillow as she attempts to flatten in.

Hordak stares for a moment. And as he stares, he realizes that he had never seen her without her mask on. Her head seems much more round and small now, and the lavender hair tufts atop her head are a scuffled mess.

The sight is...endearing, in a way, that he can't understand.

He watches her a little longer than he should before he turns around and finally exits the room.

~~~

As soft as he can help, the door shuts behind him, careful to make little noise in the otherwise silent palace. He takes one step to the left of the hallway, and immediately, he wishes he had asked Entrapta to come along with him.

Because heading through this foreign place alone, one that's full of people who all despise him and would prefer to have him punished or even possibly dead, is probably the *last* thing he'd like to be doing right now.

Oh well. No turning back now, is there?

With careful steps, Hordak blindly walks through the hallways and rounds the corners, using the faint moonlight to guide him. His ears perk up at every sound, though it always seems to be a simple creak on the floor, or the faraway whispering of people in their assigned rooms. Despite this, he remains alert, his eyes

darting every which way to make sure he's undetected. The last thing he'd like to do is run into one of the princesses from before.

Though, he *is* on the lookout for either Adora or the queen so he can ask them for what he needs.

He continues walking, and after a few minutes, he realizes that isn't certain if he'd be able to find his way back if he tried. The hallways are a maze, and he seems to have find himself completely lost amidst them. He takes a moment to freeze in place and recollect his whereabouts, gaze wandering around to study this hallway and decide if he had already been here before-

"Hordak?"

His ears flick up, and every nerve within him stutters in place. He whips around in a panic, though as his eyes land on the queen and Adora at the other end of the hallway, his nerves settle. Only somewhat, though. He still has to remain on his guard around them.

"Do you...need something?" the queen asks, taking a few cautious steps forward. She no longer wields her staff, and now her one hand clenches again and again by her side on what appears to be a reflex. "You look kinda...uh, lost."

"Oh, I…" he pauses to clear his throat and attempt to stand taller, though a wave of pain doubles throughout his shoulders that he tries to ignore. He takes a few steps forward to close most of the distance between them before adding, "...I, uh, need some sort of...mat, if you have one. As in, something to sleep on."

"A mat? But every guest room has a king-sized bed for two...Ohhh, right, right," she says, eyes widening in understanding. "I get it."

Hordak shifts side-to-side once more, not knowing how to respond.

“Yeah, yeah, okay. I’m pretty sure we have some sleeping bags in storage,” she says, nodding. She offers a smile at him, yet it’s clearly strained and somewhat awkward. Why is almost every interaction he’s had today with the Rebellion so painfully awkward? “We’ll, uh, yeah. We’ll go get one for you.”

At that, Adora and the queen stiffly trek past him, clearly avoiding eye contact and staring straight ahead as they walk down the rest of the hallway. They round a corner, though before they fully disappear, Hordak picks up the sound of light laughter.

“Adora, what? What's so funny?”

“It’s nothing, it’s just…” Another round of snickering cuts her words off. “I just never thought there’d be a day I’d be getting a sleeping bag for Hordak.”

On instinct, Hordak’s ears flick down in shame. And as he watches them finally round the corner, he’s thankful they can’t see his face any longer, for a familiar warmth is felt spreading across it - one that he can’t suppress, try as he might to do so.

He grumbles a bit to himself at his sudden frailty and leans his fatigued body against the wall. Honestly, he doesn't know why he’s embarrassed at what these princesses think of him. If anything, he should be embarrassed *for* them - after all, they *did* just leave him standing alone in the hallway without anyone watching over him, despite how it was clearly expressed that he’s put on some sort of watch. This place certainly isn’t running a tight ship, is it?

And Hordak is starting to wonder just *how* the Horde was possibly losing to this feeble Rebellion when the sound of footsteps rings throughout the hallway, jarring him out of his thoughts.

He snaps his head to the side in the direction of the sound, curious while equally worried who could be here. However, when his eyes locate the source, standing dead center in the hallway

with a wide gaze that locks with Hordak's, his blood freezes in his veins.

Catra.

Today surely is Hordak's lucky day, isn't it?

"Uh," Catra says, her gaze immediately dropping to the floor, "Do you, um, know where Adora went?"

Hordak tears his eyes away as well, looking out the window on the wall across him and pointlessly studying the stars as some sort of distraction. It isn't working out too well.

"She went with the queen to get me, uh...something. That I needed. For the night. They're just around the corner."

A beat passes in silence.

"Oh. Okay."

The sound of her footsteps starts up again, and Hordak keeps his gaze locked out the window, certain she's walking through the rest of the hallway to go find Adora. He keeps his gaze even, waiting for her figure to pass by before him on her way.

Except, it never appears.

She moves to lean on the same wall as Hordak, albeit several feet apart, where she looks pointlessly at some spot at the floor before her.

"I'll just, uh, wait here for her then, I guess."

Hordak opens his mouth to speak, though no words come out. He simply stares for a moment, wide eyed, at the person beside him. The person who he honestly doesn't know how to feel about right now.

Partly because what happened in the long past during the war and what *just* happened with the princesses are creating two warped images of her to him - one that's manipulative and bitter, and one that's kind and considerate.

What is he *possibly* supposed to say to her?

He finally tears his gaze away and looks at the floor, his head spinning. Deep down, he knows that he should probably express his gratitude to her for defending him earlier. After all, without her input, Hordak might be on his merry way to some camp surrounded by clones that may or may hate him, depending on how they feel about his betrayal towards Prime. Even worse…

He'd be without Entrapta.

Hordak knows that the princesses would never let her go to the camp with him if he was exiled there. Sure, she'd protest it, but chances are, the queen would order her to stay.

Simply put, he would've been separated from her yet again.

That is, if it wasn't for Catra's input.

But...then again…

Catra was the one who separated them in the first place, was she not? She lied to him and sent Entrapta away, and Hordak just can't *forget* that, try as he might to leave the past behind him, try as he might to just live in the *now* and know that he's thankfully here by Entrapta's side once again.

Some of him still flickers with a sense of burning bitterness for what Catra had done, and it continues to kindle within him like a fanned flame, stronger and stronger and hotter and hotter. He can't find himself to smolder it, despite how she had just helped him.

And all Hordak can do is stand there, not knowing what to say. Does he bring up the past? Does he instead just say thank you for

now? Does he remain silent? His mind spins with thoughts and questions on what to say, what to do, *how to handle this.*

However, out of the blue, some stored away part of him recalls earlier today involving his talk with Entrapta. Involving learning that Catra had never even told her the truth, leaving Entrapta oblivious to everything and feeling so *abandoned* for *so* long. And before he can even stop himself, those bitter words that have been stuck in his mind since that moment are now spewing from his mouth in a harsh tone.

"You never told Entrapta the truth about Beast Island."

"Huh?" Catra says.

Hordak keeps his eyes planted forward, clenching his fists by his side. "I *mean* , you never told her that I was unaware of her being sent there. She thought all this time that I had left her to die, and that I knew but simply never cared enough to go, all because you never explained it to her even after spending so much time with her for the past several days."

This certainly wasn't the topic Hordak wanted to talk about, but now that the fire within him has been set free, it doesn't look as if it'll be put out anytime soon.

"...I never had the chance to," Catra mumbles, and out of the corner of his eye, Hordak catches sight of her shrinking a bit in on herself, arms crossed over her chest and tail swishing around her.

Hordak furrows his brow, and before he can stop himself, he whips his body around to face and tower over her.

"'Never had the chance to'?" Hordak barks out, fists clenched harder by the side. The fire burns, hotter and hotter and fizzling away any reasoning and sensibility left in his mind, but he just can't *stop* it.

Catra shrinks even further in on herself, if that were even possible, and her eyes remain staring emptily at the floor.

“You had all that time together, and you’re saying you never had the chance to?” Hordak continues, voice raising louder and louder. It echoes off the walls, suffocating them in the noise. “Entrapta always believed that no one cared, that everyone always left her behind, and you just *let* her continue to believe-!”

“I apologized to her for sending her there, okay?” Catra yells back, swiftly cutting him off, as she finally whips around to face him head on. Catra’s eyes burn into Hordak’s as she stares daggers up at him, and they never break away, never back down. The air stiffens around them, the tension clinging to their clothes, as her yell echoes off the walls.

“And…” Catra says, her voice softening if only a bit, “...she forgave me, for what that’s worth.”

Hordak’s eyes fall to the floor, and some of the pent of fire within him smothers away. He relaxes his hands by his sides, allowing the pent-up tension within his muscles to release somewhat..

“After apologizing, some part of me just didn’t want to bring up that whole incident anymore at all,” Catra says. Her eyes continue to burn into Hordak, but he doesn't stare back, simply allowing her to talk instead. “I probably should’ve told her, about how I lied to you and that you were unaware, but...I didn’t know if Beast Island was a sensitive subject for her or anything. She was there for so long, and I...I just didn’t know if it was worth bringing up. And honestly, with all that was going on with the war and you possibly being stuck under Prime’s control forever, I wasn’t sure if telling her would make her feel better about everything.”

Hordak remains silent for a moment, not knowing what to say or if he’s even *supposed* to say anything. In the end, however, he finally answers in a low tone.

“I...suppose I can understand, in a way,” he manages to get out. He brings his cold gaze up to lock with Catra’s, adding, “Though, I still believe you should have just told her.”

Catra gives a weak shrug. “Yeah, I know. I feel bad about that now, but there’s nothing I can do to fix it, is there?”

They both fall silent then, once more leaning against the walls and staring at nothing. Thankfully, the suffocating tension between them seems to have settled, if only a little. Some nagging part of Hordak’s brain tells him that now could be a possible time to mention before, about how she stood up for him, but the other part of him wishes only to remain silent and not have to converse with her anymore.

Hordak gives a little shake of his head, for the former part of him wins out.

“I do...appreciate...for you speaking up on my behalf earlier. With the princesses.”

Hordak feels Catra’s sudden stare on his face, and suddenly, he wishes he hadn’t said anything at all. He turns his head away, though his ears fall flat in shame against his will.

“Uh, yeah. Don’t, uh, don’t mention it,” Catra says, words hesitant. “It just...I don’t know. What the princesses were saying, just...I guess it felt kinda unfair to me, is all.”

Hordak turns his head to meet her gaze, and the world seems to still around them.

“I was in the Velvet Glove too, you know,” Catra says, voice meek and low. “It's different to actually...be there, in that place, than just being chipped. I know some of these princesses who were chipped on Etheria might say that it wasn’t that bad, or that Prime wasn’t that big of a deal, but…”

She tears her eyes away, looking to the ground as she begins to ring her hands together.

“Actually *being* there, in Prime’s presence and surrounded by all those helpless clones, always being watched because he was

literally *everywhere* , and then being forced to go into that pool of-"

At that, her words cut off, and she shuts her eyes for a moment. But Hordak doesn't need her to finish. He already knows what she's referring to.

He's been through it multiple times.

The cleansing ceremony had more than enough purposes, and he had gone through it in several circumstances over the years to achieve them all. To be punished, to be restored again to some distorted view of perfection, to be free of all of the pain he had suffered through prior. But every time, there was *always* an ultimate goal to it. To be right again with Prime as something that was as important as daily nourishment, and to be *pure.*

But he could never truly achieve it, could he?

"And that's what feels so *unfair* to me," Catra says, her eyes snapping open once more and meeting Hordak's. Her gaze now holds some kind of fierceness to them, her cat-like pupils sharp, thin slivers. "The princesses want to just round all these clones up in camps like animals, as if they haven't been through enough with Prime, and then they want to do the same to *you,* and it just feels so...wrong. And I think Glimmer understands that, too. That's why she let you in when everyone else said not to."

Hordak opens his mouth to speak. Only, he can't figure out what to say, or even *how* to say it.

Catra's gaze goes soft, once more tumbling to the ground. "I was lucky I had Adora after everything. And Adora's friends, too. They were all so *nice* , even when I didn't deserve it, and they warmed up me so quickly. And now, that's why I'm accepted here. It wasn't a question to punish me for my crimes like it was with you, you know?"

Hordak swallows. "...I do."

“And I know you have Entrapta to try to vouch for you, but...She’s not really as accepted around the princesses,” Catra says. “So, her input doesn’t have as much weight as, say, Adora’s does.”

“I’m well aware of that,” Hordak says, his voice turning sour against his will. Talk of Entrapta’s mistreatment amongst the other princesses never fails to strike a painful chord with him.

Catra looks up then. However, despite her confidence in her gaze, her hands continue to wring, around and around and around each other. Whether it’s a nervous tic or simply a habit, Hordak isn’t certain, but something tells him it’s the former.

“I know we both...did things we regret. In the past,” she says, voice low. “But, I want you to know that I...understand, I guess. You know. With what you’re going through and everything.”

Hordak’s ears fall, eyes widening. At first, he doesn’t know what to say. Every part of him is conflicted on how to feel, how to react, what to say, what to do. A few hours ago, he never would’ve expected he’d be conversing with Catra in a way that’s even *remotely* civil, yet here he is.

In the end, he simply offers a weak nod.

“I...appreciate that.”

And Catra is just about to answer when approaching voices echo from around the corner, stopping her in her tracks.

“Adora! If you drop it, it’s gonna get all dusty from the floor and-“

“Glimmer, let go, I’ve got it, okay-“

Hordak’s ears perk up. He and Catra whip around to face the end of the hallway, and within seconds, Adora and the queen appear as they round the corner. Adora seems to be struggling with a bundle of something in her hands - it keeps slipping out from her grasp, near to toppling to the floor - and the queen, on the other

hand, seems to be trying to help her, reaching out and grabbing at the bundle to stop Adora from dropping it.

Finally, once they are only a few feet before Hordak and Catra, Adora gets a strong hold on the bundle and grips it snug and firm in her arms. She looks up, though immediately, her eyes dart towards Catra and brighten up.

"Oh, hey, Catra! Did you need something?"

"Nah, I just got bored in our room," Catra says. Her eyes become something soft, a fond smile grazing her lips, and Hordak can't help but feel as if he had never truly seen her smile like that before. She shrugs, adding, "So, I went looking for you."

"Oh, yeah, me and Glimmer were just doing the rounds to make sure everyone was okay. And…" She pauses to gesture at Hordak, "...We got caught up looking for something for him."

At that, she walks up to him and offers out the large bundle in her arms. Hordak narrows his eyes, studying it for a second. It's black and appears soft, though it's not a blanket. It's…?

"Here's a sleeping bag," Adora says, noticing Hordak's hesitation. "It's warm and soft on the inside, and there's even a built in mat-thing that provides some support to mimic a real bed. And this is a new one, so it hasn't been used yet."

Hordak takes the bundle - sleeping bag? - and holds it in his arms. He quirks a brow, peering at it even closer. It looks comfortable enough, not that he would complain himself. He's honestly more worried that *Entrapta* would be upset about it if it wasn't comfortable and would force them to switch places for the night.

"Thank you," Hordak finally says, looking down at the queen and Adora while offering them a curt nod. "This will suffice."

"Yeah, uh, no problem," the queen says, shifting side-to-side. To be honest, despite her attempts at politeness, she looks as if she

would rather be *anywhere else* right now than standing in front of Hordak.

Not that he, either, is enjoying standing around his two former enemies and former second-in-command that he still doesn't know how to feel about. Especially at this hour. Well, it's not that late, per sé, but the entire kingdom is dark and silent save for the faint moonlight, and Hordak would much prefer being in his room with Entrapta right now than out in the hallways of some unfamiliar kingdom that once was enemy territory.

In the end, Hordak offers another stiff nod as he starts to turn on his heels. "I should...go back to my room. Goodnight."

Before he fully turns around, he catches sight of Adora offering an awkward smile paired with a soft "goodnight" as Catra studies the ground once more. The queen, as well, seems equally as uncomfortable with this entire interaction.

Not that he blames them.

After all, never in a million years did he think he would find himself borrowing a sleeping bag from the queen of Bright Moon. But here he is, borrowing a sleeping bag from the queen of Bright Moon.

Hordak sighs to himself as he walks through the hallway towards his bedroom, trying to figure out which way to go to get back. And all he silently prays to himself is that maybe he'll be lucky enough to never have to leave that bedroom again.

It's not his sanctum back in the Fright Zone, but it's a start to a place that he can find *some* comfort in.

Especially if a certain lab partner is there with him.

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Hordak opens the door to his room, the door creaking loudly despite his light push. His eyes immediately search for Entrapta's

figure on the bed amidst the darkness, guided only by the pale moonlight that flows from the one large window. It takes him a few moments, but finally, he locates her. Her figure isn't sitting up anymore and is now laying down atop the mattress, practically smothered in blankets, though her face and pigtails peek out at the top.

"Entrapta?" Hordak whispers.

No response.

Shutting the door softly behind him, Hordak walks towards her bed. As he nears closer to the bed, he watches his step more carefully, for her long pigtails have fallen to the floor and are sprawled out in the general area around her. The last thing he'd want to do is accidentally step on her hair and cause her great pain.

He finally reaches close enough to see her face more clearly, and sure enough, she had fallen asleep. To be honest, it's a somewhat-strange sight to behold; naturally, Entrapta is always moving, always talking, always fidgeting, always doing *something.* But now, she's completely still and silent. It's certainly odd to see.

And as he lingers there a moment longer, Hordak can't help but smirk a bit to himself - here she was, boldly stating how she was going to force him to take the bed, and she couldn't stay awake long enough to do so.

No matter. He was never going to let her sleep on the floor, anyway.

He turns back around and, a few feet from the bed, he places the sleeping bag on the floor and prepares to lay it fully out. Unfortunately, a lot of Entrapta's hair obstructs the way, having sprawled out from her bed on the floor. He'll have to move it away and closer towards the bed.

So as carefully as he can, Hordak pushes her hair away. He moves slow so as to not wake her, and all the while, he watches her face

to make sure he hasn't disturbed her. After a few moments of this, he's moved them away back towards the bed so that-

Something soft wraps around his hand.

Hordak looks down, eyebrows raised. A tendril of lavender hair has wrapped around his hand, somewhat limp yet still secure. It practically envelopes his palm at first, but after a few seconds, it crawls up and around his wrist, as well.

Hordak snaps his eyes up in shock to look at Entrapta, only to find her still asleep. Is she not consciously manipulating her hair? How else would it be moving? Is she perhaps dreaming about something involving the movement of it, and his hand was the closest thing to grab? Or is this just something that happens with her hair sometimes?

Hordak peers at his ensnared hand for a moment longer. If he was being honest, the sensation is...pleasant. Her hair is warm and secure, like a hand fitting perfectly into his own, and Hordak finds his heart stuttering at the sight.

He lightly shakes his head to himself to clear his mind. He started this whole thing with the goal of setting up his sleeping bag, did he not? So, very carefully, he unravels his hand and wrist from her grasp and lets the hair fall back to the ground.

From there, he moves back to his sleeping bag and unravels it. It's larger than he expected, which isn't a bad thing, and sure enough, the interior is soft with padding on the bottom. He's immediately grateful - the prospect of resting against the rock hard floor sounds less than enjoyable, if even endurable.

Now all set up, he crawls into it. Some part of him realizes that he's still wearing his assigned robes and attire, though the other part of him doesn't see value in taking it off. What else would there to be changed into? If anything, he wishes he had his armor right now, though he knows that Entrapta will soon be working on it and he'll just have to be patient until then.

For a few moments, Hordak wrestles around in his sleeping bag. It’s comfortable in theory, though his pained muscles certainly don’t agree. He takes a moment to look longingly at bed, though he knows he’d much rather suffer down here than have Entrapta not have the bed.

And in a fleeting thought, Hordak wishes they could simply share the bed.

Hordak furrows his brow. The thought doesn't completely fleet away; it doubles back and takes root there in his mind. And as he continues to stare at Entrapta, all snuggled up in the bed, the realization completely dawns on him.

He truly wishes he could be beside her.

The desire makes absolutely no sense. Hordak naturally hates close contact with others - there’s a reason many in the Fright Zone referred to him as a “shut-in.” He was never ashamed or bothered by the sentiment that others always said because, well, they were true. *Are* true. After all this time on Etheria, he still fails to find the appeal of being close to others. It simply seems uncomfortable. Suffocating, even.

Yet, with Entrapta he can’t help but think otherwise.

His mind carries him back to the hug from before - not the initial hug they shared when Entrapta first saw him, but the one they had by the rock. The former embrace, after all, was over in a snap and honestly was a bit jarring, for he was not at all prepared, and his brain lagged a bit before it had the chance to even register that Entrapta had spun him around in her arms at all.

But, with the latter hug done by the rock...It was long. Drawn out. Shared in a moment of vulnerability. He could truly live in the moment as it happened unlike the first hug.

And he...he enjoyed it. He really did, more than he could understand. The way her small frame fit against his, the warmth that naturally radiated off her skin, the softness of her hair as it

wrapped around him and just made him feel so *safe* and *important...*

He misses that. He would give anything to feel that way again.

And as he looks up at Entrapta, sleeping soundly on the bed and now beginning to drool, he wishes more than anything that he could be there beside her. To feel her same body against his, her warmness, her soft pigtails that would wrap around him-

Hordak blinks and furrows his brows once more.

Why is he feeling this way?

He doesn't understand. She's only his close friend. His "lab partner," as she often loves to say. Is this normal for these types of bonds? Is this how everyone feels about one that would call a close friend?

He had never truly had one before, so he has no frame of reference, but some part of him tells him that it's not.

Then...What's wrong with him? Why is he feeling these absurd emotions that he can't comprehend?

...And does Entrapta feel the same way?

At that moment, Entrapta turns around in the bed in her sleep. She shuffles around for a bit before finally settling once more, her back now turned to Hordak.

Some part of Hordak thinks, for a second, that she had heard his thoughts and rejected him by turning around. He quickly realizes that's obviously not true, of course, though the sheer possibility of that crossing his mind seems to knock some common sense into his brain.

Why would she ever have the same feelings for him? She would never want to be close to him in the same way he does with her. She had embraced him in those hugs, sure, but that was only out

of the kindness and friendliness in her heart. There was no weight to it as there was to Hordak.

He doesn't blame her. He's a defective clone with abhorrent skin and the pathetic need for armor to walk without pain.

Why would she ever find that desirable?

"And imperfection is beautiful...At least to me."

The words cross his mind without warning - words that she had said what feels almost ages ago, right after she had caught him once in his pathetic state. Before she had said those words, Hordak had always viewed her as a valuable and trusted partner and asset in the Horde army, but after that…

Something in him...shifted, in a way. She seemed to be more...special to him. Able to stir up strange feelings and longings and joys and warmth in his heart that he had never felt with her before.

Is that why he's currently feeling this way? Now studying her in the bed after an awfully hectic day and wanting only to find comfort in her?

All because pointed out the possibility of him being something other than repulsive despite his features, despite his defects.

All because she saw the awful parts of him as *beautiful.*

How could one possibly feel that way? That he could be seen as something even remotely close to beautiful? It doesn't make any sense, and it never did, try as he might to believe her words.

How could she ever feel the same way that he does?

In the end, Hordak simply shakes his head to himself once more and heaves a sigh. He turns over in his sleeping bag, now facing the door, and shuts his eyes.

None of this is worth dwelling on. He knows it would never turn out well for him.

Chapter End Notes

i feel like a lot of the fandom (especially those who dislike hordak) fail to realize that he and catra had been through a lot of the same things. of course, to stark varying degrees and handling the effects of their experiences in different ways, but the similarities are still there. i think that would make their dynamic interesting post canon

anyways, thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always very appreciated! (and come say hi on tumblr! i'm beckkii over there)

Breakfast Discussions

Chapter Notes

happy new years everyone! here's to the new year :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak wakes to the sound of nearby chattering.

It's a strange feeling, at first, to be woken up in such a way. For the past several years in the Fright Zone, the only sound he ever woke up to was silence, being that he always slept alone. Some mornings, Imp would be chirping or making some annoying repetitive noise nearby, but that was on more rare occasions. Most times, it was completely silent, leaving him alone with his thoughts by morning come.

But now, his ears are flooded with the familiar sound of a certain high-pitched, somewhat nasally voice.

"Hm...I *think* I can just borrow it, or-...No, maybe I shouldn't. Well, wait, why would it even be in here in the first place? I'm sure it's fine."

He blinks open his eyes, only to quickly shut them once more at the sheer, almost-painful brightness that pours into the room. He blinks a few times, trying to adjust his vision, before he finally is able to fully open his eyes. He glances to the side from his spot on the floor, looking towards the direction of the nearby voice. It comes from the bedroom's built-in bathroom, and with the door wide open, Hordak immediately locates the voice's owner within.

It's Entrapta, squatted down at the bathroom's sink and peering into the cabinets below.

Hordak's a bit taken aback at first. Her lilac hair, opposed to being done up in two high pigtails, is completely down, flowing around her and sprawled on the tile floor. One thick strand of hair holds

onto two hair ties - probably the ones she always uses to hold up her pigtails - while she instead places all of her attention on something inside the cabinets, her hands holding open each cabinet door to see in.

Finally, she reaches in and pulls out what she needs from it - a hairbrush. She bounces up into a standing position and goes to work brushing her hair, using the mirror above the sink for guidance. As she works, she sticks out her tongue; Hordak doesn't know why she always tends to do that, but it's something he's noticed is a habit of hers ever since they first worked together in the Fright Zone. Perhaps it helps her focus better?

"Good morning, Entrapta."

Entrapta startles a bit at first, jumping in place, before she whips around to face Hordak through the bathroom doorway. A strand of hair picks the hairbrush out of her hand, and she instead manipulates that to brush her hair, leaving her hand now available to wave in greeting.

"Oh!" she chimes. "Hi, Hordak!"

Her one strand of hair that was brushing seems to have finished rather quickly, for it plops the hairbrush onto the sink. Now, still staring straight on at Hordak, she effortlessly puts her two pigtails up using her hands *and* the help of different strands of hair to fasten the hair ties around each pigtail. In the end, the entire process finishes quite fast given her mass amounts of hair, and it's honestly both impressive and somewhat jarring.

"Did you sleep well?" she asks, looking up and down the sleeping bag. A bit of worry crosses her features as she does so.

Hordak hesitates. On one hand, he isn't hurting nearly as bad as he would expect from spending the whole night on the floor. But on the other hand, he still *hurts* . Rest sometimes helps matters, but last night's sleep certainly didn't.

"Uh...I suppose so," he manages to say.

Immediately, he wishes he had phrased that differently, for a frown graces across Entrapta's lips.

"I told you," she states, stepping out of the bathroom and walking towards the bed, "I could've slept on the floor instead. It wouldn't have bothered me. It would've actually made me happier, you know."

Hordak fully sits up to peer up at her on her way. "You were already asleep when I came in. I didn't want to disturb you."

"I wouldn't mind," she says with a shrug as she bends down to pick up her mask by the bed. She firmly places it back on her head and, standing up straight once more with her hands planted on her hips, she looks down at Hordak and offers him a playful smile. "Really, Hordak, you gotta speak up for your own well being sometimes. You act like you don't deserve literally *anything* ."

Hordak furrows his brow. "I do *not*- "

A strand of hair immediately swishes out and pushes against his lips for a moment, shushing him. He narrows his eyes further to glare at her, only for her to already be hopping onto the bed and no longer paying him any attention.

"Perfuma knocked on the door earlier to say that they're having breakfast outside in the courtyard," Entrapta says as she draws the covers up and begins to make the bed. Now arranging the pillows, she continues, "Or, wait, *she's* doing daily meditation or something while the other princesses have breakf-...Wait, no, the *other* princesses are doing meditation while...Wait, wait, I don't think that's right."

She shakes her head to herself before looking over at Hordak. "Whatever, it doesn't matter. Basically , there's some food down in the courtyard that we can have. Oh! Oh! And Hordak, guess what? They even made some of the food tiny - just for me!"

At that, Entrapta breaks into the widest smile, her ruby eyes shining like the stars above. And on instinct, a matching grin

forms on Hordak's face. He never would've guessed that the prospect of there being small food available for his friend would make him equally as delighted, but here he is.

"I thought that was really nice," Entrapta says, her smile becoming sheepish as a hint of rosy blush appears on her cheeks.

Hordak's gaze softens at the sight. "It was."

At that, Entrapta finishes making the bed and uses her pigtails to swiftly hop off it. Now standing beside Hordak who's still sitting on the floor under the sleeping bag covers, she looks down at him and offers out a tendril of hair. Hordak looks at it for a moment, quirking a brow.

"So, you ready?" Entrapta asks. "You know, to go have breakfast with them?"

At her very words, a wave of nausea overwhelms his gut. If he wanted to be honest with her, he'd immediately say " *no* , not at all," because he's certainly *not* ready in any way. Seeing all of those princesses and leaving the comfort of this room is the very *last* thing he'd like to be doing this early in the morning.

For a brief second, Hordak looks back up at Entrapta's bright gaze, at her soft smile and colorful eyes that shine expectantly down at him. Her tendril of hair waits there to be taken, wavering in front of him as an open invitation.

"I mean, you don't *have* to, of course." Entrapta says, looking away for a moment. "But this could...I don't know. Maybe help break the ice between you and the other princesses? Or maybe it'd end really badly, I don't know, but...They invited you, too, so…"

Hordak pauses, his hand hovering overtop Entrapta's offered strand of hair.

What else is there to do?

He knows he should be trying for her sake.

These princesses are her *friends* , after all.

So in the end, albeit with another moment's hesitation, Hordak takes it. Entrapta uses her hair's strength to hoist him up and off the ground before whipping around and heading towards the doorway, ready to leave.

"Alright! Let's not waste any time then!"

He trails behind her, and with each step, the nausea still doesn't leave his gut.

This never will get any easier, will it?

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The courtyard appears much nicer in the daylight compared to last night's dim appearance, Hordak has to admit. The grass is lush and green, sparkling with vibrant flowers of various colors. Bushes of different sizes surround the courtyard as well, equally speckled with flowers and adding overall decoration to the lovely environment.

The people amidst the courtyard are equally as lively. Hordak's eyes first land on Catra and Adora off in the far corner, eating scones and laughing loudly over their shared conversation that's only passed between them.

In the other corner, Perfuma - he believes is her name? - and Scorpia appear to be meditating. Well, Perfuma is. Scorpia seems to be struggling with it, for she opens her eyes every few moments to look at the other princess for guidance.

However, Hordak can't help but notice that every time she looks over, her gaze is warm and full of something akin to fondness. He quirks a brow at the sight. Are they, too, in close relations now? He was aware of Catra and Adora to an extent, but not those two.

Entrapta's bot, Emily, is also seen in the midst of the courtyard, rolling excitedly around the young ice princess and old King Micah as they converse with each other, along with...a colorful horse? Hordak studies the horse for a moment, trying to realize what he's finding so strange about it, only to realize that it seems to be talking. He immediately tears his eyes away. He's had enough to deal with over the past few days, and trying to understand why there's a talking horse here in Bright Moon is the last of his concerns.

Finally, Hordak notices the sea princess, the pirate, the archer, and the queen all sitting in a circle together on the grass nearby. The archer looks up at the sight of Entrapta's appearance, and he waves happily, an equally-joyous smile on his face.

"Hey, Entrapta! Come join us," he says. He then lifts up a paper plate full of bite-sized food and adds, "We have tiny scones for you."

At the very mention of tiny food, Entrapta's eyes light up like the sun, and she waves excitedly back.

"Oh, hi, Bow! And hey, everyone!" she exclaims, already skipping on her way to join their little circle.

Hordak freezes in place at first. He knows he should follow her - not as if he has anywhere else he *could* go - but sitting around that little group sounds less than pleasant. Everyone's eyes are clearly avoiding him, and in no way does he blame them, but it does also make his presence feel obviously unwanted.

But he doesn't really have a choice here, does he?

In the end, he treks behind Entrapta like some pathetic, cowering animal on their way to join the group. The archer and pirate shuffle away from each other to make some room, and Entrapta quickly plops down with her legs criss-crossed, oblivious to any tension now amidst the group. Hordak, keeping his eyes on the

ground and avoiding the burn of stares on him, awkwardly shuffles to sit down.

Pain ripples through his body at the movement, and he bites back a growl. Now certainly wouldn’t be the time to expose his vulnerabilities, would it?

“How’d you sleep?” the queen says to Entrapta, breaking the heavy silence.

Entrapta smiles at her. “Just fine! Though, to be honest, your pillows were a bit too fluffy for my taste. But it was alright!”

The queen’s eyes then dart towards Hordak’s, and he immediately stiffens under the pressure of her gaze.

“And,” she says, “how was the sleeping ba-“

“It was comfortable, thank you,” Hordak quickly finishes for her, looking away as his ears flick down. He truthfully doesn’t know why he’s so embarrassed about this whole topic; all he knows is that he doesn’t wish to talk about it any longer. To be honest, *anything* pertaining to him is a topic he doesn't wish to dwell on with these princesses all around him.

The group goes silent at his words, and Hordak keeps his gaze fully set on watching Entrapta as she takes the plate of miniature scones from the archer and pops one in her mouth. He still can feel stares from the others burning into his skin, though he tries his best to ignore them.

“Wow, these are really good!” Entrapta exclaims. “Kind of reminds me of how my chefs back in Dryl would make them. Who made these?”

“Ah, my dearest Mermista did!” the pirate chimes out. Hordak watches as he wraps an arm around the sea princess and smiles cheerfully at her, while she, on the other hand, looks away as pink blush forms on her face. “It’s a little known hobby that she doesn’t do quite often, but she is in fact a magnificent baker!”

“Don’t make a big deal out of it,” the sea princess - Mermista, correct? - mumbles, though a small smile forms on her face as she looks up at Entrapta. She takes a sip of coffee from her mug before adding, “I felt pretty bad about last night, so I hope this...You know. Makes up for it.”

Entrapta grins back at her. “Oh, don’t worry about it! But, thank you. I really appreciate it.”

The group falls silent at that, and the air amidst them is calm. Settled. No focus on Hordak, just as he prefers it. And honestly, if he could just sit here for the rest of his time here and pretend he doesn’t exist, then he’d be more than grateful.

The peaceful silence lasts only for a moment, however, for another voice quickly pipes up.

“So, Entrapta,” the archer - or Bow, as Entrapta called him? - says between mouthfuls of his own normal-sized scone, “Do you have any new inventions you’ll be working on lately? Now that your goals have...uh, *shifted* ...I was just kinda curious. I’m starting some new stuff myself, like more inventions for my arrows that could be used to help people during this time.”

“Oh yeah, for sure!”

She pauses to pop another scone in her mouth. After swallowing, she then gestures to Hordak sitting by her side.

“I was gonna make some new armor for Hordak.”

Hordak’s blood freezes in his veins. This is *not* the topic of conversation he was planning on.

“Armor?” Mermista asks, her icy eyes darting towards Hordak. “Why would he need new armor?”

In that moment, Hordak prays that by some miracle, they could go back to talking about her generosity of providing Entrapta with tiny scones for breakfast.

“Yeah, I’m kinda confused,” the queen says, holding her mug of steaming coffee closer to her lips while her eyes dart occasionally towards Hordak, “I mean, the war is over. Why would you need that?”

Bow adds, ”Well, it could always be-“

“What, are you planning on more fighting?” Mermista cuts in, words as sharp as knives. “On starting another war or something?”

“I wouldn’t assume *that* ,” the pirate says. Mermista turns to glare at him, but ignoring it, he looks towards Hordak with a gentle smile. “What *do* you need it for, friend?”

Hordak narrows his eyes into slants despite the pirate’s blatant kindness. “It is none of your concern.”

“Uh, if it involves any fighting or wars, then *yeah* , it is our concern,” Mermista snaps. “And I really don’t know what other purpose armor would have for-“

“Sorry, I probably...uh, shouldn’t have brought this up,” Entrapta says, offering a meek smile to everyone. She turns her head to look up at Hordak, and her smile immediately falters, worry written clear in her squinted eyes that once shone so brightly.

Hordak stares back down, ears fallen. He knows that she didn’t *know* any better, and she looks just so *guilty* by her honest mistake that he can’t help but feel bad on her behalf. His heart sinks at the sight, and he opens his mouth to reassure her, only for a different voice to interject before he has the chance to say anything.

“No, I’m genuinely just asking,” Mermista says, waving a hand. “If it’s harmless, then why can’t he just tell us why he needs it? It wouldn’t be a big deal if he just explained.”

“I *said* ,” Hordak growls, his fists tightening by his side as he looks up at her, “that it does not concern you. At all.”

Mermista glare burrows into him. “That sounds pretty suspicious if you ask me.”

“Okay, how about I get us more coffee and scones?” Bow pipes up, his voice overly chipper. He clumsily moves to stand, saying, “I think we could all use-“

“I think I get it now,” Mermista sneers, crossing her arms over her chest and tossing Hordak a bland smile. “That’s why you’re sticking around Entrapta all this time. You need her to make stuff for you, like armor.”

Hordak freezes. At her words, a flash of white, hot anger bubbles throughout him, and for a moment, all he does it stare at her, words unable to move past his lips. How does one even *come* to that possible conclusion? And how does he even *respond* to the sheer absurdity of it? The initial anger gurgles within, stronger and stronger the more he stares back at the sea princesses.

But try as he might to contain it and hold back, it soon ripples out of him with a piercing yell.

“You have *no* idea-!”

“You know she’s smart. She’s smarter than all of us, and she’s great at making stuff,” she continues, gesturing towards Entrapta with a wave of her hand. Entrapta only stares back, her expression unreadable, as Mermista continues, “And you know that she’ll help you if you're her friend. Or, if you pretend to be one.”

Hordak’s jaw drops, his eyes going wide, as he’s left speechless for a moment.

“Entrapta helped us all before, like when Glimmer was on Prime’s ship and then with disabling all the chips, because *we* are her friends. Don’t you remember?” she says, turning towards Entrapta directly. “You saved so many of us when we needed your help, and we couldn’t have done it without you. And now? Hordak’s

doing the same thing, except I bet that he's only doing it for his own benefit."

His blood gone cold, Hordak watches Entrapta as she opens her mouth to speak. Only, nothing comes out. Her wide gaze snaps towards Hordak's - only for a second, and completely unreadable - before her eyes tumble helplessly towards the ground. In a flash, a tendril of hair snakes up and flicks her mask down, further concealing her expression. She makes no more movement or sound.

"Mermista, you don't know that," Bow says, his tone soft. "You can't just assume things."

"I'm not just-!"

Mermista stops herself in her tracks, sucking in a breath. She then shakes her head, digging the heels of her palms into her eyes and groaning all the while. Finally, she looks back up and snaps once more.

"Why are you guys acting like I'm being ridiculous about all this?" she asks, her eyes darting about the group. "The only thing we know about him-"

She pauses for a moment to gesture at Hordak.

"-is that he created an army here to take over Etheria, only for him to then allow Prime and his even larger army to fully take over. We don't know *anything* else about him. How are we supposed to know if he ever stopped wanting to do that? How are we supposed to know he's not using Entrapta to help him?"

At her words, bursts of fury grow throughout Hordak. They ripple beneath his skin, amidst his bones, ready to explode in a moment's notice. The sensation practically itches to be released the longer he stares up at the princess - the princess who's spitting words that are nothing but lies, who stares down at him with a sharp glare.

And try as he might to hold back, to stay calm, to maintain peace for Entrapta's sake, he just *can't.*

"You do *not* know me or my motives!" Hordak cries out. "How dare you just accuse me of wanting to disrupt this peace now, and to *use* Entrapta-!"

"Everyone here," Mermista says, swiftly standing up to tower over the sitting group and gesture at everyone in the entire courtyard, "has seen what you've done to Etheria. You've done nothing but hurt and use people, like Adora and Catra and Scorpia and *now* Entrapta, and you're acting like we're crazy for saying otherwise."

Bow pipes up from the floor, tone urgent, "Guys, let's all just calm do-"

"I am well aware that I made mistakes in the past, but you do *not* get to accuse me of using Entrapta," Hordak yells, moving to stand as well. Hot pain gushes throughout his upper limbs at the jarring motion, but he resolves to ignore it, instead staring daggers at the princess before him. "And what she is doing to help me with my armor does not affect you-"

Mermista groans loudly, cutting off his words. "Do you not hear how suspicious that sounds? 'Helping you with your armor'? Seriously, why else do you need armor? Why else do you need *her* ? You obviously don't want 'friendship' or anything - you're just some failed leader who needs another person to help you again because you can't do it by yourself."

She then points towards Catra on the other end of the courtyard who looks over with wide eyes. In fact, Hordak realizes that *everyone* around them is staring. The entire courtyard has gone silent, save for their little group that once was peacefully eating scones and discussing the joys of Mermista's hidden hobby of baking.

"Catra told us before," Mermista says, "that she helped lead the Fright Zone. And I know why now. You needed her because you

can’t do it alone, just like you’re doing now with Entrapta.”

Hordak looks to Catra for a moment, trying to catch her gaze, only for her to tear her eyes away immediately to pointlessly look at a spot on the ground.

He brings his eyes back towards Mermista’s then, and now staring straight on, unwavering, he sneers, “As I said, you do *not* know me or my intentions. And you can not accuse me of even *attempting* to use Entrapta or wishing to start another war-“

“I don’t care what *you* have to say about it, because obviously you’re gonna defend yourself,” Mermista cuts him off. “I’m asking everyone else here for their input. You know, the people who aren’t possible threats under watch.”

“Mermista, *listen* .”

At the sound of the queen’s voice, everyone falls silent and turns to look at her.

“You’re right. I know we don’t know anything about him,” she says, her tone even and withstanding. She stands up as well as she gestures to the entire courtyard, saying, “But I’m trying to do what’s best for *everyone* here. Entrapta is vouching for him, and she will only be here in Bright Moon for now unless he is as well. And *I* have to take that into consideration. And I trust Entrapta, so-“

“Of *course* I trust Entrapta!” Mermista interjects. “That’s obviously not the point here. It’s that I don’t trust *him* .”

“And that’s why he’s going on trial as soon as possible!” She yells. Seeming to realize her sudden spike in temper, she sucks in a breath for a brief second before continuing, her tone now much calmer, “As queen, I know exactly what I’m doing and how I’m going do it, and you shouldn’t question me, whether you’re a part of the Princess Alliance or not.”

At that, Bow stands to put a hand on the queen's shoulder, grabbing her attention. He cuts in, his voice low, "Glimmer, you say 'soon,' but what *exactly* does 'soon' mean? Because Mermista's right - we can't just let him be 'on watch' for all this time. We can't take that risk, and besides, it's not fair to those he had hurt in the past."

The queen looks down at the ground for a moment. She clenches and unclenches her fists by her sides, again and again and again, as her brow furrows deeper in clear thought. In the end, she finally looks up at their little group.

"Tomorrow. We'll hold it first thing tomorrow."

She pauses to look at Hordak. Her gaze is stern, though Hordak doesn't feel threatened by it - he simply stares back, unmoving.

"You'll be properly charged for your crimes then, and we'll know exactly what to do with you."

At that, she looks around to the rest of the group. "Is that fair? Or am I being unreasonable here?"

Bow shrugs before bringing his coffee mug to his lips, only to keep his eyes locked directly on it and avoiding any other's gaze. He doesn't add any comments - or, at least any *decipherable* comments, for Hordak hears a bit mumbling spoken into the mug as he takes a sip though it's incomprehensible.

Mermista looks away, along with the pirate, and no comment comes from either of them. The pirate appears to have no true opinion on it, though Mermista is still visibly scowling, her eyes narrowed and hands clenched into balled fists by her sides.

Finally, Hordak turns to his side to see how Entrapta is feeling after everything. The sight of the mask used earlier to cover her face worried him - he knows she uses it mainly for work reasons, of course, but he's also learned over time that she tends to use it in times of distress as well. Whether it's to hide her expression from others or if she simply dislikes feeling vulnerable, he isn't-

Hordak’s eyes widen.

Entrapta isn’t there.

Immediately, his eyes dart around the courtyard like ricocheting bullets in search of her. Only, to no avail. She’s nowhere in sight, not even a flash of purple or anything. It’s as if she had completely vanished from thin air, and Hordak’s gut twists with another round of nausea as worry ripples through him.

“Hey, wait, where’s Entrapta?” Bow says, seeming to have realized her sudden absence as well. “Did she leave?”

Concern crosses Mermista’s features as she glances around. “Uh, I didn’t see her go anywhere…”

No one says anything else, and the group is left awkwardly looking every which way for a moment to try to catch some sight of her. Only, there is none.

However, seemingly out of nowhere, an idea pops into Hordak’s mind.

He knows where she is.

And without a moment's hesitation, Hordak swiftly turns away from his spot amidst the group circle to leave.

Another wave of pain washes over his back at the sudden movement, but yet again, he bites back any expression of it, feeling all of their eyes locked intently on him and watching his every move.

“I will go find her,” is all he says.

As he walks away towards Bright Moon’s entrance, no one says otherwise or tries to stop him. He isn’t completely certain why, but he’s thankful, and he’ll allow himself this one measly victory for the day.

Chapter End Notes

sorry for all the angst and fighting lately. don’t worry, i have much more fluff and soft moments coming up in the next few chapters - i just had to get some of the initial, pretty bad tension out of the way with these chapters. but trust me, i have more fun writing tender entrapdak moments compared to writing chapters like these

as always, kudos and comments are super appreciated! :) and come say hi on my tumblr! i’m beckkii over there <3

Burdened

Chapter Notes

> back with another update! so far we haven't really delved in too deep about how entrapta is feeling about everything going on, but there's a lot of that in this chapter :)
>
> i hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak hurries through the hallways, each step quicker than the last. The sound of his footsteps echoes off the walls; they bounce around him and provide him something to focus on other than the fatigue in his bones, the persistent ache in his muscles that long for proper rest compared to last night's measly sleep, the fear that churns in his gut at Entrapta's sudden disappearance.

It's a strange thing, him rushing down the hallways in search of her. Some part of him feels as if he should be worrying about the ever-growing tension between him and the princesses, the incoming dread that accompanies anything involving his fate, and the fact that his trial - the trial that could end in severe punishment or possibly even execution - is tomorrow. His entire *future* is being determined in one day's time, and yet...

He isn't worrying about any of that.

All he can worry about is her.

To be honest, he probably should've thought this one through before being so quick to search for her without any aide. The kingdom's hallways are still maze to him, and as he continues his search for her, he finds himself more and more lost. Asking for help from the queen or even any of the princesses might've been a good idea in hindsight.

However, he does know what he's looking for amidst these hallways; it's not as if he's rushing in without any clue on where to look. For at the moment of her disappearance, his mind immediately thought of the vents; after all, he knows she finds comfort in them. During their shared time in the Fright Zone, he soon realized that she would often use them for transportation, as possible hiding places, and as places to hunker down in when she needed to think and be alone.

So now, it only makes logical sense that she retreated to a vent. Well, it made logical sense at the *time.* Now, as he wanders through these cursed never-ending hallways, he can't catch any sight of a venting system. Not one that's clearly visible, anyway.

But there has to be something somewhere, right?

It doesn't take him too long to find out. After a few more moments of hurried walking, he heads through a hallway that contains a door he's never seen before. It isn't as precariously designed as, say, the bedroom doors are. It's design lacks any decorations, leaving it bland and basic in appearance. Curious, Hordak pushes it open.

The door opens up into a large maintenance room that's full of wires, cleaning supplies, and various pipes. One very large vent pipe, in particular, rests on the floor by the farthest wall, and Hordak notices how similar it is to the ones back in the Fright Zone.

And there, sitting behind a grate that reveals one entrance to the middle of the vent pipe, is the familiar neon-shaded bug eyes and magenta mask.

"Entrapta?"

Entrapta's head snaps to the side, directly facing Hordak through the grate. He can't see past the bug eyes, but he can still feel her stare as it lands on him.

“Hordak?” she says, voice soft and somewhat muted behind the mask.

Hordak shuts the door behind him with a soft click before he ambles over to the vent pipe. He watches his surroundings carefully as he walks; the place isn’t completely dark, but the lighting is on the dimmer side, basking his surroundings in a light indigo hue.

“Are you alright?” Hordak asks as he kneels down before the vent pipe’s middle opening. He’s now at eye level with her, staring into the bug-eyed mask though still unable to see beneath.

Entrapta nods. “I’m fine. Just…”

Her body curls in slightly amidst the vent pipe, her legs drawn in closer against her chest and gloved fingers clenching tighter atop her knees.

“...Needed some air.”

Hordak chuckles dryly. “This doesn’t appear to be the most sufficient place for air.”

“You know what I mean,” Entrapta huffs out, though despite being unable to see it, Hordak can hear the small smile in her voice. He finds himself smiling a bit in response.

“Fine, then, more *specifically* , why’d you come out here?” Hordak says as he moves to sit fully down, knowing his legs will be too fatigued to hold him up by kneeling any longer. He finds the ground to be awfully dusty beneath him, but he’ll just have to deal with it.

Entrapta looks away from him. Her hands begin to clench and unclench her knees, again and again and again in a seemingly endless loop. She hunches her shoulders as well, making her body even smaller within the pipe.

"I...I don't know. I mean, I know why, but it's hard to put into words, I guess? Like…" Her words trail away then, and she gives a little shake of her head.

"Like…?" Hordak prods.

She looks down. "It's like, sometimes I just..don't know how to sort my feelings out about everything. And I don't know how to react with everyone there. It's kind of overwhelming, I guess, with everyone around me shouting their different opinions. And it's hard for me to gather my own thoughts correctly. Sometimes being away from all that, like right now in this room, helps me clear my head so I can actually *think.* "

She pauses for a moment, hesitating for a moment with no words coming out. In the end, she gives another shake of her head.

"It's...hard to explain."

Hordak draws a bit closer. "I'm willing to listen."

She snaps her head up to look at him. For a long moment, they stare at each other, his lime eyes against her bug eyes. The air is still around them, and neither or them make a move to disturb it.

Until, finally, Entrapta speaks.

"It's just hard because...I want the princesses to understand you. And while I can get how they're feeling-"

"With them being cautious around me?" Hordak asks, tone genuine.

Entrapta shrugs. "Well...In a sense. Obviously I disagree with what they think because I *know* you. But from their perspectives alone...They're all just scared, I think . Mermista, Bow, Glimmer, Adora, *all* of them. They all just want what's best for the people, and I know they see you as a threat to that. I mean, they were the same way with me when I first reunited with them because of

how I made weapons and all that with the Horde. That's just how they are."

She looks away. "So, it's...difficult. I know they distrust you for their own reasons, but it just makes me so frustrated that they won't even give you a chance or care enough to understand you. And then I have Mermista pointing me out when I'm *already* trying to sort out my feelings, and it really throws me for a loop. It's just...overwhelming. For me, at least."

"Is that why you left?" Hordak asks, his voice gentle. "Because of what Mermista accused? Or was it just because of everything going on?"

She's silent for a moment, and Hordak can practically hear the gears whirring in her head as she decides on how to answer that.

"...Both. I'm aware that she doesn't know you *or* your whole story, so of *course* she's going to make wrong assumptions. She just doesn't understand. *None* of them do. But…" She gives a little shake of her head. "I wish I could communicate to them about how what they're saying isn't true, and to try to explain our side of things. But, then I just feel like I'll mess up at that. Communication with them has always been hard for me."

She sighs and tears her gaze away.

"And that's why everything's difficult. I'm stuck in the middle between the princesses and you, trying to be some mediator that I'm bad at. I'm just...not good at handling everyone's different opinions. It's stressful."

Hordak looks to the ground for a moment, mulling over her words, before he speaks out once more.

"I understand. Though," he says, "you don't have to put all of the pressure on yourself. It's not your fault if the princesses don't understand me, or if I can't understand them. You can't put all of this on yourself."

“I know that, Hordak, I just…I want…”

Entrapta’s words cut off as her shoulders sharply hitch up. Her fingers clench even tighter around her knees, digging into her pant leg material.

“...I want things for you to get *better* . I want this to be a time of rest and joy after all the war, not a time for fighting. A-And I want the same for the princesses, too. This isn’t supposed to be a stressful time. And I want to help fix it. But I don’t know what to do, and I don’t know how to handle all of it, and it’s so hard, because...I…”

She turns to look at him. A beat pauses before she takes in a shaky breath and finally speaks, her words wavering on what seems to be the edge of tears.

“I care about you so much, Hordak. You’re the only one who understands me, or at least *tries* to when you can’t. And I...I can't lose you. If this trial doesn’t work out well for you, and you get punished or taken away from me...I...I don’t know what I’d do. I’d...I’d be alone again. Just like I always am.”

Hordak’s throat tightens at her words. A burst of warmth springs into his eyes, and he immediately blinks it away to remain stoic. Yet, her words are so *kind* , so full of *meaning* , and every part of him twists with warmth and comfort and sorrow all the same.

Right then, he knows that if he could do *anything* to make her feel better...He would. He would go to heaven and hell to help her right now.

He just doesn’t know what to do.

“I mean,” Entrapta says, looking away, “I don’t know how much time we have until the trial, but maybe, if we have a lot, we can fix things between you and the princesses until then. Maybe we can try talking to them more to help them understand.”

Doubt immediately floods Hordak at her words.

How could they possibly fix things with the trial being *tomorrow?*

“Entrapta,” Hordak cuts in, voice hesitant, “did you not hear? What the queen said about the trial?”

Entrapta shakes her head. “No. I guess I left before then.”

“It’s tomorrow. In the morning.”

Entrapta falls quiet for a moment.

“Oh. Really? That soon?”

Hordak nods. “I’m...afraid so.”

They sit in silence for a few seconds. It drags on, creating a heavy tension between them that clings to the air.

Until, eventually, Entrapta’s voice rings out.

“I mean...Maybe...Maybe things will work out. I don’t know,” she says, voice small. She shakes her head. “I just feel so dumb.”

Hordak quirks a brow. “Why would you-“

“I thought things could be different between you and the princesses,” Entrapta continues, ignoring Hordak, “and maybe, for example, this whole breakfast thing would work out. But I always interpret things wrong, don’t I? Why can’t I get it right? Why am I so stupi-“

“You are *not* stupid, Entrapta,” Hordak sharply cuts in. “Don’t say that. It’s not true.”

“Then why am I so bad at these things?” Entrapta cries out. Her fingers clench tighter around her knees, and if Hordak could see her hands, he’s certain her knuckles would shine a pasty white. “Why can’t I ever communicate with them right? We’re never on the right page, and I’m want to help them understand yours and my side of things, but I’m so *bad* at it.”

Entrapta sucks in a shuddering breath, shaking her head once more.

"And then I bring up things I shouldn't, like your armor," she says with a wild wave of her hand. "That's what started that whole fight. Why do I always say things I shouldn't? How am I supposed to know when to say and when not to say things? I just don't *get it.* I'm so stupid-"

"Entrapta, *stop* saying that," Hordak interjects once more, his words loud enough to overcome hers. For seeing her say such things, such things that are *not* true, fills his body with some kind of anger he can't describe, can't understand.

Why he feels so strongly on her behalf, he isn't certain, but he can't quite extinguish it.

"You are not stupid in any way. Far from it, actually," he states. "Just because they fail to communicate well with you is not your fault. And just because you brought up something that you wished you hadn't in hindsight does not make you stupid, either. It was only a mistake. Everyone makes them. I make plenty."

"But, I make them all the time-"

"That's alright. You can't use them to tear yourself down. Were you not the one who told me that first? To never give up, despite any struggles or failures?"

She shrugs weakly. "I did, but-"

"Then why won't you believe that now?"

Silence befalls them as his words ring in the air. For a long moment, they stare at each other through the grate, each of them refusing to look away.

"I hate seeing you bring yourself down like this," he says, tone softening, "because there's no reason for you to feel this way."

Entrapta sighs. “I...I guess. I just want everything to work out in the end. I want you all to be...Well, maybe not *friends,* but at least understanding of each other. Especially from the princesses. I want them to understand *you* .”

“But that’s not all of your responsibility,” Hordak adds. “You’re putting all of that on your shoulders, and there’s no need to. It will come with time. The war just ended, and I gather that everyone is on edge. You can’t blame yourself for that.”

“I…” She looks away. “I know. I just feel like a fai-“

“You are not a failure, Entrapta. Don’t say that.”

At his words, she heaves a shuddering sigh beneath the mask. They remain in silence for a moment, neither of them moving, neither of them shattering the stillness between them.

In the end, Entrapta gives a little nod.

“...Alright.”

At that, she pushes on the grate, removing the final barrier between them. She crawls out, and Hordak moves back a bit, allowing her space to sit on the ground. Now fully out and facing Hordak, a tendril of hair flicks her mask up, revealing her face.

Hordak immediately notices how her ruby eyes are teary, the vibrant irises beneath wavering and sparkling despite the dim light. Her flushed cheeks are somewhat damp as well, though they seem to have dried a bit. She wipes a gloved hand over her cheeks as she sucks in another breath.

And finally, she looks up at Hordak with her watery gaze. Her eyebrows crinkle with an emotion that he can’t quite decipher - fondness or sadness or perhaps even both, he truly isn’t certain. Her lip begins to quiver as well, and Hordak begins worry that he has done something wrong when her entire body jumps into his lap.

He retreats back a bit in sudden shock, though the moment his mind catches up with him, he leans in close. Her body is warm and soft pressed up against his own, and he savors the feeling that he craved ever since their last embrace. It just feels so right, so perfect, the way her small body fits up against his. He wraps his arms around her, matching the way both her arms and pigtails wrap around him.

After a moment, she squeezes harder against his body and burrows the side of her head closer into his chest, further messing up her bangs that were already somewhat disbelieved from her mask. Hordak pushes them to the side and out of the way with light touch.

And all he can do is look down and gaze at her, his eyes soft and ears flicked down against his will.

He doesn't want to let go. If Entrapta wishes to remain here for the rest of the day, he'd be more than willing to obligue. To feel her heartbeat against his chest, to feel the way her chest moves up and down with each shuddering breath she takes, to feel the warmth and softness of her presence - he wouldn't trade it for anything.

Never did he ever believe he'd feel such a way with a soul on Etheria, yet here he is.

Not that he knows why. All he knows is that it's a feeling he can't fight, understandable or not.

"Sorry…"

Hordak's ears perk up at her quiet voice. It's barely audible with how soft her tone has gotten.

"Sorry?" he asks. "Why are you sorry?"

She shrugs. "I'm not normally this...emotional. Most times, I don't have people to talk to when I'm feeling this way, or when I go to be alone with my thoughts. People don't really want to deal with

it, if there even are people around me in the first place. Like in Dryl, there isn't really anyone."

She pauses for a moment, hesitating on her words.

"So, normally, I just...deal with it. Now, though, it's...it's different, having you here, but in a really good way that I'm just not used to having."

Hordak's heart twists at her words. He simply can't understand - how could anyone not bother enough to care? How could anyone just let her be alone when she's feeling these ways?

Her fingers clench tighter then, bunching up the robe on his back in her grasp.

"So...Thank you. I'm...I'm glad you're here."

In response, Hordak pulls her closer to his body.

They stay there like that for a long moment, holding each other. He rests his chin atop her head, his muscles fatigued despite it still being only an hour or two upon first waking. If he was being honest, his body is already beginning to creep up on the verge of pain, though he doesn't want to bring it up to her. Destroying their little peace is the *last* thing he'd like to do if he could help it.

He'll just have to manage. For her sake.

So he shuts his eyes, resolving to ignore the pain. At least for now. And all he does is simply listen to her faint heartbeat against his chest, his breathing subconsciously meeting it. His mind drifts off to somewhere else, to somewhere other than the stress that clouds his mind, and he focuses solely on the feeling of her around him.

Until a sliver of light, accompanied by the sound of voices and the door swinging open, grabs his attention and yanks away the peace.

“Entrapta?”

Hordak’s eyes snap open, and Entrapta’s body bounces off his lap in shock. They both whip around to face the door, and Hordak squints at the bright light that pours into the room amidst the dim lighting.

And standing in the doorway, their shadows dark against the stark light, appear to be Bow and the queen.

“Hey, are you alright?” Bow says, taking a step forward into the room. “We were worried after you left all of a sudden.”

“Oh, yeah, I’m fine,” Entrapta says, offering a wide smile. It’s genuine and warm, and Hordak’s heart clenches at the sight. It’s like sunlight peaking amidst storming clouds, seeing her smile after everything, and he can’t help but stare for a moment and admire it.

The queen - Glimmer, he’s certain is her name - steps forward, her staff trailing beside her. She glances between Hordak and Entrapta sitting upon the floor, with Entrapta’s pigtails still wrapped loosely around Hordak and their bodies nearly touching, and she quirks a brow.

“I hope we weren’t...um, intruding or anything,” she says, looking away for a moment before tossing them both an awkward smile. “We just wanted to make sure you were okay.”

Entrapta shrugs. “Don’t worry! But I appreciate the concern.”

Glimmer smiles once more, a bit more confident this time. “Yeah, of course. You’re one of us, aren’t you?”

Entrapta doesn’t answer at first. Her eyes go wide, expression unreadable for a moment, before a small smile makes home on lips, and she nods. No words come from her - only that little movement in response.

And Hordak is curious to see if she'll add anything when Bow's voice pipes up.

"Oh! I, uh, almost forgot," he says, taking a few steps forward.

As he approaches them in the dim light, only then does Hordak notice something in his hand. It's small and in a plastic bag, and he squints, trying to make it out, though failing to do so.

However, when Bow stands before Hordak and offers his hand out - the one holding the packaged item - he's able to finally see what it is.

It's a large scone.

"Everyone else ate, and we noticed you didn't get the chance to, so…" Bow says, looking to the side. "...And we weren't sure if you were gonna come back and join us, so, uh, just in case, we wanted to bring you this."

For a moment, all Hordak can do is gape at the food before him. His jaw drops in shock, though no words pour out. He isn't certain what to say, or even if he *could* say anything. He looks up at Bow, eyes still wide, and he looks back down with a waiting expression.

In the end, Hordak tears his eyes away to look back down at the baked good hovering before him. With hesitant movements, he takes the plastic bag in his hand, finding it still warm.

"I…" Hordak begins, only for his words to trial off. He swallows before looking up at Glimmer and Bow once more.

"Thank you."

Glimmer's lips form a smile, albeit a bit hesitant and unsure. Bow smiles as well, and together, they share an unreadable glance before beginning to back away.

"Well, we should return to the others," Bow says, taking the final step back towards the doorway. "Are you two coming? Everyone is

still there, and I know Mermista and Seahawk were also worried abou-"

"Wait, actually! I wanted to ask something."

Hordak looks over at Entrapta, quirking a brow. Ask something? What is she going to-

"Can I instead introduce Darla to Hordak? You know, the ship?"

Glimmer peers at her a moment. "You mean, leave Bright Moon's grounds to take him to where we left it? Or have Darla flown here-"

"No, no, take him there to her. We can walk."

"Is there a reason why?"

"No particular reason," Entrapta says with a shrug. "I just want to introduce them."

Glimmer looks down, her brow furrowing as she mulls it over. This goes on for a few seconds, but finally, her head snaps up to meet Entrapta's gaze.

"...Fine. I trust you to go with him," Glimmer says. "Darla is parked nearby in the Whispering Woods - it's a little walk there, but it's not too long. Some guards are out there too to patrol the area and direct any citizens roaming around right now, so if you're lost, they'll guide you there."

Entrapta's eyes light up. "Great!"

"And be back before sunset."

"Yeah, yeah, okay," Entrapta says, nodding eagerly. "That's fine."

At that, Glimmer looks at both Entrapta and Hordak, offering one final smile. "Well, have a safe trip, then. We'll see you this evening."

And without another word, Bow and Glimmer turn on their heels to exit the room, shutting the door softly behind them.

"Oh, wow, that's great!" Entrapta says the moment the door clicks shut. "I wasn't sure if they were gonna let us go. You know, with you being on watch and all. But I guess Darla's not too far away and there's guards out there, so I get why she'd be alright with it."

Instead of addressing that, Hordak only raises an eyebrow to peer at her. "I wasn't aware you wanted to take me to see the ship."

Entrapta smiles up at him, and Hordak can't help but notice that it's almost a bit…mischievous, in a way.

"Well, while I *did* want to introduce you to Darla at some point, that's not really why I asked to go. Because guess what?" she says, tone infallibly on the brim of excitement.

"What?"

"I have some supplies left on the ship!" she exclaims. "I had to use a lot to make space suits for everyone, and I left them there. So, while we were hugging, I realized something great!"

Hordak can't help but smile. Of *course,* even in a moment of tranquility, Entrapta would be thinking about something like this.

"Those supplies could be used to make you some new armor!" she says. "There's a wide variety of supplies there, and I know I could make something great. It wouldn't take that long. I could even finish it today."

Hordak's eyebrows raise. At the notion of new armor, he once again becomes acutely aware of the pain he was trying his hardest to ignore earlier.

"That would...certainly be helpful," Hordak says. "But, what if the other princesses see the armor and think-"

She shrugs. “Ah, well, that’s a future problem for us. We’ll figure it out later. And besides-“

Her gaze wanders over him, up and down, and it softens into something akin to concern.

“I’d rather deal with them arguing about it than seeing you in pain any more.”

She looks up at him, and the moment their eyes meet, she offers him a warm, small smile.

“You know what I mean?”

And all Hordak can do for a moment is stare at her, his eyes wide and ears fallen. Her ruby eyes are so full of eagerness and excitement at the very prospect of creating this armor, all for *his* sake, and he can’t figure out how to respond.

Finally, he swallows and nods.

“I...Yes. I do,” Hordak says, his lips forming a smile as well. “Thank you, Entrapta. I appreciate it.”

Her smile widens further before she finally stands back up. Once more, she looks down at him and offers a tendril of hair for him to take. He takes it carefully with his free hand, knowing that it doesn’t hurt her though still wishing to be gentle just in case.

“Alright, well, we don’t have a moment to waste!” Entrapta says once Hordak’s standing, her voice as chipper as ever. She immediately whips around and heads towards the door, her words floating over her shoulder, “Oh, I can’t wait for you to meet Darla! You’ll love her, I’m sure!”

And as Entrapta heads out the door, Hordak quickly falls into step beside her, his grip still tight on the plastic bag holding the baked good. He looks down at her as she continues talking about the ship, each word spoken more excitedly than the last.

He can’t help but smile. It seems he can’t do anything else around her.

Chapter End Notes

off to (finally) get hordak some armor!

thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always super appreciated! (and come say hi on tumblr! i’m beckkii over there :))

Close By

Chapter Notes

> next chapter is finally done! this time, it's mainly a break from the main tension with the princesses to delve into some more fluff with hordak and entrapta :) this whole scene on darla is going to be longer than i can fit in only one chapter, so i'm splitting it into two. now, here's the first part!
>
> i hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak has just finished his scone when finally, after several minutes of walking through the Whispering Woods, they arrive at the ship.

The first thing he notices is that it's not that big of a ship. In fact, its size is rather small and compact - perfect for a group travelling throughout space for a short duration of time. And despite the ship now parked amidst a small clearing, it doesn't even take up the entire area. He also notices how the ship appears lifeless, for no light or sign of activity can be seen within the large glass windows.

Curious, Hordak begins to approach the ship. And he's hardly even made it a step forward when a sudden tendril of lilac hair wraps around his hand and yanks him with it.

"Come on!" Entrapta yells, her vibrant eyes shining with excitement as she races forwards. "You're gonna love her!"

Helpless to stop her, especially with that tight limb of hair wrapped around his wrist, he trails behind her with quick steps to keep up with her bounding pace. Bursts of pain erupt within his muscles at the jarring movement; but, he resolves to ignore it. He doesn't wish to stop her obvious excitement if he could help it.

Finally, they reach the shut entrance. She halts to a sharp stop and eagerly looks up to the ship, her fists clenched tightly by her face in bubbling anticipation.

“Darla? Are you there?”

A beat passes. Then two.

And all of a sudden, without another moment passing, the ship explodes with life - the inside erupts with artificial lightness, along with the lines that decorate the ship’s exterior, and the entrance extends forward, forming a large ramp that leads up into the inside.

“Greetings, Entrapta.”

Hordak’s eyes widen in shock at a booming, feminine voice that comes from within. Did the ship just...talk? It must have. It truly just spoke. And it addressed Entrapta directly, too. The voice was robotic, sure, and it was certainly an AI of some sort presumably built within the ship’s programming, but that was definitely *not* what he expected.

No wonder Entrapta made friends with the ship. After all, she seemed to bond with all sorts of AI, and many of them didn’t even have the capacity to talk with her.

He doesn’t even have a moment to dwell on this any longer, for suddenly, Entrapta squeals as her fists shake by the sides of her face in that thrilled gesture she always seems to do. Her strand of hair finally releases Hordak’s wrist, and just like that, she bounds up the ramp, not even having to plant her feet on the ground for her pigtails whip her small body straight up into the interior.

“Hordak, come on! You have to meet her!” Entrapta exclaims, now peering down at Hordak from the top of her ramp with shimmering eyes.

At her words, Hordak treks up the ramp, steps careful and cautious on this unfamiliar platform. Once he finally reaches the

top, now standing besides Entrapta at the very front of the ship's interior, the ramp moves to shut, trapping them within. And once settled, Hordak turns around, eyes immediately darting around to survey the area.

The main hull is moderately sized, if a bit on the smaller side. It's bright and illuminating as well, with the control panel that's lined up against the large glass windows lit up and ready for use. He also notices a stray chair in the middle of the hull, though he quickly realizes that it must be used for navigation. Even more in this area, he finds a main hallway that seems to lead into what he infers to be separate rooms for the passengers.

Entrapta takes a step forward, and without a moment to waste, she jumps over to what appears to be the main control center by the windows. Her gloved fingers wrap around the edge, and she leans forward, yelling, "Darla! How are you? Oh, I missed you so much!"

At her words, a vibrant purple sphere erupts from within, along with a voice.

"I am fully operational," the AI voice echoes.

"That's great! Anyway, guess what! I brought a friend for you to meet."

At that, one pigtail wraps around Hordak's waist and pulls him to stand near her. She points a gloved finger in his direction and beams up at him.

"This is Hordak!"

"Hello, Hordak."

Hordak opens his mouth, hesitating, as he looks down at Entrapta for a moment and back up again. Is this his cue to say something? Does he look at the sphere as he speaks? How does he approach this? Is he supposed to say 'hello'? How on Etheria do you properly greet a spacecraft?

“Uh, greetings, er...Darla.”

There’s no response. He’s not sure whether that’s a good or bad thing.

“Anyway,” Entrapta says, releasing her hold on Hordak once more, “Hordak and I have some business to attend to here. I wish I could show him around, but unfortunately, we don’t have time for that today. So I was wondering...No one has been in your rooms since our group last was here, correct?”

“Correct. The ship’s rooms have been uninhabited since She-Ra and her group’s past presence.”

“Okay, great!” she says, turning to Hordak. She smiles up at him as she adds, “Then all my stuff must still be here! C’mon, let’s go!”

Without another word, she whips around on her heels and races away. Hordak doesn’t even get the chance to follow on his own for another tendril of hair latches around his wrist, guiding him with her on her eager pursuit. It’s a bit more gentle this time, thankfully.

“Talk soon, Darla!” Entrapta shouts over her shoulder as she rushes towards the main hallway with Hordak close by. “Thanks for all your help!”

“I am pleased at your satisfaction. However, I must announce - my operating systems are in need of a new update before some basic systems may start to fail. Would you be able to update them?”

At Darla’s words, Entrapta freezes in place at the entrance of the hallway and releases her loose grip on Hordak’s wrist. She peers back for a moment at the sphere as she rubs her neck, saying, “Ah, actually, we’re kinda on a time crunch here. Are the updates that serious?”

“They are not. They are recommended updates, however.”

Entrapta furrows her brow for a moment, deep in thought. In the end, however, she simply shrugs and heads into the hallway. Her form becomes swallowed by the dim light, and the only thing left behind are the words that carry over from her, "It's alright. If we have time before we head back out, I'll do the updates then."

For a moment, Hordak looks back at the purple sphere, studying it, before the hallway door slides shut and all he can do is resolve to follow Entrapta.

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The hallway is larger than he expected. It branches off into several rooms, each one equally spaced apart and hidden behind triangular shaped doors. After a few seconds of walking, Entrapta stops before a particular door, and it slides open with a whoosh.

They enter together, and the very moment they are inside, the door slides shut behind them. Hordak finds the room to be awfully dark at first, making it impossible to see; but, within seconds, a tendril of Entrapta's hair flicks on the light from somewhere, and the room floods with light of a cyan hue.

He blinks, taking it all in. For starters, there's a large bed with its head pressed up against the back wall and the foot pointing towards the doorway. The sheets and pillows are neat and organized, seeking as if they were never even disturbed or used before. Even more, he notices large trunks lining the edges of the wall. They must be-

"Yes! Everything's here!" Entrapta says, bounding towards the trunks. Her pigtails raise her body up so she can hover over them for inspection, and after a few moments, she adds, "Yup, I bet I could make some armor with all these supplies. I mean, it's not as optimal as using the stuff I had at the Fright Zone, but-"

She freezes in place all of a sudden before turning to look at Hordak. With a raised brow, she asks, "Hey, you know what? Do you think maybe we could go to the Fright Zone? I mean, I don't

know if Glimmer would let us, but all my best equipment is left there and that might work better then…”

Hordak stiffens, ignoring Entrapta’s words as they float over him.

For all he can recall is how he had destroyed all of her stuff - every last thing, big or small - several months ago.

Back when he had been told about her “betrayal.”

“Uh, Entrapta?” he cuts her off.

“Yeah?”

“That...would not be necessary.”

She quirks a brow. “Why not?”

“I…” He looks to the side. “I may have. Disposed. Of all of your belongings. At the Fright Zone.”

She’s silent for a moment, cocking her head to the side in utter confusion.

“What?” she finally says. “Why would you do that?”

Refusing to meet her eyes, Hordak keeps his gaze locked onto some random speck on the wall. All the while, he can feel the ínstense burn of her eyes on his face, studying him, yet he tries his best to ignore it.

“I was quite...upset. At you. When Catra lied to me that you… betrayed me. So I...Well. Many things were broken and destroyed. Uh...More specifically, everything was.”

The room is silent for a moment.

Until, all of a sudden, Entrapta bursts into laughter.

“What are you-!”

“That’s...That’s kinda flattering, really,” Entrapta manages to get out between giggles, her body bent over a bit as she clenches her stomach. “Were you...Were you really that upset? To get rid of *everything* ? Hordak, it would’ve been smarter to just *use* my stuff for the Horde - I had so much!”

Hordak’s brow furrows tightly together as his ears flick down in shame. “Well, I-! I-I felt betrayed! And hurt, so I did not think it through to-“

“Wow, that’s…” Entrapta giggles, her tone breathless. Her body shakes with each round of laughter, and after a few seconds, she sucks in a breath and attempts to finish, “That’s so…!”

Another round of laughter interrupts her again, and this time, she doesn't even attempt to speak amidst it.

“I don’t-!”

Hordak opens his mouth to speak those words only to quickly snap it shut again before he can finish, for a hot blush has begun to spread across his face and lowered ears. He simply stands there, unable to move, as he watches Entrapta laugh on and on. Watching her find amusement at Hordak’s rash decision in the past is certainly embarrassing, and yet...

Some part of him flickers with warmth at the sight of her happiness, at the way her face flushes with color, at the way the several strands of her hair curl in on themselves. He should be utterly embarrassed, to have someone openly *laughing* and *mocking* him, but he can’t help but almost...enjoy watching her as well. And at the sight of her giggling, he begins to feel a bit of a smile worming onto his lips, though he tries his best to suppress it.

“I’m sorry, Hordak, that’s just-“ Entrapta says, chuckling a few more times. Finally, though, most laughter seems to have fallen away, and she heaves a sigh, looking up at him with sparkling eyes and a lopsided, shining grin. “That’s just funny to me, is all. I

mean, it doesn't even make sense why you'd get rid of everything when you could've just *used* my stuff for the war. You…"

Her words trail away then, and just like that, her smile falls into something less goofy, something more sincere. Her soft eyes burn into him, never looking away, and the air becomes heavy around them.

"...You must've really been upset, to do all that. Weren't you?"

Hordak's eyes widen. He doesn't know what to say at first, all words having left him. All he can due is stare into that vibrant gaze that leaves him entranced as it always does, leaves him unable to look away.

"I…I was. And I…"

He finally tears his eyes away.

"I was unsure of how to...cope. Without you there. I thought destroying all remnants of you would make me feel better, or to help me forget, but...it failed. I could not forget. I…"

He sucks in a small breath.

"I only missed you more."

The air hangs silent between them. Hordak brings his gaze up to lock with Entrapta's, only to find her expression unreadable. Her mouth has dropped open a bit, her eyes crinkled together, and a small tendril of hair has snaked up to rest against the tip of her mask, ready to flick it down. And all they do is stare at each other in heavy silence, neither of them making a move or disturbing the silence.

Until, all of a sudden, Entrapta pipes up, her voice hardly above a whisper in that rare way she sometimes speaks.

"Hordak, that…"

Entrapta pulls her gaze away, falling to somewhere on the floor. A hint of rosy red begins to color her cheeks, and she grabs a tendril of hair, her fingers flying aimlessly around the strands.

"...That really...I..." she says, words tumbling over each other. She opens her mouth to speak once more, though she hesitates, seemingly unsure of herself.

"That really what?" Hordak pries, noticing her hesitation.

"Well...That really means a lot to me. It's...It's like when you told me that you attacked Catra over her sending me to Beast Island. It's just...I'm not used to it, I suppose."

Hordak tilts his head to the side. "What do you mean?"

"...People don't normally…care so much. About me," she finishes, turning her head away. Her tendril of hair continues to fiddle with the tip of her mask, and Hordak wonders if she'll put it down any time soon.

"So, it...it just means a lot to me," Entrapta adds, her tone sincere. "To hear someone say that. That someone...missed me. And not just because they missed me for the help I could provide them or anything like that. That they actually missed me for...me."

Hordak's gaze softens at her words, his heart squeezing tightly in his chest. Every part of him longs to reach out, to embrace her, to provide her with some sense of comfort; yet, he finds himself holding back, unsure of himself.

Instead, he decides only to speak.

"Entrapta, of course I missed you," he says, words soft and low. "You were...my friend. It did not matter that I thought you betrayed me, or that I believed you would never come back. You were the only one who showed me compassion for many years, and I...Strange as it was, with you working with me, I even found myself not caring as much about...Well, about opening the portal. I…"

He looks to the ground for a moment.

"I just could not imagine being separated from you. So, when you were suddenly gone...Of course I missed you. I could not bear it."

All of a sudden, Entrapta's head whips up with a shocked expression on her face, and their eyes lock. She stares at him for a long moment, the air heavy around them. But soon enough, she opens her mouth to speak.

"I…Hordak, I..."

However, her words quickly fall away. Instead, she only offers him a shy smile, the blush never falling away from her cheeks.

"W-well, I should probably get started on the armor," she blurts out, words shaky. Her gaze quickly darts back and forth between Hordak and the supplies on the ground, unsure of herself on where to look, as she adds, "We gotta be out of here before sundown, after all!"

Hordak's lips quirk down in a frown, if only for a second. For despite her obvious attempts to change the conversation, some part of him wants to go back to what they were talking about so he can ask what she was going to say before she decided to only smile instead. The question lingers there, taking up space in the front of his brain, and curiosity begs him to ask.

However, he resolves to just let it go.

"Would you like me to assist you?" Hordak asks, taking a step closer to her and the supplies. He knows Entrapta is obviously well equipped for this type of job, for she's done this whole thing before, but if he could possibly be of any aid…

Entrapta shrugs. "If you'd like to. But I don't mind doing it all myself, you know."

"Well, I don't mind *helping* you, if it would make things easier."

She bites her lip for a moment, pondering, until she finally says, "Alright, alright. You can help!"

With that said, she leans over the trunks and immediately begins to unlock them.

"Let's get started then!"

~~~

Within mere minutes, the trunks are open and almost entirely emptied, and various supplies sprawl out on the floor in a scattered mess. Hordak patiently sits in silence as Entrapta sets everything up, her hair whipping around to and fro and gloved hands placing things here and there in frantic motions.

As he watches, Hordak can't help but feel a tug at his heart at the sight. It's a strange way to be feeling now as he only watches her set things up, he knows, but watching her in her element as she prepares to do something she loves reminds him all too well of their time together in the Fright Zone. Just as back then, she now appears to be completely absorbed by everything, her tongue sticking out and brows furrowed deep in conversation. And just as back then, all Hordak can do is watch in earnest interest.

As he watches, he can't help but notice that overall, she seems happy now. It's a complete shift from her behavior before, most certainly due to her being given the opportunity to create something with tech, and Hordak is grateful for this little distraction for now.

She certainly needs it, as does he.

All of a sudden, Entrapta lets out a little gasp of surprise. Her hands dive into one trunk, and she pushes a couple things aside, finally revealing something that once only peaked out from beneath several supplies - a tracker pad, it appears to be. She pulls the technology fully out, and a smile lights up her face as she looks at it in her hands.
~~~

“Yes, I still have it! All of my logs are still here!”

Hordak quirks a brow. “Logs? In the tech pad?”

As far as he’s concerned, he’s only aware of the use of her recorder to make her logs. After all, she always seemed to be chattering into the thing back during their shared time in the Fright Zone. So, why the pad-?

“This tracker pad has all of my visual recordings on it and other data I decided to store. I first tried to use Emily for this kind of thing, but I found that it’s easier to keep it all on this pad instead,” Entrapta says, her fingers already racing away atop the screen to turn it on. “I brought it with me to space to report all my findings and experiments there, and while I wasn't able to get much data done on space because of my limited time, I *do* have a lot of visual recordings saved about my projects working on the space suits, Darla, and some other stuff. So-...Oh! Wait! Hordak!”

“Hm?”

“I have to make a log of this then!” She beams, her eyes wide with excitement.

Hordak stiffens. “As in...a visual recording? About making the suit?”

“Yeah!” Entrapta says. Her pigtails carry her up into a standing position, and with her hands on her hips as she looks down at Hordak, she continues, “This is a big project for me! Just like the space suits I made logs of, this is super new and exciting stuff that I gotta record!”

“I…” Hordak glances away for a second, for fear already has begun to creep up his throat. The thought of a recording sounds...less than delightful. And despite how it’s simply an irrational fear, he can’t seem to abate it.

“Will you record...the entire duration of making the suit?” Hordak asks. “Or will you-“

“No, no, it’ll only be the very beginning,” Entrapta says with a light wave of her hand. “Just to talk about what I’m doing and all that. It’ll help me for future reference if I ever have to make more armor for you or if there’s flaws that pop up over time.”

Hordak furrows his brows for a moment, pondering. Being recorded, even if it’s done in a short duration of time, sounds very...well, intimidating, so to speak. After all, having to see a visual playback of himself on a recording is certainly not something he’d ever want to do. Not that he would ever *have* to rewatch it, but it’s still *there* to be rewatched if one were to desire to do so.

In the end, he simply sighs.

How could he deny her wishes?

“...Alright.”

“Great!”

At that, Entrapta bends down to place the tracker pad on the floor, resting it to lean up against the trunk. From that spot, the camera on the pad now has access to a wide view of the room, save for the blindspot behind it with the trunk it leans against.

She steps back to create space, and with a tendril of hair stretching out from her spot, she clicks in the tracker bad to start the recording. And not leaving a moment to waste, she begins to speak immediately.

“Okay, I think it’s working...Alright! Assembly of Hordak’s armor number 2! And this time, it’ll be an upgrade!”

She looks over at Hordak still sitting on the floor besides the trunk, and all of a sudden, a pigtail darts out at him and wraps around his waist. In a jolt, he’s yanked up and off the floor to stand right beside her, albeit swaying at the staggering movement. He blinks, trying to orient himself and mask the startled, somewhat flustered expression on his face.

“This is the test subject, Hordak!”

She looks up at him from her spot squished up against his side, locked tight due to the pigtail that holds him securely. And for a moment, all Hordak can do is stare down at her. She’s so close, so warm and pressed tightly against his body, and his mind goes blank at the realization of how suddenly *near* she is.

“Symptoms without armor include general pain in muscles, causing a decrease in the ease of mobility and-“

Entrapta’s words float around him, sounding as if they are spoken underwater, as he tries to focus on them yet fails in doing so. As she babbles on, she doesn’t even seem to notice how close they remain, how tightly she stays pressed against his body. He looks down at her, at her figure with its curves that he’s never truly noticed before but certainly is *now,* and all he can think is how she’s just so *close.* Hordak knows it’s hardly a big deal because they have shared hugs multiple times before, but yet-

“Alright! Now, onto measurements!”

And just like that, she’s gone, jumping away on her pigtails to grab her tape measure. Hordak blinks, startled by the loss of warmth and pressure of her body against his.

Entrapta jumps close, using her pigtails to extend the tape measure across Hordak’s stature. Her eyes scan him up and down as she states to the tech pad, “Hm, still the same height as you were in the Fright Zone, so I can use the same measurements I had recorded before. Width of this arm seems to be-

She drones on and on, hopping around Hordak and taking in measurements. It doesn’t take too long - only a minute or two, as a matter of fact - and before Hordak knows it, Entrapta is standing in front of the track pad, talking about her assembly process and other important details.

“I’ll have to record any issues with the armor in a few weeks time, so I’ll back to update then. But for now, this is Entrapta, signing

off!”

And just like that, with another tendril of hair clicking off the tech pad, the short recording is over.

“See?” Entrapta says as she plops onto the ground, already diving into her supplies to get started. “That wasn’t that bad.”

“I...suppose not.”

With slower movements, Hordak sits down near Entrapta. He begins to look through the supplies, studying all that she has set out to use, and yet…

He finds himself glancing up at her. More times than he’d care to admit, if he were to be honest. She seems lost in her work already, excitement flooding her entire body as she begins to draw at blueprints, ramble on about ideas, and put together pieces.

And through it all, Hordak can’t stop looking at her. He can’t stop studying the way she moves, her expressions, her lively mannerisms. He can’t stop wishing that he were closer again, that he could be by her side once more.

He doesn’t know why. It doesn’t make any sense. He feels just as he did last night when he looked up at her in the bed from his spot on the floor, when all he could think about was how confusing it is that he’s feeling this way.

Ah, well. It isn’t worth dwelling on. He has a project to assist her with, does he not?

And so, finally, he manages to fully tear his eyes away and begin to work.

Chapter End Notes

> right now i really want to reach into the screen and shake hordak while saying, “buddy! you’re in love with her!” but unfortunately, i can’t do that XD

thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always super appreciated! :) (and come say hello on tumblr! i'm beckkii there :D)

Searching

Chapter Notes

> i'm back with an (little longer) update! and once again, it delves a bit more into entrapta's thought processes! i adore writing about her feelings and thoughts, so this chapter touches on that and....another thing :)
>
> anyways, i hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Surprisingly enough, it doesn't take too long to complete the armor.

Perhaps it was because of Hordak's additional aid, the time crunch they were forced in to finish, or simply just because of Entrapta's eagerness to work on it. But regardless of why, the armor is finished within a few hours - a shockingly quick amount of time for such an intricately designed thing.

Hordak leans side-to side, stretching his aching back, as he takes in the sight of the armor laying before him. It's similar in design to the last, though the blue and red tones are darker and more toned down. Even more, every piece of it appears stronger and more finely tuned, and Hordak can't help but study it with awe.

Sure, he certainly *helped,* not nearly as much as Entrapta did. She was essentially the one who created this, as she did the last. And he would forever be grateful.

"Alright, I think that's about it!" Entrapta says, stretching side-to-side as well. Her pigtails lift her body off the ground, and she hovers over the suit with eyes narrowed in suspicion.

"Hmm, well, I might actually need to make an adjustment here," she says as a strand of hair darts out to poke at various points in the armor. "And right here. And here. Right here, too."

"Any minor adjustments can wait, I'm certain," Hordak interjects. "It can always be done in the future. For now, the suit looks well done, Entrapta. I would not worry over any little things."

Entrapta bites her lip, pondering for a moment, before she shakes her head. "Nah, I'd rather do it now. Rather get it fixed now before you complain about it later."

Hordak's eyes narrow as a flash of indignance sparks through him. "I would never complain about your wor-!"

"I'm just teasing you, Hordak," Entrapta giggles as a flash of hair swipes over his lips, shushing him. She tosses him a coy smile, eyes warm, as she turns on her heels and allows her pigtails to swiftly carry her away. Over her shoulder, she adds, "Well, I'll go get the tool I'll need to fix it! I'm pretty sure I left it last in a different room. So, be right back!"

And just like that, with the door shutting behind her with a whoosh, she's gone.

Looks like all Hordak can do is wait for her to get back, then.

He surveys the room for a moment, unsure of what else to do. The floor is now a mess, with various tools and supplies thrown about everywhere, while the armor itself rests in the middle like a prized possession. Well, it certainly is in *his* eyes - to have someone spend so much time and effort to create something for his own well being truly means a lot to him. He'll have to be sure to thank her properly when she returns.

Amidst the scattered supplies, his eye catches sight of the tech pad laying there, now turned off after it was used for digital diagrams as they worked. Hordak peers at it for a moment, curiosity beginning to creep up on him; he knows it holds much of Entrapta's work and data during her time here in space, but to what extent? What sort of things are in there?

Even more, he knows how much she enjoys talking about her research; perhaps he could look through it now and ask her to

talk about it? He can already hear the excitement that would be in her voice, can already see the way that she would smile wide as she talked about all she found.

He hums to himself, debating. Would taking a glance inside be considered a breach of privacy? It's not as if he wants to see anything personal she has stored. Besides, he's almost certain that it only holds work-related data, and he knows how much she loves to share those things with him.

And with those final thoughts in his mind, he reaches over and grabs the tech pad.

It turns on at his touch, and immediately, he's flooded with various folder icons. They are labeled only by increasing number, so following that order, Hordak clicks on each one and takes a peek inside.

He finds them, as expected, to hold the standard content - constellation findings, meteor sightings and their speed/measurement estimates, Darla's codes and possible upgrades, and more. As he clicks through each one, he finds himself smiling at her obvious fascination that's seen in the logs. Many of them are auditory, others are typed out, and some are even visual; but, *all* of them are chocked full of Entrapta's true, unfiltered excitement. It certainly is entertaining to look through.

Finally, he reaches the last folder. Sure enough, as Entrapta had mentioned before, it's full of visual recordings about the space suits she had made for the others. Hordak taps through each log, noticing how there's a video for each person - one for Bow, Glimmer, Adora, Catra, and herself.

And he's just about to tap out of this folder when something catches his eye.

There's another file in here.

He squints his eyes to study the name. Except, there isn't one - the file is left as regular code, as if auto generated by the pad

when she failed to name it.

He quirks a brow, wondering who this log could possibly be for. No one else also had a suit created, right? Even more, all of the other files were named properly. Why is this one not?

He raises a finger to tap on it, only to hesitate. Could this be a file that isn't meant as research? Something personal? Then, why would something personal be in this tech pad? After all, as he had already guessed, nothing in this has been secretive content so far.

Perhaps this is just another log she forgot to name?

And with that thought in mind, Hordak clicks on the file.

The first thing that he realizes is that the video feed is succumbed into darkness. Pure, rich...Wait, no. It's *not* entirely dark. In fact, as the camera adjusts to the lighting, Hordak can make out a shape - a *familiar* shape.

It's Entrapta, sitting down atop the very same bed that's in this room.

A tendril of hair is snaked towards the camera, probably supporting the tech pad up to record herself. And that's when Hordak notices that her entire hair has been let down, no longer in pigtails but instead free-flowing around her, as she sits in a criss-crossed position atop the bed with the covers bunched up at her feet. She seems to be wearing sleepwear as well, for she's dressed only in her white tee, flowy pants, and fuzzy socks.

Is it nighttime, then? Why is she recording a log at nighttime? All the others in this folder were recorded during the day, so why would she-

And that's when Hordak notices her expression amidst the darkness.

It's...distressed.

He inches closer to the screen as questions flood his brain. Is she worried about something? Did something happen? Is this why she's making a log now, of all times?

And through it all, he can't tear his gaze away from her face with downturned lips and averted eyes as she begins to speak.

"Interpersonal relationship dilemma number...19, I believe? Yeah. That's it."

Hordak's heart drops at the sound of her voice, at how oddly *sullen* it is.

"So, in general, today was an eventful day," Entrapta says, her voice a bit more chipper at that statement. She twists her gloved fingers around a strand of hair, continuing, "Adora wanted to rescue Catra from Horde Prime - though, to be honest, I'm not sure why exactly since I *thought* they were enemies. But that's not the point! The point *is,* we went to rescue her. We created a whole entire plan and everything."

She looks down at her lap for a moment, pausing. And when she speaks next, her voice falls to a hushed tone.

"And I had...my own plan."

She shakes her head to herself. "It's stupid, I know, I know. I even promised myself on Beast Island, when he never came for me, that I was going to *forget.* I had to just let him go, you know? It's not... *He's* not...worth it. He never...He never came. So, I just...I had to move on."

She drops her hands then, shoulders sinking in shame.

"But then I made a plan to find him."

Hordak's eyes widen at her words. The plan...to find "him"...

Is *he* the "him?"

"The whole time, I was telling myself to stop," Entrapta says, fists clenching tight in her lap. Her voice is higher now, and it picks up more and more with greater speed with every word she speaks. "I was making lists in my head and crossing off every Horde clone that couldn't be him, I was trying to catch the gaze of all of them to see if they'd remember, I was...I was trying *everything.* "

She shakes her head once more, causing a stray hair strand to fall in her eyes. "And I kept trying to stop and tell myself that it just wasn't worth it, but...but…"

She goes silent for a moment, until suddenly, she digs the palms of her hands into her eyes in a burst of frustration.

"But it was!" she cries out, voice strained. "It *was* worth it! And I know he never came for me, and I know I should be angry, but...I just can't. I can't even move on. It's so stupid, I know it is, and I know I need to forget about him, but I just can't *help* it."

At her words, Hordak's heart clenches tight in his chest. Her voice is awfully pained, and each word and phrase of hers tumbles over each other as if she can't quite get them out fast enough.

"Like, I knew I was already making a mistake when I brought the crystal with me," she says, voice calmed down somewhat. It sounds more disappointed with herself, if anything. "I should've just left it where I found it in the Fright Zone. But no, instead I decided to hold onto it, and then I brought it with me to the Velvet Glove, *knowing* that if I found Hordak, he'd recognize it and remember me. But...I shouldn't have even brought it with me because I'm *trying* to forget, and I *shouldn't* be looking for him."

At that, she wraps her arms across her chest, leaning forward ever-so-slightly. Her pigtails, as well, wrap tighter around her body. Whether this is a conscious thing done by her or simply her body's way of reacting to how she's feeling, Hordak isn't certain.

"But I was. For example, Bow and I entered a room full of clones. And I *tried* to focus on the mission and just *stop* looking for him,

but…”

Her words trail off at that, and she looks to the ground, a deep frown set on her lips.

“...But then I saw a clone. A *confused* looking clone, too. One that looked as if it didn’t belong, as if this wasn’t where it was supposed to be. And...And immediately, I couldn’t help but think…”

Her hair curls in tighter around herself.

“‘That must be him.’”

Entrapta sighs. “And I couldn’t help it but go after him, to show him the crystal. It turned out to *not* be him, but...I was *so* hopeful. I was *so* excited at the idea of that being Hordak and that he’d maybe remember me. And that...that makes me so…so *angry* at myself, because I’m-“

Her voice sharply stops, and she swallows for a moment. Only then does Hordak notice the shine in her ruby eyes, faintly picked up by the pad’s camera.

“I’m supposed to forget about him!” she cries out, hair frizzing a bit at her words. “But I just *can’t!”*

She goes quiet for a moment, and all Hordak can do is stare at her through the screen, his body frozen and grip tight on the pad. His mind whirs with questions, feeling a burning sadness at the sight of her so distraught and having sheer curiosity at what else she has to say. After all, they had hardly any time to talk about all that occurred between the two of them since they got separated, and to hear her talk about her experiences regarding him so *openly* on this recording leaves him clinging onto every word she says.

“It’s strange,” Entrapta finally pipes up, her voice low and weak. “I had never been like this with someone else before. When the princesses, for example, had left me behind, it didn’t sting *nearly*

as much. Same with Catra and Scorpia when they left me on Beast Island. But...with *him…"*

She brings a gloved hand up to her eyes, rubbing away any tears that had sprung up. She heaves a shuddering sigh, and her hair loosens around her as she releases the pent-up energy.

"...It's different, somehow. And now I'm left here confused because even though I'm upset at how I had kept trying to find him on the Velvet Glove, I *still* want to look for him. And I wish so badly that I *had* found him," she says.

She picks up a strand of hair once more, and her gloved fingers begin to rake through it in a self-soothing motion. And when she finally speaks back up, her voice is hardly above a whisper and barely audible through the screen.

"I miss him."

Hordak's heart stops, ears falling.

"I miss him so much," she adds, voice shaky. "I can't get him out of my mind. And this is why it's a dilemma - it doesn't make *sense.* What makes him different from others to me? Why does he matter so much?"

She pauses, looking to the side. "Well, factually speaking, I *have* done much research on interpersonal relationships, and every fact and piece of data from Hordak's and our relationship seems to point to one conclusion. I've already come to it awhile ago, even before all this. That's why I made the crystal for his armor the way I did."

Hordak's ears perk up, and he leans in closer to the pad, intrigued.

"But...I thought...It's possible to fall out of it, isn't I? That's what research says, and data *never* lies. So, I know it's in the realm of possibility. People fall out of it all the time. But then...Why can't I…? A-And I'm *trying* to, but…"

She pauses, her brow furrowing in confusion.

“No matter how hard I try, why can’t I stop lo-“

“Entrapta?”

All of a sudden, before Entrapta has the chance to finish whatever she had to say, a new voice cuts in through the feed. She jumps up in bed as her hair frizzes around her, evidently caught off guard, before she looks up with wide eyes. Based on where she’s looking and the faint stream of pale light that enters the room, the voice must’ve come from someone standing in the doorway.

“Are you alright?” the voice continues, and immediately, Hordak recognizes it - it’s Bow’s voice.

“I heard you through the walls,” Bow adds. “You sounded kinda upset.”

For a split second, Hordak catches the exact moment Entrapta is stumped on how to respond. However, immediately, any hesitation on her features washes away, and she replaces it with a cheery smile.

“Oh, I’m alright! Just making a log of all the interesting data I found today. But, then I started talking about Wrong Hordak, and that obviously makes me feel sad *for* him, so…”

“Ah, yeah, I understand. Just wanted to check in,” Bow says, completely oblivious to her lie.

“Thanks, Bow, I appreciate it!”

“Yeah, anytime,” he says. “Make sure to get some sleep though, alright? It’s pretty late.”

“I will, don’t worry!”

“Alright, well, I’ll let you be then. Goodnight, Entrapta.”

"G'night!" she beams back, voice awfully chipper.

And just like that, Bow is gone, and Entrapta's smile falls away.

She looks to the camera for a second, mouth open as if ready to speak but clearly hesitating. In the end, all she does is sigh and do a little shake of her head once more. A flash of hair reaches out, and with that, the video ends.

And Hordak is left staring back at his shocked expression through the blank screen.

He furrows his brow, questions already piling up in his mind. She was looking for Hordak? Back in the Velvet Glove? How had Hordak never seen her, memory-wiped or not? Is that how the crystal ended up on the floor that he was able to pick up? Speaking of the crystal, what did she mean when she said 'that's why I made the crystal the way I did'?

And *what* was she going to say before Bow interrupted?

The questions swirl around him, overwhelming and intriguing him all the same. All the while, he simply stares at his reflection in the tech pad, trying to settle and answer the questions yet failing in doing so.

But all of a sudden, through the clutter of thoughts in his mind, he picks up on the sound of footsteps from outside the room.

Entrapta's coming back.

Immediately, he tosses the pad away. His initial goal of this whole thing was to now be able to talk with her about her findings of space, to be able to let her explain how she made the space suits, to allow her to talk about Darla. But now, if he were to bring up the tech pad with her, he's certain she'd know that he had found that video - a video he's certain he was *not* supposed to see.

He scoots away from the pad, as if further proving that he was not at *all* interacting with it, just as Entrapta enters the room.

“Found the tool!” she exclaims. The door shuts behind her with a whoosh, and with the use of her pigtails, she propels over to where Hordak is sitting within seconds. “Sorry that took so long. It was hiding somewhere in one of the compartments.”

“No worries, Entrapta,” Hordak says, trying to keep his tone as even as possible.

He seems to have succeeded, for Entrapta doesn't question him. Instead, she whips over to where the armor lays on the ground, now hovering over it with her hands on her hips.

“Alright, let’s try this out! We don’t have anything robotic to help you get it on, so…” she says, looking towards him, “...Would you like me to help you?”

Hordak freezes at first, unsure of how to respond. Of *course* he need help - his muscles currently ache, and any sharp movements on his own to put the pieces together would surely strain him further.

Yet...How pathetic would that be of him to need her aid? He already feels pathetic enough when he needs robotics to get his armor on, but needing *Entrapta?* The thought of it makes him feel like a fool, feel ridiculous, feel-

“I’m gonna take your silence as a ‘yes,’ then,” Entrapta says with an understanding smile graced on her lips, cutting his thoughts off.

Hordak simply stares back at first, failing to respond. Yet, at the utter sympathy shining in her eyes, he starts to feel a *bit* better about the whole thing.

“...I...Yes. I need some assistance.”

“Let’s get started then! No time better than the present!”

With that said, Hordak strips himself of the white robe he wore on the Velvet Glove, leaving him only in an underdress that still

covers most of his body. Immediately, Entrapta gets straight to work, using her pigtails to swiftly aid him on putting on the armor. Thankfully, the whole process goes by very smoothly and in little time, as well.

So before long, Hordak is finally dressed in armor once more.

He looks down at his arms, his chest, his legs, carefully flexing every muscle all the while and feeling a smile creep up on his face. It still has yet to be powered by the crystal that now rests in his discarded white robe pocket, but despite that, it still feels so *right* on his body. It feels just like the last armor that Entrapta made for him, which, by his standards, felt perfect. He also takes special note of how his neck port is still, thankfully, protected.

"How is it? Do you like it?" Entrapta says, hovering on her pigtails up to Hordak's height and gazing at him with eager eyes.

Hordak smiles - a full smile, this time - and looks up at her.

"It turned out great, Entrapta. Thank you."

She beams, clenched fists shaking side-to-side by her face and legs kicking a bit in the air. Without a moment to waste, she lunges herself down to dig the crystal out of the discarded robe pocket. Once she gets her hands on it, she lifts herself back up to eye level with Hordak and holds it before the slot on his chest.

"And now, the final part!"

With that said, she carefully inserts the crystal with a click. And just like that, the armor comes to life on his body, now working to support him. Relief washes over his fatigued muscles, and all he can do is look at Entrapta and smile once more.

"Is it good? Does it work?" She asks, eyes wide and sparkling in anticipation.

Hordak nods, immediately taking note of how much better even that simple motion feels now. "It works perfectly fine. Do not

worry."

She squeals at that, and on instinct, Hordak can't help but smile once more. Her happiness truly is infectious.

"Oh, that's great!" she exclaims, lowering herself a bit on her pigtails to hover around Hordak's body and inspect all other aspects of his armor now that it's on him. "Let me just check everything and make those minor adjustments, and then we should be good to go!"

As Entrapta hovers around him with her one tool in hand, eyes narrowed and tongue sticking out deep in thought, Hordak watches with amusement. Naturally, having someone study his body so intensely - whether for scientific reasons or not - would feel awfully invasive. Yet...with this new armor on and with *her* doing the looking...

He doesn't mind. Not at all, in fact. After all, he finds that this armor - as was the last - is shaped to display his best qualities; well, at least the qualities *he* always found appealing, where no scars or damaged skin appear. Why he's particularly okay with Entrapta doing the looking, he isn't certain, yet-

All of a sudden, at that thought, Hordak recalls the recording he had watched on the tech pad.

"What makes him different from others to me?"

That's what Entrapta had said, and her question still burns into Hordak's brain, refusing to singe away. And not only that question appears in his mind, but also all of the *other* questions he had formed as he listened to the recording.

Now, as he watches Entrapta study the armor on his body, he can't help but dwell on all that she had said. She was angry at him, yet also missed him. She was frustrated with herself, yet she couldn't help it. She was seemingly confused with something about her and Hordak's relationship, yet she seemed to know deep down what the conclusion to that 'something' was.

And she had *looked* for him. It all started with that fact. Unbeknownst to Hordak, she had gone around, searching for him everywhere. Despite how she felt after all that occurred, despite the fact that she wished *not to,* she still *cared* . For what reason, Hordak can't understand, but she *did.*

So before Hordak even has the chance to think it through, words begin to tumble out.

"Entrapta, you...visited the Velvet Glove, correct? During your time of space travel?"

"Hm?" she says absentmindedly, clearly absorbed in her work that's now focused on his right leg. "The Velvet Glove? Yeah, I did. Why?"

"Did you...look? For me?"

Entrapta freezes.

"I…"

She looks up at him, stunned into silence once more. Slowly, her pigtails raise her back up to eye level, though almost immediately, she looks away. It's only for a second, as if hesitating on what she's going to say next. But finally, when she finally brings her gaze back to lock with Hordak's, she speaks up in soft tone.

"...I did. I looked everywhere. I....I needed to find you."

Hordak's heart stops in his chest. Whether it's because of her words, the way she holds eye contact, the rare softness in her tone, or a combination of all three, he isn't certain.

"Despite how you thought back then that I had abandoned you?" Hordak asks, his tone incredulous. "Why would you still look for me?"

Her eyes widen for a moment before tumbling to the floor.

"I...Hordak, I told you before. You mean a lot to me. I couldn't just...forget about you. I wanted to find you, and I hoped that I'd be lucky enough to have you remember me, too."

At that, she brings a hand up, resting it lightly on his chest with her fingers dusting over the top of the crystal. "That's why I brought this with me to help. I knew that, if you *had* forgotten me, maybe this would help you remember."

"It did," Hordak cuts in.

Entrapta's eyes dart up to meet his.

"Huh? Really?"

"Yes, it did. This was even before we had seen each other that one time on Etheria," Hordak says. "This was during my time on the Velvet Glove. I had found the crystal on the ground, and…"

Even now, he can see the exact moment in his head when he had found it, clear as day. And he can recall all that he felt, looking at that crystal in his hands - flashes of warm emotions that coursed through him, remembrance of lavender hair and the sound of high-pitched laughter, recollection of a *name.*

Entrapta.

"I remembered you, and your name, as well. It was not much, but…" his words trail off for a moment before he adds, "...It was enough to be considered straying away from my programming and to kickstart memories that should've been fully wiped."

Entrapta stares at him, expression unreadable save for the shock hidden in her eyes. They then crinkle into something warm, something fond, and a soft smile makes way on her lips. Her palm presses more firm against his chest, causing his heart to stutter, as she inches closer.

"I...Even after all the memory altercations…" she says, not finishing her sentence but instead opting to only smile at him, her

face mere inches away.

That last realization hits Hordak like a truck.

She's so *close.*

It's true - in that moment, Hordak comes increasingly aware of her body nearly pressed against his, at her hand resting firmly on his chest, at her pigtails inching her closer and closer. Her face is right before his, and Hordak's ears fall flat as he tries to maintain eye contact with her vibrant eyes.

But suddenly, she giggles.

"What-?"

"Your ears are so cute when they do that, you know," Entrapta says, giggling between words. She brings a gloved hand up and gently rubs it, and immediately, hot blush burns into Hordak's face as his entire body freezes. Not out of fear or another or a bad reason - not at all.

"Aww, even your ears get some blush on them, too," she muses, smile widening even more as studies Hordak's ears. By now, her entire body is pressed into his, and he can feel her heartbeat in her chest as it beats against his own - well, beats probably isn't the best term to describe it. *Pounding* is more suited.

"Entrapta-" Hordak manages to get out before his voice cuts off, uncertain of what else to say.

At that, she tears her attention away from his ears and meets his eyes. Her own are now half-lidded, staring at him with their vibrant color that he can't seem to tear his attention away from. All the while, her body remains pressed against him, her one hand stays on his chest, and her other - the one that once rubbed his ear - now slides down to lightly rest on the side of his neck.

And all Hordak can do is stare at her, his heart all but about to burst from his chest. Her face is *right* before his, and some part of

Hordak becomes aware of what this could mean while the other part of him refuses to actually believe it.

He knows what kissing is - he had accidentally caught many of his soldiers in the act over the years - and this...this seems to be…

But, she wouldn't. She would never with him. They...They're *friends,* not…Not...

"Hordak…" Entrapta says, her voice low and smooth in a way he's never heard before. He shivers at the tone, eyes never tearing away from her own, body never pulling back. He watches as she looks down at his lips, back up again, and then back down at his lips.

She leans in. Even closer.

And then-

The lights shut off.

In a panic, they both pull away, eyes wide and darting about at the sudden interruption. They're left only in dead silence for a long moment as nothing but rich darkness floods the room.

Until, out of nowhere, Darla's voice cuts in from somewhere above.

"Some of my systems seemed to have failed due to the lack of updates. This includes lighting, water, and navigation tools."

Entrapta appears confused at first, until suddenly, she lightly smacks her hand on her forehead. "Oh, yeah, Darla's updates. Shoot, I completely forgot."

With a sheepish smile, she then looks up at Hordak.

"Uh...Guess I should go do them, huh?"

Hordak swallows, nodding carefully in fear that even that small motion would cause his now-shaky legs to fully collapse.

"You...Yes, you probably should," is all he manages to get out.

She looks to the door for a moment, clearly hesitant. However, her pigtails finally lower her back down to the ground to stand on two feet once more, and she takes a step towards the door.

"Yeah, uh...Yeah. I should," she says, and even in the dark, Hordak catches sight of the burning blush on her cheeks.

At that, she begins to fully walk away. By the time she reaches the door and it opens with a whoosh, she looks over her shoulder at Hordak and tosses him a wide smile that appears somewhat...shaken.

"Um, well, when I finish, we should probably get going! It's probably close to sunset soon," she says. "I'll be back ASAP to help pack up the tools and grab my tech pad before we head out! Alright?"

Hordak nods in response, all words seeming to have left him. So, with that, Entrapta disappears in a flash out the door.

And Hordak is left standing there, his heart still thundering in his ears and nerves still shaken, as he tries to collect himself.

Because what on *Etheria* had just happened?

Chapter End Notes

> i kind of wanted to make hordak completely oblivious to the concept of kissing, just to make his reaction to everything in this more amusing and startled, but, i went with realism since i feel like he'd know about it after all those years on etheria. so, instead we get to have our space bat be completely aware, just incredibly awkward XD

anyways, thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always super appreciated! (and come say hi on tumblr! i'm beckkii over there)

Last Time

Chapter Notes

looks like we're back again with the main group in this chapter! hordak and entrapta are my favorite characters, but i still love writing about the other ones, too :)

actually, i wrote this whole chapter with a whole other section to it where adora, bow, catra, and glimmer are talking with each other about...something. i decided to cut it out of this chapter since i didn't want it to be too long, but since i still want to include it, i'm gonna post it as its own chapter in the middle of the week! it's pretty short and already finished, after all

alright, anyways, i hope you enjoy! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time they reach Bright Moon's courtyard, the sun has begun to make its way down the sky, basking Etheria in a dim golden hue. It seems that they've made it back just in time - right around sunset.

Standing by the entrance besides Entrapta, the first thing Hordak notices is the roaring fireplace amidst the princesses and others. Even more, four large logs have been placed down around it in a misshapen square, acting as a makeshift seating arrangement. Various princesses have already sat down atop it and are beginning to converse, and through everything, everyone seems oblivious to Hordak and Entrapta's presence.

Hordak first catches sight of Perfuma and Scorpia close together on one log. The young ice princess sits next to them as well, and the horse lays down besides the log. Catra and Adora take up space on the log across of them, scooched up close with Catra's head resting on Adora's shoulder. On the log adjecent to them,

Mermista and the pirate - Seahawk, correct? - sit side-by-side. That leaves Bow, Glimmer, and the king left, who all are absent.

Until…

"I've got the food!"

Glimmer's voice rings loud into the courtyard as the castle doors burst open, revealing her and Bow both holding trays of hot chocolate supplies and sandwiches. They race over to the others congregated around the fireplace, and at the sight of them and the food, everyone immediately cheers.

And that's when Hordak notices that Entrapta is smiling as well, her eyes locked on the tray.

"Oh! Oh! Tiny cups! And there's some tiny sandwiches, too!" Entrapta squeals, both hands on her cheeks and eyes sparkling in glee.

At the sound of her voice, Glimmer looks up and waves. "Hey, glad to see you back. Hope your trip went well."

She beams, "Yes, it did!"

Glimmer's eyes then dart towards Hordak, and in a flash, they widen. It's only for a moment; if Hordak had blinked, he would've missed it. However, almost immediately, she goes back to whatever she was doing, tearing her eyes away and beginning to pass out food amongst the group.

"My dad is out for the next few days to make sure everyone in the camps all over Etheria are doing well," Glimmer explains as she rounds the campfire with Bow, stopping before every pair to offer them food. "So, he won't be here to eat with us."

"That's a shame," Scorpia says as she takes a bite of her sandwich. She takes a swig of hot chocolate before adding, "This stuff is so good!"

Hordak ignores their little conversation, instead quirking a brow at what happened prior with Glimmer. Why did she stare at him like that? What could have caught her attention? Does he look-

That's when it hits him.

She had noticed the armor he's now wearing.

The armor that, earlier this morning, stirred up tension between him and the princesses.

The armor that he probably should *not* be wearing.

And he's just about to speak out about it when a different voice cuts in through the air.

"So...You got armor."

Hordak freezes at the voice.

It's Mermista's.

He looks over, finding her staring directly at him. However, oddly enough, there doesn't seem to be any malice hidden in her eyes. They only study him, waiting for an answer from her statement, which was simply that - a statement. Not a patronizing question, not a bitter remark, none of that. Just a statement.

"Indeed," Hordak says, voice low. Unsure of what else to add, he glances away, staring absentmindedly at the grass.

"That's...Yeah," she says. "I see that."

The air falls quiet around them, heavy and uncomfortable. Tension clings to them, and Hordak shifts a bit in place, itching to just leave but knowing he's truly trapped here for Entrapta's sake.

"So, uh…Entrapta, you must've made it for him, huh?
That's...really nice of you!"

Hordak glances up at the sound of another familiar voice. It's Scorpia, smiling hesitantly at Entrapta but with genuine kindness nonetheless.

Entrapta beams back, oblivious to the tension at the mention of her work. "Oh, it's no big deal. Since all of my supplies were on Darla, I had an excuse to introduce Hordak to her! And-" she pauses, wrapping a limb of hair around a stunned Hordak for a moment and squeezing, "-he helped, so making it was a piece of cake!"

"Worked together on Darla, huh?" Scorpia repeats. "That must've been nice. I'm sure you guys missed doing stuff like that since you two...well...haven't been able to work together for a while."

"Ugh, tell me about it," Catra's voice cuts in with a groan. "I mean, not the whole "working" together thing, but the whole…" *being"* together stuff. You know. After so much time being apart."

At her words, Adora looks over at Catra with a fond gaze, and a soft smile forms on her face. "Aww, you mean with me?"

"No, I mean with Hordak-...Of *course* I mean you, dummy!"

They both giggle a bit then, eyes gentle and grins warm at each other. Catra's ears dip and blush covers her cheeks, Adora's as well, and they lean in close. And without another moment passing, Adora closes the gap between them to share a short kiss, light laughter still on their lips all the while.

Hordak's eyes widen at the sight, and a burst of jealousy sparks in his gut. Not because of *them* sharing a kiss *,* of course, but because they're just so... *openly* affectionate with each other. No hesitation, no fears of rejection, *none* of that.

He tears his eyes away.

"Ugh, can't relate," Mermista groans between swigs of hot chocolate. "Seahawk never leaves me alone. I *wish* I could get a moment away from him."

At that, Seahawk scooches in closer, wrapping an arm around Mermista. She immediately blushes, looking to him with wide eyes.

"Ah, but I know you would miss me!"

"No, I wouldn't…"

However, as she says those words, her eyes tumble to the ground and a small, genuine smile lights up her face. She glances back up at him, and they share fond gazes, pressed side-by-side together on the log with Mermista tucked under Seahawk's wing.

And all Hordak can do is look away at the ground, trying his best to *not* let jealousy and bitterness spur up further within him at the sight of these stupid princesses and their stupid happiness and their stupid open affection around him.

"Are you gonna join us?"

Hordak glances up at Glimmer's words, finding her and Bow now idly standing by the edge of the fireplace, trays of food still in hand. As she speaks, Glimmer's eyes are directed towards Entrapta, leaving Hordak unsure if she's addressing *both* of them or just Entrapta in regards to joining them.

Honestly, he hopes it's just Entrapta. Because, if he were to be honest, he'd rather turn in for the night. While a big reason for that is fatigue, for he'd rather just spend time resting up in his room instead of stuck around all of these princesses for the evening, it's not only that.

For starters, he's not welcome among everyone here. He knows that. And...even more…

The trial is tomorrow. The trial that determines his fate.

Determined by all of these princesses that now sit before him.

Given all that...He'd rather just be alone.

“Yeah, of course!” Entrapta says to Glimmer. She turns to Hordak, adding, “Come on, let’s-“

“I, uh, might go, Entrapta,” Hordak cuts her off. He looks away towards Bright Moon, shifting side-to-side. “If that is alright with you.”

He looks down at Entrapta then, and he immediately regrets it, for the sight causes his heart to sink. Her eyes are crinkled in sadness, lips downturned, and she glances away the moment their eyes meet.

“But, Hordak, you can-“

“Why don’t you enjoy spending time yourself with them?” Hordak suggests, tone soft. “Don’t worry - I’ll be fine alone until you come back.”

Entrapta is silent for a moment, instead moving to grab a strand of hair and begin to run her hands through it, biting her lip all the while. She seems to mull it over in her mind, until finally, she sighs and drops her shoulders in defeat.

“Alright. But…”

A strand of hair darts out towards Glimmer’s tray of sandwiches, snatching one out of them. She brings it back to her before lifting it up to Hordak, almost as if presenting a gift.

“...Can you at least take this to eat? If you’re not gonna stay for dinner?”

Hordak studies the sandwich. It does look... appetizing, he has to admit. He pauses, looking to the crowd of princesses who all have gone back to talking amongst themselves and oblivious to Hordak and Entrapta’s conversation, before looking back down at Entrapta’s hopeful gaze.

In the end, he sighs.

“Alright.”

He takes the sandwich, offering Entrapta a small smile in return.

“Thank you.”

At his words, she beams, her smile lighting up her face. And just like that, without another word, her pigtails carry away towards the fireplace in search of a spot to sit, and Hordak is left alone once more.

He starts to make his way towards Bright Moon’s front doors, keeping his gaze locked on the ground in hopes to ignore anyone’s eyes on him. There doesn’t seem to be any - everyone is too engrossed in their own conversations to care where he goes. It does strike him as kind of odd - isn’t he supposed to be on watch? These princesses certainly have lackluster security here.

Before he enters the castle, he takes one last glance at the group. His eyes land on Entrapta, who seems to already have found someone to converse with - Scorpia. They laugh amongst each other, Entrapta’s hair frizzing up a bit as she laughs loudly and Scorpia’s gaze fond as she looks down upon her.

Hordak can’t help but smile. Entrapta deserves this, doesn't she? She deserves a night to feel included, to feel happy with the princesses.

Especially with... *Tomorrow…*

Hordak shakes his head, trying to clear his thoughts, before he enters Bright Moon to spend his evening alone.

~~~

He should be able to sleep.

After all, Entrapta practically forced him to sleep in the bed tonight instead of that measly sleeping bag.

He pulls the large blankets up higher around his body and rolls onto his side, allowing his head to further sink into the mountain of pillows. It truly *is* comfortable - much nicer than the sleeping bag was - and some guilty part of him regrets not taking up Entrapta's offer sooner. That might've helped save him any muscle pain.

Regardless, he's here now, and he's truly grateful. He peers over the edge of the bed, looking down at Entrapta's small figure in the sleeping bag, and a pang of guilt stabs him in the chest. She must be uncomfortable; though, he has no real way to tell, for she's turned away from him and curled up around herself.

Some part of him wants to ask her to switch for her sake, despite how much he doesn't want to get up, despite how he's comfortable in the bed. But, either way, he *knows* he'll be met with the same arguments from before - "I'm telling you, I've slept in *vents* before, so I'll be fine" and "I had the bed last night, so it's only fair" and " *Hordak,* if you don't get in the bed, I'll physically use my hair to throw you in it myself."

So, here he is. Comfortable and warm in bed. In optimal position to sleep.

And he just *can't.*

Truthfully, he's not surprised. Try as he might to ignore the looming fact all day, try as he might to instead just focus on the *now,* he knows what tomorrow morning brings. No more delay, no more awkward meals around princesses, no more pretending he's an accepted member among them.

He has the trial tomorrow.

He rolls back over on his back, gazing at the ceiling with empty, half-lidded eyes. He's been doing this for almost an *hour* now - ever since Entrapta finally came back from the courtyard and they decided to turn the lights off to sleep - and frustration slowly

builds in his gut the longer he can't sleep. At *what,* exactly, he's frustrated at, he isn't sure.

His body for betraying him? The trial tomorrow? The princesses? Himself?

He has no clue. All he knows is that it's *frustrating.*

Honestly, he just wishes it would be morning already to get this over with. Rather that than laying here in this too-comfortable bed, acting as if he isn't on his way to receive a death sentence, sent away forever from civilization to rot, or who *knows* what.

And that's the worst part.

He doesn't know what to expect.

He's certain he'll be punished, that's for certain. But...In what way? Will it be painful? A simple execution? Will…

He looks down at Entrapta, still curled up and a large pigtail shielding her face from him.

...Will he never be able to see her again?

That realization, out of all things, is what fears him the most. And the worst part is, that's almost an absolute certainty - no matter what the trial holds, no matter what they decide to do to him, it's practically *certain* he'll be forced to stay away from her. Whether it's due to death or being sent away to some isolated island or something else, he *knows* he'll have to leave her.

The thought brings a wave of nausea over him, and he turns away, looking at the ceiling once more.

Ugh, how he wishes he could just *sleep.*

He shuts his eyes once more, trying to think of mindless things. Think of...the Fright Zone. How *is* the Fright Zone doing, anyway? Is it left uninhabited? He has no clue.

Maybe he could think about...hm, his time as ruler over the Fright Zone? Or perhaps he could think of the Velvet Glove and Horde Pr-

Hordak grimaces. No, no, he doesn't want to think about him. Not at all.

Perhaps he could focus on the sound of wind outside? It's faint, but through the windows, his ears can pick up on the white noise. He focuses entirely on it, trying to think of nothing else. Various other thoughts pop into his head, but he shuts all of them down, focusing on the wind and only the wind to help him-

A new noise cuts through the air.

Hordak twitches a bit in shock, stunned out of whatever light sleep he had fallen into. His ear flicks up, curious at the new sound that drones on and on. Only then does he realize that it must've been going on for some time now.

He blinks his eyes open, gaze darting about the room in search of the source. Only, there's nothing - nothing in *here,* anyway. It must be coming from outsi-

Movement catches the corner of his eye.

Carefully, he shifts up in place, looking down in the direction of the movement. It's coming from Entrapta's little area on the floor, and as his vision adjusts better to the darkness, that's when he realizes *what,* specifically, is moving.

It's Entrapta's gloved hands, raking frantically through her hair that flops around her on the sleeping bag. Each time she rakes through her hair, the back of her glove rubs against the sleeping bag's material, generating the noise.

He squints in confusion. Is she awake, even at this hour? She has to be. Though, her body is still turned away, so he can't be for certain. Unless…

“Entrapta?” he whispers.

She jumps a little in place, stunned out of her movements. Her body whips over in the sleeping bag to face him, eyes wide and hands pulled back from her hair as if guilty at being caught.

“Huh?”

“Are you alright?” Hordak asks, leaning forward nearer the edge of the bed.

Entrapta only stares for a moment, blankly, until a small frown tugs at the corners of her lips. She looks away, and subconsciously, her hands begin to rake through her hair once more.

“Yeah, just...can’t sleep,” is all she says. A tendril of hair reaches up to the top of her head, looking for her mask to flick down, only to find it absent and instead resting beside her sleeping bag on the floor. Instead, she just turns her face away further, shaking her head.

“I’m...worried. About tomorrow. With the trial.”

At the frailty in her soft voice, a pang of sadness shoots through Hordak. His eyes crinkle as he looks down at her - her body which is still turned away from her as she so often does in vulnerable moments.

“And normally, right now, I’d try to get my mind off things by going to my lab,” she says, voice shaky. “Working on robots and new tech always helps me, you know? But we’re not in Dryl, and I can’t do that, and everything here is so unfamiliar, and…”

She shakes her head, a bit more violently this time, as she draws back her hands from her hair once more.

“Ah, I hate all this. It’s just...stressful. Everything is so unpredictable and...a-and I hate it. And with the trial tomorrow…”

Entrapta finally turns to look to him, eyes soft and dim in the pale moonlight.

"I'm really worried," she finishes, voice hardly a whisper.

Hordak's ears flick down, his frown deepening. He looks down at the floor over the edge of the bed, trying to gather his thoughts but failing badly in doing so. They're a mess, sprawled out in his mind like a scattered puzzle, and he can't seem to connect them in their rightful places.

He knows he should say something reassuring. Something positive. Something that will give them hope for whatever tomorrow has in store for them.

But all he can think is that this might be the last night he has with her.

At least for a while.

He looks up, vision a little blurry and eyes suddenly sprung with warmth as he looks down at Entrapta. He blinks it away, willing himself to be stoic. But, the longer he looks at her, and the longer she stares back with mournful eyes, the worse it gets. A lump forms in his throat, and he turns away, focusing his attention out the window instead.

The shimmering stars stare down at him, almost as if they're mocking him. After all, it was Entrapta's biggest dream to see the stars up close, and he never even got the chance to take her himself. He'll never be able to see her wide smile at the sight of the galaxy before her, to see her astonishment as she revels in it, to see...to see..

"After everything, should we finally go to space?"

Hordak's words shock even himself as he speaks out. They came seemingly out of nowhere, out of some deep longing within him, but here they now are, spoken aloud for Entrapta to hear.

“Huh?”

“You talked about space. Back when we first reunited after the war,” Hordak continues, eyes locked on the stars. “You offered to make me a space suit, and you said that we should go together.”

Entrapta is silent for a long moment.

“Yeah,” she finally says, her voice still shaky. “Yeah. I remember. Do...Do you still want to? To go?”

“...I do.”

Finally, Hordak gains the will to turn his eyes away from the stars, looking back down at Entrapta once more. Her eyes shimmer in the moonlight, the rest of her body dressed in the pale color, and she smiles. Only a little.

Yet, it’s the warmest he’s ever seen.

“Then, it’s a promise,” Entrapta says, eyes crinkling at the corners with her smile. However, it falters a bit then, her lips trembling ever so slightly. Nonetheless, the grin sticks to her face, withstanding.

Hordak smiles as well, though he knows it’s equally as weak. He isn’t sure how to manage anything else.

“Indeed,” he reaffirms.

At that, Entrapta lays fully back down, this time facing Hordak. She shuts her eyes then, heaving a shaky sigh, and Hordak is certain she’s about to go to sleep when something moves. It’s the pigtail she was combing her hands through before, now snaking out from around her body and reaching out to Hordak on the bed. It hovers in front of his hand, waiting there like an open invitation.

He takes it, movements careful to not hurt her, and holds it gently. It curls around his palm for security, and Hordak’s eyes go wide

with wonder. Then, on instinct, he begins to rake his fingers through it, reveling in the softness of it.

He knows, as he lazily runs his hands through her hair, that Entrapta had said before that people have pulled at it. That people have used it as a way to hurt her, to gain control of her. He had even seen it firsthand back on the Velvet Glove - back when Prime had captured her and he had yet to have his memory restored. Prime yanked on her hair, holding her up with it despite how much she yelped out in pain-

But here it is now, looped in his hands. Trusting him. The corners of Hordak's lips quirk up at the realization, but it forms a sad smile, his ears flicked down and heart beating painfully in his heart.

He can't lose this. He can't lose *her.* He doesn't know what he'd do.

All of a sudden, a light snore sounds in the bedroom. Hordak glances over the bed to find Entrapta now asleep, drooling onto her pillow.

The smile fades at the sight, this time replaced with a true frown as sadness consumes his thoughts. He shakes his head to himself, as if clearing his thoughts through the motion, before he relaxes fully in the bed and shuts his eyes.

He keeps a loose hold on the hair all the while, unwilling to let go.

For he realizes, as he starts to drift asleep, that he might not be able to feel some part of her so close ever again.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always super appreciated <3

(and come say hello on tumblr! i'm beckkii there :))

Discovery

Chapter Notes

> hey, a midweek update! this is pretty short, and it was supposed to be part of the last chapter, but i didn't want to make that chapter too long. so, here it is as it's own little piece! it's pretty important to the trial, so i wanted to fit it in beforehand
>
> next update will still be this weekend, as usual! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Thanks for the help, guys."

Adora glances up from her spot on the grass to see if Bow, Glimmer, or Catra had heard her sarcastic remark. Only to find that, no, they hadn't, for they continue to laugh amongst themselves by the dying fire. Knowing them, she's aware that they probably *had* heard her, only to completely ignore her instead.

"Really having fun down here," Adora continues, picking up another empty cup left from beside a log. "Alone. Cleaning up everything. Without any help."

At that, Catra's ears finally perk up. She glances over from her spot lazily lounged atop a log, tossing Adora an amused smile that seems somewhat...mischievous, Adora realizes. She picks a nearby napkin off the ground and, with her smiling growling all the while, flings it in her direction. It lands at Adora's feet several inches away.

"Here you go," Catra sneers, tone laced with amused sarcasm. "Is that helpful?"

Adora only glares at her, gaze narrowed and empty. She rolls her eyes before snatching the napkin off the ground, stuffing it into

the trash bag she brought along with her and grumbling under her breath.

Further ignoring the laughs of her friends around her, Adora now moves over behind the log. It's darker on this side, for it's absent of the fire's light, but she can still make out-

Something cold touches her hand.

She freezes, eyes wide in shock, before patting down the area again to confirm that *yes,* something cold is there - something both cold *and* smooth. She grasps onto it, rounding back over the log to sit on it facing the fire and bringing the object in hand towards the light.

It's...a tech pad.

"Hey, someone must've left this behind," Adora announces.

Now suddenly seeming to hear her, her friends all round over to where she's sitting on the log, with Bow and Glimmer plopping on either side of her and Catra leaning behind her on her shoulder. With everyone watching, Adora taps it on, and the tech pad comes to life.

"It's probably Entrapta's," Bow says. "I'm the only other one I know who's got a tech pad, and I left mine in my room."

Adora clicks through it, glancing through the files and taking quick peaks inside at the content. Sure enough, it's full of information on space, Darla, suits, and more. *Definitely* the sort of thing Entrapta would record in here.

"Huh. Well, I'll just hold onto it for her until tomorrow," Adora suggests. "I don't wanna bother her in her room right now only to-"

"Hey, what's that?"

She glances down at where Glimmer is pointing on the screen - a file stashed in the last folder Adora had clicked onto, labeled "Hordak Armor Ver. 2."

Adora shrugs. "Uh...I dunno. Probably something to do with that armor she made for him. That's my best guess."

"Huh…"

Glimmer word fades into nothingness as she hesitates for a moment, her finger still hovering over the file. And immediately, it clicks in Adora's head on what Glimmer wants to do - she wants to look at it and see into Hordak and Entrapta's personal lives, specifically from what occurred while they were away today. That's obviously when she made him the new armor, after all, and this file seems to be about that.

But, wouldn't looking at it be an invasion of priva-

Adora doesn't even have a chance to finish that thought, for Glimmer has clicked on the file, and Entrapta's voice surrounds them.

"Okay, I think it's working...Alright! Assembly of Hordak's armor number 2! And this time, it'll be an upgrade!"

Entrapta stands proudly within her quarters back on Darla, the room seeming just as it had all that time ago when they last were on it. Adora quirks a brow, expecting Hordak to be somewhere in the vicinity, only to find him nowhere.

However, the confusion doesn't last long. For all of a sudden, with a whip of hair darting out to the side, he's pulled up and into the camera frame, body staggering at the sudden movements with wide eyes. He blinks for a moment, clearly disoriented at the jarring movement.

"This is the test subject, Hordak!" Entrapta explains, beaming up at him smushed up against his side.

And he...stares. He stares down at her, his eyes...soft? Yes, they're soft as they gaze upon her, and they appear somewhat flustered, too. Even more, his ears are turned down - an expression Adora knows all too well from years living with Catra - and his mouth is agape, as if he wants to say something but is too stunned on what to say.

Entrapta begins to drone on, talking about something with the suit regarding...pain? *Hordak's* pain, it seems? The words float around Adora, barely graspable in her mind, for all she can focus on in Hordak amidst Entrapta's words as she zips around him, jumping from here and there and blabbering on and on.

He just...can't seem to look away from her.

That same expression - that same *soft* expression - is plastered on his face as he watches her, eyes following her every move as if she would vanish into thin air if he were to look away for a moment. Never had Adora seen Hordak look so...tender. All crease lines and bitter snarls that are all too common in his day-to-day expressions are all wiped free now as he keeps his eyes locked upon Entrapta.

And at the sight of it, something in Adora's heart cracks. Just a bit.

Because…Well...

The trial is tomorrow.

And he's…

Well...

"I'll have to record any issues with the armor in a few weeks time, so I'll be back to update then. But for now, this is Entrapta, signing off!"

Entrapta's cheerful words cut off Adora's train of thought, just in time to see her give a little wave to the camera before it turns off.

The tech pad succumbs to darkness, and all at once, everyone's faces are reflected on the pad's screen.

No one moves.

"Man, this is…" Catra begins, voice low. "...kinda depressing, huh?"

"What do you mean?" Bow asks.

Catra shrugs. "I dunno. It's just...We're legit planning on sending him away on his death sentence tomorrow, and then to see him like *that* with Entrapta, where he's literally-...And she's making him armor to-...Ah, I don't know. It's just...depressing."

Adora looks down at her lap. Catra was right about their plan - while they were still going to hold the trial to be fair, they four have decided that, most likely, Hordak's punishment would be to send him to Beast Island alone. While Micah and Entrapta miraculously survived, they knew that the same most likely wouldn't occur for Hordak, at least not for some time.

So, together, they decided that would be the best punishment - to send him away onto that island. In theory, it sounded like a fair plan considering all he had done in the past.

And *yet…*

"And knowing that Entrapta made the new armor," Catra speaks back up, "all for pain management to help him-"

"Wait, pain management? "Glimmer interjects, curiosity spiking her voice. "Is that what Entrapta was talking about? In the video?"

Adora quirks a brow. She heard *something* about pain in the recording, but its real meaning had completely flown over her head, and she honestly has no clue what they're talking about. She cocks her head to side then, piping up, "Wait, what? What was Entrapta saying?"

“Look, play the recording back,” Glimmer says, tapping back on the tech pad to bring it back to life.

She scrolls through the recording, looking for the specific part she wants to show. Finally, she seems to find it, muttering a “There!” under her breath and letting the recording play for all to hear.

“Symptoms without armor include general pain in muscles,” Entrapta says to the camera, “causing a decrease in the ease of mobility and sporadic bursts of sharper pain that tend to increase in variability the longer the subject goes with armor. These almost entirely diminish when armor is worn, expect for a few buffers here and there, but the overall outcome of the armor tends to be almost 99% effective!”

Glimmer pauses the recording at that, and they all fall silent for a moment.

Until...

“...That’s what the armor does?” Adora questions. “It’s...like an aid? To stop...pain?”

“I thought you all knew that,” Catra says, leaning to the side with a hand planted on her waist. “I realized once Entrapta first put that crystal-thingy in its center all that time ago - it’s like a power source. The best way I was able to subdue him, whenever we’d fight, was to rip it out. The armor would stop working, and he’d fall almost immediately.”

“...So, Mermista was wrong then,” Bow says, words slow, “when she said he was using it to fight. He really just...needs it?”

Adora sighs, lowering her gaze. She stares at her reflection in the tech pad, and it stares back, crinkled brow and downturned lips and all.

“...Are we really doing the right thing here?”

Her sudden question hangs in the air. It stays there, hovering around them unanswered, until Glimmer's voice finally pipes up.

"You mean...With what we decided we're going to do to him? After the trial?"

Adora nods.

"Yeah."

"Guys, c'mon," Bow's voice cuts in. He looks around at all of them, saying, "You watch a video of him not looking like he wants to kill someone, and that's that? Suddenly he's not guilty of all those crimes that he-"

"It's not just *that,* " Catra cuts in, voice sharp. "It's...Entrapta. I'm thinking of her too, here. I mean, he's legit her *only* friend, and-"

"Hey, wait, that's not fair," Bow interjects, crossing his arms over his chest. He furrows his brow, snapping, "We're Entrapta's friends too, you know."

Catra scoffs. "Seriously, Bow? I'm talking about, like, *really* close friends."

"Wha-? We *are* really close friends. I don't know what you're-"

"Oh, yeah?" Catra sneers, gaze sharp as she stares at Bow. She crosses her arms as well and leans forward, saying, "I mean, really think about it. Who has she been with all this time? Who has she been clinging to? Who does she *really* seem to trust around here?"

Bow looks away, expression unreadable.

"I...I guess, but-"

"I think I know where Catra's coming from."

Everyone's gaze lands on Adora at her words.

She keeps her eyes locked on her lap, shrugging before speaking back up again. “I mean, if you all treated Catra the same as Hordak and decided that *she* needed to be punished for all she did, too, I...I don’t know what I would do. I...couldn’t be away from her. I just couldn’t.”

“Exactly,” Catra says, her voice soft. “That’s what I’m trying to say here. I just feel...kinda bad. Which is *really* stupid, I guess, considering everything. But…”

She falls silent then, looking to the ground. Everyone follows suit, their gazes tumbled to the grass and failing to meet each other. They remain in a thoughtful silence like that for a long while, and no one dares shatter the peace.

Until Catra speaks up once more.

“I don't know. Just something to think about,” she says before turning on her heels, beginning to walk away. She yawns then, and over her shoulder, she adds, “I’m heading to bed. Night, guys.”

Adora looks to Glimmer and Bow, sharing empty glances with no words. In the end, Adora only tightens her grip on the tech pad to not lose it and shrugs, moving to get up and walk away as well in Catra’s direction.

“I, uh, might as well go to bed, too,” Adora says, taking slow steps backwards as she speaks. She offers a smile - one that wavers a bit in hesitation, but shines nonetheless. “Night!”

That said, Adora fully turns around, not allowing Bow or Glimmer a chance to say anything else. She’s not even sure if they were *going* to say anything, anyway.

And with that, she meets up with Catra to head towards Bright Moon together.

Chapter End Notes

looks like entrapta's recordings were actually pretty important, after all...

but anyways, thanks for reading! comments are kudos are always really appreciated :D (and come say hello on tumblr! i'm beckkii there)

Displayed

Chapter Notes

> alright, finally at the trial! i really wish i could make it more long and drawn out (which would be more realistic, too) but i have some other things i have planned for this fic, and there's only so much i can write, so you get a trial condensed into one chapter!
>
> it's still a longer chapter, though ;)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak stares at the door before him.

It stares back, waiting.

He knows he has to go in there.

It's not as if he has any other choice. For starters, two Bright Moon guards stand beside him, ready to escort him into the throne room; he knows that if he tried to make a run for it, he'd be stopped immediately. Even more, if he *were* to successfully escape, he doesn't even know where he'd go.

And...To be honest…

He truly has no desire to hide from the trial.

He'd rather just get it over with. Let them send him away, punish him, whatever they desire. At this point, he truly doesn't care anymore. There's nothing in this world that would really miss him, that would mind, that would...

Well.

Except for Entrapta.

The thought of her sends a pang of sadness through his heart like a bullet shot clean through. He lowers his gaze, looking to his feet, and tries to think of anything else other than the thought of her. To be honest, though, it's not as if he'll be able to hide from the idea of her forever. After all, through these doors, she's waiting there amongst the other princesses, for she was ordered to meet up with them earlier this morning to have some time to discuss before Hordak's entrance.

Hordak can recall in his mind, all too clearly, the look on her face when she had to leave their shared room. The way her eyes studied him, wide and swimming with fear, and the way her lips trembled. She looked as if she wanted to say something, *do* something, but she didn't.

Glimmer fully escorted her out of the room, and that was that. She was gone.

And now she waits, with the rest of the princesses, on the other side of these doors.

He sighs.

Here goes nothing.

As if hearing his thoughts, a Bright Moon guard moves to open the double doors, revealing the throne room. Hordak blinks at first, somewhat taken aback at the strange sight. For starters, the throne is far back, suspended in the air and only reachable through floating disks that lead up to it. Even more, the room is larger than Hordak expected, though he realizes that it's about the same size as *his* throne room in the Fright Zone.

And the most jarring sight of all - one that he expected, but still nerves him nonetheless - is the large table that expands down the middle and is full of princesses and others. In fact, almost every person in the Rebellion seems to be here, princesses or otherwise. Glimmer stands upright at the head, while the rest of them sit in their respective chairs.

Hordak's eyes first dart to Entrapta in the farthest chair to the right, hoping to catch her gaze. Only, she's looking instead at her hands clenched atop the table, each thumb rubbing over the other back and forth on an endless loop. Her gaze is empty, and Hordak can only wonder what thoughts are running through her mind.

Without a moment to waste, the two guards escort Hordak to a seat at the other end of the table, closest to the door. He keeps his eyes on the ground, daring not to meet the princesses gazes that he can feel all burning into him with each approaching step. Finally, he reaches his seat, and he sits before finally raising his gaze to look out before him.

"Hordak."

Glimmer's voice rings out, loud and assertive.

"Today, here in Bright Moon, a trial will commence to try Hordak, former Horde leader, for his crimes," she says. "This includes conquering towns, causing destruction of certain kingdoms, and more."

Hordak drops his gaze to his lap. The words she says ring empty in his ears - words that once would fill him with pride, with accomplishment, with almost *joy* for all he was doing for Prime. But, now, they feel...meaningless. Foolish. Pathetic, even.

He huffs out a quiet sigh. This trial certainly won't be an enjoyable ride, will it?

Not that he ever thought it would be.

"Now," Glimmer says again, "I want to start with a simple question. Something that I think could be...important, since it might clear some things up for us."

She pauses.

"Why do you wear armor?"

Hordak freezes, gaze darting upwards in shock.

What?

Out of all the questions he expected from her - where are you from? Why did you do it? Do you have anything to say first? - this is the *last* one he would have guessed. He hesitates, staring wide-eyed at Glimmer who only stares back, expression unfazed.

He opens his mouth to speak, only no words come out. They remain stuck there, waving on the tip of his tongue but failing to make the final leap.

Because this is the *last* question he'd like to answer.

He glances around. Here sits all these princesses, these people he viewed as enemies for *years,* and he's supposed to just *tell* them about his need for armor? His defect? How he's a failure, how he's broken, how he's-

"And don't bother lying," Glimmer cuts in, startling him out of his thoughts. "Last night, we discovered...something. Adora?"

At the sound of her name, Adora looks up at Glimmer, a perplexed expression on her face for a moment. However, a light bulb seems to go off in her mind, for she mutters a little "Oh, right!" before grabbing something off her person and placing it on the table for all to see.

It's...a tech pad.

Entrapta's tech pad.

"That's…" Entrapta says, eyes narrowed and confused as she stares at it. "That's mine."

"You left it by the campfire last night," Adora explains. "We didn't know whose it was for sure until we went through it."

Entrapta only stares at Adora for a moment as her words sink in. She makes no reaction until, suddenly, fear strikes her expression. She glances over at Hordak, and just like that, it clicks in his mind what this all means.

They found the video they made.

The video about his *armor.*

“So?” Glimmer prods. “Can you tell us?”

Hordak tears his gaze away, shifting a bit in his seat. With dread, he recalls the video all too well - it talked all about the armor’s purposes, Hordak’s body, why he needed it, *everything.* There were no omitted details. There were no watered-down terms that Hordak can lie about. Everything was spoken, clear as day, in Entrapta’s specific terminology that she so often uses for accuracy.

He’s truly stuck, isn’t he?

And with a sigh, keeping his gaze planted on his lap, he finally speaks.

“It’s...something to help me manage. With my pain. So that I can function...normally.”

“So that *is* it, huh?” Glimmer clarifies. “Is that it’s only purpose?”

Hordak nods. “As of now, yes. In the past, my armor was definitely used for...combat, of course, but Entrapta made this version specifically for my well-being.”

“Is that true, Entrapta?”

Hordak looks up in time to watch Entrapta nod at Glimmer.

“Yeah, it is.”

“How does it...work?” Mermista adds from her spot at the table, voice laced with curiosity. “That doesn’t make any sense. How

would armor even help him?”

“It’s, uh, like a sort of exoskeleton, I suppose,” Entrapta says. Her fingers start to fiddle with each other atop the table, clearly uncomfortable under the stress of the questions, as she continues, “It’s powered by a First Ones crystal I specifically crafted to help compensate for his entire body, essentially diminishing any pain and aiding in mobility.”

“A crystal…” Glimmer says, her voice trailing away as she mulls Entrapta’s words over in her mind. She remains thoughtful for some time until, suddenly, her eyes snap towards Hordak and down at his chest - right where the crystal lays.

“Can I see that?”

Hordak follows her gaze down to the crystal, unsure. To be fair, he doesn’t really have a choice - refusing her offer would certainly seem suspicious. However, on the *other* hand, he’d *really* prefer to just keep it in. It’s powering his armor, for one thing, and he also simply doesn't want anyone else to touch it. It’s...special, in a way. It’s a gift from Entrapta, after all.

But, again, he doesn’t really have a choice. So in the end, he gives in and pops it out, trying his best to ignore the way his body immediately sparks with pain at its absence and biting back a grimace.

He passes it over the table, and Glimmer holds it close to her narrowed eyes to study it. She bites her lip in thought as she turns it around in her hand, inspecting all angles and sides.

“It has some First Ones writing on here,” she mutters. Looking over to Entrapta, she then asks, much louder this time, “You said you ‘crafted’ this or something, right? So what does it say?”

Entrapta freezes.

“Uh...I don’t know.”

“You don’t?” Glimmer prods. “I thought you said you-“

“Well, you see, the writing was already there. When I made it,” Entrapta cuts her off. “So. Uh. I don’t know. What it says.”

Glimmer quirks a brow. “But, can’t you read First Ones-“

“I-I can, kinda, um, but not…not, uh, that. I don’t know what that says.”

Hordak narrows his eyes, studying Entrapta. She seems awfully...nervous, all of a sudden, if her increased fidgeting with her hands and choppy way of speaking is anything to go by. Which, it *certainly* is - Hordak’s spent enough time with her by now to know her nervous tells, and those are some of them.

Then...If the marking on the crystal is First Ones writing that she *can* read...

Why is she lying to Glimmer about it?

Glimmer hums in question, quirking her brow further. In the end, however, she lets Entrapta go and instead turns to Adora in the seat nearby.

“Well, *you* can definitely read it, right?” Glimmer asks.

“Yeah, I’m sure I could. Let me see.”

At that, Glimmer passes over the crystal, and Adora looks it over. For a moment, she makes no expression. But then, all of a sudden, her eyes widen. Immediately, she glances up at Entrapta who, the moment their eyes lock, tears her gaze away. Her gloved fingers clench right around each other atop the table as she keeps her eyes on the ground, clearly uncomfortable.

And all Hordak can do is stare at them, utterly confused.

What is going on?

“Wait, what does it say?” Glimmer asks, voice piqued with curiosity.

“Uh, it says...um...crystal! Yeah. That. It just says crystal.”

Glimmer furrows her brow. “What? That’s it?”

“Yup!” Adora says as an awkward smile dawns upon her lips, matching her equally-stilted words. “Definitely crystal!”

“Are you sure? You seemed kinda shocked at first-“

“No, no, trust me, I know what I’m reading,” Adora continues, her smile wavering. “It says crystal. One hundred percent. Again, trust me, I’m a First One who can read their-“

“Okay, okay, jeez. I get it,” Glimmer cuts in, taking the crystal from Adora. She stares it at a moment longer, frown deepening, before she simply shrugs and passes it back over to Hordak across the table. Immediately, he puts it back in it/ rightful place, feeling his armor come back to life around his body with relief.

For a moment, his eyes linger on the crystal. He looks up at Entrapta who still has her gaze fixated on some random spot on the table, clearly trying to avoid making eye contact with him or otherwise. Hordak frowns in confusion, trying to understand why she’s acting so strange over this. Adora, as well. She *clearly* was lying, but…

...Why?

What does it *really* say?

Is it that big of a-

“Okay, so it’s confirmed,” Glimmer states, startling Hordak out of thoughts. “You need armor, not entirely for fighting purposes, but also for support. Right?”

Hordak nods. “That is correct.”

“But…”

Hordak looks over in the direction of a new voice. This time, it’s the plant princess from before - Perfuma, he’s certain.

“Why?” she finishes. “Why do you need support? You seem fine to me. I still don’t really get it.”

Hordak freezes, his blood stopping in his veins.

For knows the answer.

And it’s not one he wants to share.

After all, speaking aloud that he has pain he needs to manage is somewhat humiliating, sure, but the reason *why...* That he’s *defected…* is a whole other matter.

Not one that he wants to delve into.

“So?” Glimmer asks when Hordak fails to respond. “What’s your answer?”

He looks down. Maybe he should’ve tried to run before. He actually might’ve been able to succeed. He has enough strength to overcome a few guards, doesn’t he? Entrapta could surely have find some way to follow, and together, they could’ve avoided this whole mess, they could’ve escaped from-

“Hordak, you have to answer. Otherwise, I’ll be forced to use a truth spell, and you’ll have little control in what you share with us here.”

He sighs in defeat.

It’s hopeless to avoid answering, isn’t it?

“I am...a defect.”

The room falls silent.

He’s not sure what other reaction he expected, to be fair.

“A...defect?” Bow questions, shattering the silence. “What do you mean?”

“I *mean* exactly what the word implies. I am defected,” Hordak states, trying to keep the bite out of his tone but failing badly in doing so. “When I was cloned, something must have gone wrong, making me different from my brothers. As in, I am weak and need support. I have...discoloration, all over my body. They do not.”

He cuts his words off then, not wishing to speak any more on that subject. The longer he’s lived, the more he’s come to terms with his body and its imperfections, but... *still…*

To share his defect with Entrapta was one thing. To share it with all of these princesses staring him down is another.

“So,” he reluctantly pipes back up when everyone fails to answer, “That is why I tried to reach my brothers and why they all arrived here on Etheria. I...wanted to prove myself. As worthy. Despite my defect.”

“Wait, wait, let me make sure I’m hearing this right,” Mermista interjects, waving her hand around. “You wanted them all to come to Etheria, not *as* much because you wanted a bigger army to fight us, but mostly because you...wanted to prove yourself? To...Who, Prime? Is that it?”

Hordak tenses up, his blood going cold. Talking about Prime and all that occurred with him, is simply...not the direction he wants to go in right now. He knows it’s an inevitable topic, and he knows the princesses are obviously curious about it all, but yet…

He was a fool. He was *such* a fool to try to return to him.

And he can’t seem to forget it.

Bringing Prime up right now certainly won’t help matters, either.

“That...Yes. That is correct,” Hordak finally says after a long moment. “That is why I worked so long on the portal, and with Entrapta, as well. While I know now that was...a mistake, I was not fully aware of the consequences of opening the portal. All I desired was to return my brothers. I had no other will for being on Etheria any longer. Well…except…”

He pauses, words trailing off for a moment.

For there *was* indeed a time he truthfully did not want Prime to return. There was a time where he was...actually content. Content in a way he never thought he’d be on this backwater planet, content in a way that shocked even him the more the realization sank in - that he was actually enjoying himself on Etheria, that he felt important to someone once more, that he was truly... *happy.*

He glances up at Entrapta, and their eyes lock, ruby clashing against green.

“...At one point.”

He looks away.

“But, my brothers all still arrived, regardless,” Hordak continues. “And seeing the consequences of my actions, of the portal and my fight to bring my brothers here...I now know my mistakes. Mistakes that I can not take back. I…”

He hesitates for a moment, lifting his eyes back up. They study the people before him - the people who he never thought he’d have to be so honest, so *open* with, yet here he is. He has no other choice, after all, and he truly has nothing else to say in defense of himself. He had made mistakes. He had hurt people.

All because of his foolishness.

To believe Prime would actually want him again, to believe he was actually *worthy* of something...

He sighs.

“I...apologize.”

Everyone’s eyes widen.

He wrings his hands underneath the table, desperate from some kind of distraction amidst his speaking. “I am aware of the harm I had inflicted upon you all. And I understand why you distrust me. I don’t blame you. And...I am sorry. For all I had done.”

No one moves or says anything.

Hordak shifts in his seat, hoping some mindless movement will help ease the nerves tangled in his gut. It doesn’t, of course. Instead, he’s stuck under the burning, awful stares of the princesses - stares that refuse to look away, refuse to soften on him, refuse to let him go. He’s frozen in place, left on display in this vulnerable state before these people who were once his enemies, and he can’t escape. No one dares break the silence, no one dares ease the tension, and he’s just *stuck.*

Until Glimmer mutters something under her breath.

“I don’t...get it.”

Her words are cold - angry, even. Hordak quirks a brow, confused at this sudden bitterness. Why would she be angry? Here he is, rendering himself vulnerable for them to tear him apart by resolving to apologize, and she’s *upset?* It doesn’t make any sense.

But Hordak hardly has any time to question it any longer, for Glimmer pipes up again, this time much louder.

“I don’t get *you,* ” she clarifies, her narrowed gaze locked onto Hordak. “It doesn’t make any sense. We had fought you for *years* - and *now* you’re apologizing? *Now* you feel bad about everything?”

“I-“

“And don’t even get me *started* on how you’ve been acting here ever since we let you in Bright Moon,” she interjects him, voice sharp enough to cut. Her echoing words bounce off the walls, loud and accusing, as she continues, “It doesn't make any sense. *None* of this whole situation does. I mean, we gave you *so* much freedom - much more than you honestly deserved, considering everything. We...We let you be with Entrapta. We let you be around the princesses. We gave you a room, and a place to sleep, and food and drink, and...and...the armor, we haven’t even *mentioned* the armor! We let you wear it, no questions asked. And...And then…”

She sucks in a breath before adding, “And then we even let you *leave* with Entrapta! We let you go on a *spaceship,* not knowing if you would even return. I mean, you could’ve...you could’ve left! You could’ve been free! I just...I don’t…”

She shakes her head with a sigh, her body deflating as all steam seems to exit her body. And when she speaks back up, her voice has gone soft.

“I just...I don’t get you. You haven’t done anything here to hurt us. You haven’t even tried. You’re just...here, doing what’s instructed,” she says. “And now...You’re apologizing to us? It doesn't make any sense. What...what *changed?”*

“I already told you,” Hordak says, tone even. “My purpose for fighting... *Prime...* is gone. I have no will now to fight you. And I have realized my mistakes, as well. What I did...It served me no good. I am aware of that now.”

“Okay, but...How does that really change things?”

Hordak glances over in the direction of another voice - it’s Perfuma once more, speaking up in a timid tone.

“I mean,” she says, wringing her hands together, “Just because he doesn't want to hurt people now, doesn't mean that he hadn’t in the past. We can’t just... *forget* that.”

“Perfuma’s right,” a different voice - Bow - adds, waving in Perfuma’s direction. “Just because he’s no longer a threat doesn’t really mean he gets off the hook. Things don’t just work like that. We have to do *something.”*

“Then why don’t you just punish me already?”

Everyone falls silent at Hordak’s words.

He sighs, lowering his gaze. It’s true - all of this talk going in circles ismeaningless. He had already resolved his fate last night, after all. And his apology truthfully wasn’t an attempt to get out of it; it was simply that. An apology.

He knows what he deserves. What they are saying is correct.

He has to atone for what he did.

And as he looks up at Entrapta, at the princesses around him who had - as Glimmer said - treated him fairly well in his time here…

He knows, deep down, that he doesn’t deserve this.

Not by any means.

“I don’t care anymore,” Hordak says, voice low. “I accept whatever fate you have in store for me. Do as you see fit. I will not fight it - I never would have. Just get it over with instead of bickering back and forth over me. I don’t care.”

Glimmer quirks a brow at his words, eyes widening. “What? That’s it? Seriously?”

“Yes. I’ve said it before, I don’t care-“

“No!”

Hordak falls silent as a different voice cuts in.

Entrapta’s voice.

Hordak looks over to where she sits; except, now, she's standing up, both hands planted firm atop the table and body leaning forward. Her ruby eyes are wide and shine with fear, a deep frown is set on her lips, and the tips of her hair seem to frizz up, if only a bit. At the sudden attention placed on her, she freezes up, and a tendril of hair jumps up to flick down her mask. She remains standing, however, but her body deflates somewhat.

And when she speaks, her voice is soft behind the mask.

"N...no," she repeats. "Don't...say that. You can't...You…I…"

Her fingers tighten atop the table.

"... *I* care."

The room falls silent. No one dares move or say anything to ease the tension in the air around them - the tension that clings to their clothes, the furniture, *everything.* It suffocates them, and Hordak shifts more in his chair, desperately wishing to rid this awful tension but not knowing *how.*

Until another voice interjects.

And this time, it's Bow.

"Entrapta," he says, tone soft. "I don't want to be rude or anything - I really don't! But…"

As his sentence trails off, she looks up in his direction, waiting. However, her mask stays in place, leaving the only thing that stares at him as bug eyes with her own real ones hidden. And all Hordak can wonder is what expression is truly on her face.

"But...Why?"

Hordak's eyes widen at Bow's words.

How *dare* he-

“What...What do you mean?” Entrapta says behind the mask. Her voice shakes a bit - clearly unsteady, and somewhat hesitant, as well.

“Again, I really mean this in the nicest way!” Bow says, shaking his hands side-to-side for emphasis with a weak smile on his face. “I’m just...curious, that’s all. We all know you really care for Hordak - anyone can see that. But, I’m wondering...Why? Again, I’m just asking out of curiosity.”

Entrapta remains silent for a moment, completely emotionless with the mask hiding any expression on her face. A thick strand of hair wraps over to the front of her body, and she grabs a hold of it before raking her hands through for comfort.

“I mean, I could show you the data I have compiled for *why,* if you’d like…” Entrapta says. “...But, well, to put it simply...Hordak’s my friend. He gets me. He...understands me. That...That means a lot.”

Bow studies her a moment, gaze still curious but fully listening nonetheless.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah,” Entrapta continues. “And he cares about me. He lets me talk about things that make me happy without telling me to be quiet, and he actually *cares* about what I have to say, too. I’m not annoying, or irrelevant, or... *anything* like that with him. I actually...matter.”

At her words, something tugs at his heart. And the longer he looks at her, the longer he studies her figure that looks so afraid standing up there but withstanding against their questioning nonetheless, the more his eyes soften with something fond. And at the way she *describes* him…

Hordak feels...something. Something good, something warm, flickering in his chest like a growing flame.

He's important to her. Anyone here can see that.

And that concept fills Hordak with a feeling he can't quite describe.

"And then, with *Prime…* " Entrapta pipes up again. "When I was captured, Hordak went against him for me. That matters to me a *lot* , too. I could've died, but then he threw him off the-"

"Wait, wait, what?" Glimmer cuts in, voice raised. "He did *what* to Prime?"

Entrapta freezes at first before looking to Glimmer and cocking her head to the side. "Wait, you...didn't know? That's how Prime was first subdued. I mean, I think it all ended with Adora going in his mind or something like that, but-"

"Entrapta, wait a second," Glimmer interjects once more, her hand waving about for emphasis. "I didn't know that happened to Prime."

"I told you before. Prime is gone now, and that is why I have no will to fight you all any longer," Hordak inputs. And with narrowed eyes, he adds, "But I fail to see how the way Prime came to his demise matters here."

In all honesty, he really just wishes they would all stop talking about Prime. But this isn't the time to bring that up, is it?

Glimmer shakes her head. "No, no, this *is* important. Because there's a *big* difference between Prime just dying and you not wanting to fight anymore because of that, compared to you *actively* trying to kill him in the first place. That's kinda important here!"

"Wait, I'm lost…" Mermista speaks up. " *How* is that important? I'm confused."

"Because *he,"* Glimmer says, gesturing to Hordak, "didn't have to kill Prime. But he did. Wasn't that the guy he was trying to

impress for so long, that he *fought* for? Why would he try to kill him then? I mean, doesn't that kind of account for *something* here?"

At first, Hordak doesn't know what to say. He simply stares at Glimmer, not speaking up, not doing anything.

Because...Well, it's *true.* He didn't have to do that. In fact, doing so was a terribly dangerous thing to do. But, *yet...* He did it regardless. He had tried to kill Prime out of fear for Entrapta's life, despite how he was the person he had gone after for so long, despite how important he was to him. It was the worst thing any of the brothers could have done - to betray Prime in any way was awful, was a crime punishable by death, was simply... *blasphemous.*

Yet, in that moment, none of that mattered. Both out of a desperation to save Entrapta, but also…

Because he realized how much he did not need Prime.

That all those years, slaving away and wasting time and effort to return by his side, did not matter. It was a foolish dream, an empty goal, something that inevitably ended in pain and sorrow for all of his failures.

Prime was not who he needed.

He needed...to be his own person.

A blasphemous concept, yet one that struck him in that moment nonetheless.

"Hordak."

At Glimmer's words, Hordak brings his head up, jarred out of the tumbling thoughts in his mind.

"Do you...regret it? What you did to Prime?"

Immediately, Hordak shakes his head.

"No."

The words shock even his own ears. Never did he believe he would say such a thing, and never so fast, either. The words sting in his mind, and guilt begins to swim painfully in his stomach, wracking him with a sudden wave of nausea.

For it hits him then with a thud in his gut.

He does not regret betraying Prime.

All this time, he had tried his best to never think those words, much less speak them aloud. It's an abomination to believe such a thing, and while he may have betrayed Prime, he believed ever since that perhaps he could pretend that he regretted it, that he was still loyal, that he was still *worth* something. And he's certain that, in the near future, he will dwell on this fact more deeply, will convince himself otherwise that he *does* regret betraying Prime and he *is* still worthy.

But he can't deny it.

What he had said to Glimmer is true.

He does not regret it.

And as he looks over at Entrapta, now sitting down with the mask still dawned upon her face but surely staring at him behind those bug eyes, he knows he would *never* go back. And nothing could ever convince him otherwise.

"Hordak," Glimmer says, voice loud once more amidst the otherwise silent room. She places her staff more firmly by her side, announcing, "I believe we've had enough time with you here today. You've said your piece, and you'll now be escorted to a waiting room until we have finished discussing matters. Understood?"

Hordak nods. He's not sure what else to say.

Glimmer looks to the guards by the door then, nodding. "Lead him away."

At that, the two guards from before approach Hordak, and he gets out of his seat. In silence, he follows them out of the room to be lead to who *knows* where, all the while ignoring the burning stares on his back.

To be honest, he's not sure if that went well.

Not as if there's anything he can do about it now.

~~~

Waiting for the princesses to call him back feels like hours.

Well, for all Hordak knows, it might actually *be* hours.

It's not as if he has any real concept of time in this room he was directed in. It's awfully bland and empty, save for the large couch in the middle that he now sits on, and there's no windows dawned upon the walls. Even more, it's a bit on the dimmer side, giving it an overall depressing atmosphere.

Oh well. What did he expect?

He's still under trial, after all.

To be honest, it wasn't as bad as he was expecting. It went by much quicker than a regular trial would be - *much* quicker - but he isn't complaining. Not by a long shot. And truthfully, he never expected much different from these princesses, for their law and order system seems somewhat...disorganized. *Very* disorganized, to be more accurate.

But, yet again, he isn't complaining. The sooner he can get this all over with, the happier he will be.

Well, all things considered.

For "happy" might not be the best way to describe how he's feeling right now.

Nonetheless, out of everything, he truly just wishes he could see Entrapta. If only the princesses had given them time to talk between now and the trial, to just see each other for a little, *something.* But no, he's stuck away in this room, she's remaining with the princesses as they all discuss his fate, and it's one of the worst aspects of waiting in this room.

Hordak groans, shifting on the couch to get into a more comfortable position. It certainly has to have been a few hours by now. Do the princesses really need to talk for that long? What could they possibly be discussing? They have to be finished someti-

The sound of the double doors opening cuts off his train of thought, and he snaps his head up in curiosity.

It's the same two guards from before, waiting by the entrance. The sight of them sparks Hordak both with relief and panic - relief that this must mean that the princesses are done speaking, but panic that this *also* means that he's about to receive his sentence.

This really is it.

And all he can do is helplessly get up at the guards' commands and follow them out the door.

~~~

They lead him to same room as before - the throne room - and as he enters, everyone falls silent. He keeps his gaze down, not daring to look up at anyone, not even Entrapta. Out of the corner of his eyes, however, he can tell that everyone is still in the same seats as before. In general, not much has changed in here since his time waiting in that room.

The guards lead him to the same seat he previously was in, and he sits.

"Hordak."

At the sound of his name spoken by Glimmer with that authoritative tone she so often uses, he looks up at her. Once more, she stands high and straight on the opposite end of this table, staff in hand, as she stares back at Hordak.

"After much discussion, we have decided on your punishment," she says, tone even. "There...was much debate, so I apologize for having you wait so long."

Hordak doesn't answer. He simply stares straight on, keeping his face neutral.

"Regardless," Glimmer continues, "We've all come to a final decision. Due to all of the destruction you've caused to Etheria, you will work to repair it. Some people may assist you if they'd like, and a few will *have* to work with you on several projects, such as any involving destruction done by both you and Catra. So far, for starters, we've decided you'll begin this process with Salineas."

Hordak's heart stops.

What?

He...He couldn't possibly have heard her correctly. No, there's no way. But as he looks over at Entrapta, finding her to have the hint of a bitten-back smile on her face with relief clear in her eyes, all he can realize is that yes, this is *true,* this is all *real.*

This is it. Repair of destruction. With the help of others.

That...That's all it is.

And it doesn't make any sense.

“What?” Hordak finally says, tone incredulous. “Is...Is that all?”

Glimmer nods. “Of course, in the process, you are still under watch by the princesses. And until you leave for Salineas for your first project in a few weeks, you will stay here in Bright Moon. You will also stay here in between any projects. But, once you have finished what we see fit, then you are free of our terms. Before all of that, of course, you have to comply.”

Hordak only stares, jaw dropped and eyes wide.

It just doesn’t make sense.

None of it does.

How could...Why…?

“Do you understand?”

At Glimmer’s words, Hordak nods on instinct. Though, to be honest, he does *not* understand. He doesn’t even have a clue. And as the guards escort him away to his room with the meeting dismissed behind him, Hordak can hardly process the blurred together voices and words and people that move about. And once he reaches his room, left alone for only a moment, his mind is a haze, the world whirring about him without a way to calm it down, to settle it, to *understand.*

But then, through the chaos, a voice appears in his room. A *familiar* voice, better described, along with purple hair and shining eyes and a gleaming smile that beams up at him. She’s speaking about something positive, something along the lines of luck, but Hordak’s mind lags behind and refuses to comprehend her.

Because it just doesn't make sense. None of it does.

And he isn’t certain how to *feel.*

Chapter End Notes

something i want to mention is how, in this fic, hordak says that his real goal for having prime come to etheria was to impress him and receive honor despite being a defect. and while that's definitely canon, hordak ALSO says in his backstory speech in the show that he wants prime to come to crush the rebellion as well. but, to be honest, i think that might've been a lie, or at least a result from his conditioning that he doesn't truly believe. in my opinion, his real goal was for prime alone. so, while i'm not sure if it's canon or not, i put that concept in this fic! i'd like to hear your thoughts on it, though :)

anyways, thanks for reading! comments and kudos are super appreciated :) (and come say hi on tumblr! i'm beckkii over there!)

Clashing

Chapter Notes

> back with another chapter, and this time, it's just some alone time with hordak and entrapta! i really do like writing about the other characters, but i love having some one-on-one time between these two
>
> even if things aren't..entirely fluffy...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He knows he should be happy.

After all, here he is, wound up somewhere he never could have imagined. The shining stars and moons blanket the dark sky above him, basking him and Entrapta in a hazy glow as they sit together on the balcony. Hordak never even *realized* they had a balcony connected to their room; but, it turns out that every guest room has one. Upon realizing that this evening, Entrapta quickly took advantage of that, dragging Hordak out here the moment night fell and the stars came out.

And in typical Entrapta fashion, they don't sit on the floor like most would. Instead, Entrapta decided to perch herself up on the railing to get a better view, and she hoisted Hordak up with her, as well. Her pigtails now wrap around the rails for support, along with an extra tendril wrapped behind Hordak's waist to keep him secure and from wavering.

Due to all of this, Entrapta sits practically squished up against his side. The heat of her body is pleasant and nice against his own, especially now that he's taken his armor off for the night. And while the nighttime air is chilly as gusts of frosty wind flow against his skin, Entrapta's warmth besides him compensates for it.

With all of this, he *should* be happy. There's no reason not to be.

Yet…

He *isn't.*

He knows why he isn't. He knows why there's this deep ache, this deep dissatisfaction that gnaws in his gut and clenches his insides. He knows why, try as he might to enjoy this evening and just live in the moment for *once* in his life, he simply...can't. He knows why he isn't happy despite everything telling him that he should be, that this is a time to celebrate, that this is a time to be content.

It's because he doesn't deserve it.

None of it.

It all boils down to that. Everything is so perfect - *too* perfect - and some dark part of his mind screams at him that it's wrong, it's all so wrong, it's *unfair.* Unfair to the princesses he had hurt, unfair to Entrapta for all she's done for him, unfair to all of Etheria, unfair to *everyone.* And he knows it's out of his control that he was never punished, and he knows that it's not as if he can *force* them to do so, but...That would be the ideal solution. He deserves that. Not...Not *this.*

He needs punishment, shouldn't he? Wouldn't that be the most fair? He needs to atone for what he had done, and not just through rebuilding, but something...something *more.* Being let off the hook so quickly doesn't make any sense. It's just so... *wrong.*

Because all beings must suffer to become pur-

"Oh! Oh! Look!"

At Entrapta's sudden words, Hordak's gaze immediately darts to the sky, startled out of his thoughts. And there, following the direction her hand points in, does he see what she's referring to - a shooting star. It streams throughout the sky, leaving behind a trail of glittery gold before fizzling out into nothingness.

“I never get sick of watching those,” Entrapta says, voice laced with awe. “I mean, they’re not as rare as people think - it’s all about timing and whether you look hard enough in the sky! But, I still think it’s pretty neat.”

“Indeed,” Hordak manages to say, looking down at her beside him. A trace of a soft smile lights up her face, and her eyes seem to sparkle with the reflection of the night sky. And Hordak, despite every part of him telling him that this is wrong, that him enjoying this night is so *wrong,* can’t help but feel a little better at the sight of her. She looks so happy, so at *peace* with everything, and he finds some solace in the sight. The corner’s of his lips tug upwards - only a bit - as he adds, “I find them fascinating, as well.”

She looks up at him then with dreamy eyes, that smile still adorned upon her face. It widens as they lock stares, and something about her soft gaze flutters Hordak’s heart in a way he can’t understand.

“We really got lucky, huh?” she says, voice quiet.

Immediately at her words, whatever solace Hordak had falls away. His smile drops, and he quirks a brow at her, opening his mouth to ask a question he really has no need to. After all, he already knows *exactly* what she’s talking about.

The trial from earlier today. How Hordak received no punishment. How everything is just so *perfect* in ways he can’t help but feel guilt at.

“What do you mean?”

“With...everything. With the princesses, and the trial,” she says, tearing her eyes away to study the sky once more. Absentmindedly, she kicks her feet back and forth in front of her, saying, “I mean, I was nervous the whole time. It was just so...stressful. Especially since I was stuck with them for so long while we talked about what to do with you. Well, don’t get me wrong - I like the other princesses. And I’m friends with a few of

them. But, being around them while they all debated over you made me…anxious."

"While I was away?" Hordak clarifies. "During those few hours?"

She nods, gripping her fingers over the railing and gaze tumbling to the ground beneath her.

"It was just...a lot. A lot of debating back and forth, I mean," she explains. "At first, a lot of people were neutral on what to do to you, with a few people for you and a few other people completely against you. Eventually, though, everyone who wasn't for you became neutral, and that's when Glimmer made the final decision that your punishments would only be community service."

"They...all became neutral?" Hordak says, curiosity spiking his tone. Honestly, the concept that no one there still wanted him severely punished baffles him.

"Well, okay, *mostly,"* Entrapta says. "*Technically* a couple people were reluctant to go neutral, but they eventually just conceded. So, it still all worked out! And like I said - I think that makes us pretty lucky."

At her words, another wave of guilt washes over Hordak, and he turns his head away. Lucky isn't how he sees it, despite how he knows he should, despite how Entrapta is clearly happy, despite *everything.*

But he just *can't.*

"You know, Hordak, we could actually go now."

"Go?" Hordak asks, turning his head back to face Entrapta with a quizzical stare.

"To space! We seriously could!" she exclaims, her eyes shining. "We have a few weeks until you start your community service, right? That's more than enough time! We could go on a week trip, or...or...Even just a few days! Darla is able to quickly get us out

there in the galactic atmosphere, so the whole ordeal would be no issue with time!”

Hordak raises a brow, hesitant. “Are you certain? That seems somewhat sudde-“

“No, no, it’ll be great! All I have to do is make you a suit, and I bet Glimmer would let us go!” she says. The more she speaks, the quicker her voice gets, and the more her volume raises as well, creating an air of excitement that practically radiates off her. “Please, Hordak? It would be so fun!”

Hordak studies her for a moment, eyes narrowed in thought as he mulls it over in his mind. Her smile is wide and infectious, cutting deep into Hordak’s weak spots, and to see her so happy is just...Well...It’s hard to refuse.

Despite everything telling him otherwise, that he doesn't deserve this, that he doesn’t deserve to be with her, that he must be rightfully punished because that’s the solution and that’s what he needs and that’s how he should redeem himsel-

“Please? You promised, you know!”

Hordak huffs out a sigh before tearing his eyes away. Her excited gaze is too pleading, too begging, and it reminds him all too well of what Imp looked like whenever he’d beg Hordak for some head scratches. And Hordak knows that he’s never been able to resist giving in.

“Alright,” he finally says, allowing himself to smile a bit at her. At least for her sake. “We will go sometime before Salineas.”

“YES!”

At Entrapta’s yell, Hordak watches as she shakes her hands back and forth, joy rippling through her. Most times when she’s excited, Hordak usually catches her rocking her balled-up fists; but now, she instead flaps her hands side-to-side, and something soft

makes home in Hordak's heart. He breaks out into a true smile of his own, unable to remain stoic under seeing her so happy.

Once she stops, she returns back to her initial spot snuggled up close against Hordak's side. Only this time, she tentatively rests her head on his shoulder, movements slow presumably out of care to protect him from any pain - especially since he's currently without his armor. At the sensation of her head there, Hordak's heart flutters - and not entirely in a nervous way. He never thought he'd like the feeling of someone leaning on him for support, but he quickly realizes that he *does* - at least with her - for her hair is soft and warm against his neck, and her touch, mask included, is light enough to not cause any pain to his muscles there.

But the moment the initial thrill passes, another pang of sadness burrows in his gut. He wills it away, wills the voices in his head to just leave him alone and let him enjoy this peace now. But despite everything, he simply...can't. Every part of him tells him that this is wrong, that he doesn't deserve her here, and the longer she rests her head there, the worse it all gets.

He bites back a growl of frustration, trying to keep the peace at least for Entrapta's sake. She's so *happy* about everything, and he can't ruin that for her. But, as he dwells on it longer, it continues to manifest like growing weeds in his mind, gaining strength the longer they burrow there. And then he thinks of the talk of going to *space* - how does he deserve to go? On a leisurely trip with *her?* He doesn't deserve it, he doesn't deserve *any* of this, he-

"Hordak?" Entrapta says, interrupting his thoughts.

"Hm?"

"Are you alright? Your body seems kinda...tense."

Hordak's heart stops.

"I am...fine."

Entrapta is quiet for a moment, and Hordak wonders if she decided to let it go or actually did believe his lie. However, suddenly, she pulls her body away and looks up at him. Her ruby gaze swims with worry, and the more he's left under her invasive stare, the more anxiety grows within him.

"You don't really seem fine," Entrapta says, frown deepening. She cocks her head to the side, adding, "You've been quiet. And more so than usual."

"I assure you, I am-"

"Hordak, you've been quiet all *evening,*" she interrupts, voice louder than his to silence it. "I keep trying to...I don't know, brush it off for you being tired or something, but...Are you sure nothing's bothering you? Because I feel like something is."

Hordak looks away and shifts a bit in place atop the railing, feeling her gaze still locked onto him and wishing he could run from it.

"You know you can talk to me," Entrapta pipes up. Her voice has gone awfully soft, and the sheer gentleness of it pierces something in Hordak's heart, makes him wallow in rising guilt.

"I…"

He sighs. He knows he has no reasonable way to explain everything. He should be happy. He should feel just like Entrapta - excited for the future, relieved at what had occurred, content at where they are right now. After all, there's no real reason to feel this way. There's nothing logically in the way his mind seems determined to drag him down, to stamp out any positive thought, to flood him with guilt.

But...He just can't *help* it.

No matter how hard he tries, no matter how much he wishes to just enjoy the *now,* he *can't.* And the more Entrapta's saddened gaze lingers on him and guilt swallows him for ruining *her* happiness, the more anger begins to well up inside him. He

should be happy with her and talking about the stars, talking about a future, but all he can think is that he doesn't deserve this and he needs to be punished and he *is* a defect that needs to be fixed and Prime was right that he *is* a failure and he always was and he-

"Hordak? Seriously, you can tell me-"

"I should have been punished."

Hordak's words immediately silence her.

He breathes in a sigh, staring at his lap for a long while. Tension fills the air around them, and neither of them make an effort to break it. They simply sit there, quiet, for a few moments that feel like hours.

He shouldn't have said anything.

He knows he should've just stayed quiet. Entrapta was happy, she was... *enjoying* herself tonight, and now Hordak has ruined it. And as he finally dares to look over and catch her gaze, and he finds her to be staring at him with utter confusion and sadness all the same, the more regret starts to chew up his insides and fill him with shame.

"W...What?" Entrapta says, eyes wide in shock and voice hardly above a whisper. "Hordak, what do you mean?"

"I...I mean what I said," Hordak explains. His own tone is low, softer now. "I...don't deserve this, Entrapta. I had hurt everyone so much. I can't simply be free to do as I please as a consequence."

Entrapta quickly shakes her head. "But you'll work to fix what you had done, Hordak. They're giving you a chance instead of just sending you away, and you *deserve* that chance. I don't know why you think-"

"But that's not *right,* " Hordak cuts her off, a sudden bite to his words. "These things can not easily be fixed. I had done so much, and...and with Prime...I was foolish. I had caused harm to so many of them, all for my selfish desires that all accounted to nothing. I…"

At that moment, as he stares at Entrapta, all he can see is that one time on the Velvet Glove. That time when she knelt there, handcuffed before him with fear shining in her eyes, for Hordak was going to hurt her, to *kill* her - all because Prime had said so, all because he was so foolish to believe in Prime and be willing to do whatever he commanded.

"I had almost hurt you, too. During that time in the Velvet Glove, before I rebelled against Prime."

Entrapta's eyes soften at his words. She opens her mouth to speak, only no words pour forth. All she does is stare and stare and stare at him, leaving them both in a heavy silence for a few moments.

Until Entrapta suddenly shakes her head once more.

"But you *didn't.* You went against Prime. You...You saved me. Doesn't that mean *something?* You can't just say you deserve to be punished when-"

"But I just as easily could have killed you!" Hordak cuts her off, voice risen to overcome hers. He narrows his eyes, saying, "I should have never tried to open the portal, and I shouldn't have gone after him. I shouldn't have even tried to conquer this planet, hurting many in the process and all of it accounting to *nothing.* I…"

His words trial off for a moment, and he sighs before adding, "I should have just let it all *go.* I should have known he would never want me back. I am a defect, and that makes me worthless in his eyes. I knew that. But instead, I was a fool. Etheria - and you as well - would not have suffered as much if I had not made those

mistakes. And for those princesses to just let me *go* - it doesn't make sense. It's a poor decision. I need to be punished for what I had done, to become right again-"

"How can you *say* these things?"

Hordak falls silent at Entrapta's yell.

At first, he only stares at her, shocked. Her voice had gone louder than he had ever heard, completely silencing him, and it now leaves him speechless. She stares back, her eyes wide and flaming with some awful mixture of anger and sadness, and her brow is furrowed, creating deep crease lines around her eyes. Her hair, which had frizzed a bit on the ends at her yell, now calms down somewhat; but, the strands remain tightly clenched around the railing much harder than before. Her hands grip onto it as well, and if Hordak could see her knuckles, he's certain they would be white from the pressure.

"Yes, you made mistakes and bad decisions. But everyone does!" Entrapta says, voice pained and still terribly loud. "But that's why there's forgiveness. There's still *hope.* The princesses could have all decided to send you away, but they decided to give you another chance. And you deserve that, too."

Hordak narrows his eyes, a flash of anger sparking through him.

"I do *not* deserve-"

"Catra deserves forgiveness," she cuts in, counting off fingers. "Scorpia deserves forgiveness. I deserve forgiveness. *Everyone* who had worked for the Horde deserves forgiveness. And that includes you."

Hordak shakes his head. "But I am much different from them. I had-"

"How? How are you different?" Entrapta cries out, silencing him once more. "Hordak, you did bad things. And so have I. So has Catra. So have *so* many other people. How are you any different?"

“Because I-“

“ *Why* do you think you deserve *nothing?”*

Hordak falls silent once more.

Entrapta looks down to her lap, eyes narrowed in anger but lips trembling all the same. She looks so angry, so *upset,* and the sight tears into Hordak’s heart and invites guilt to seep through. He wants to say something, *anything,* to make her feel better, yet he just can’t. He doesn't know what to say.

“You always treat yourself like you don’t deserve anything, like you’re worthless or something,” Entrapta says, keeping her gaze locked to her lap and shaking her head all the while, partially concealing her expression. However, as Hordak stares, he starts to notice something glistening in the corners of her eyes. Are they tears?

He tries to counter, “I do not-“

“Yes, you do!” Entrapta cries back out, bringing her eyes back up. “You do all the time!”

With her now looking at him face on, Hordak quickly finds out that he was right - those *are* tears shining in her eyes, now wavering on the cusp of her eyelids but refusing to freely fall. He despises the sight of it, of her so distraught *,* but he doesn't know what to do or how to fix it. He’s not sure if he can.

She looks away, lip still trembling. And when she opens her mouth to speak, her pained words quiver as well, threatening to break despite her loud tone. In fact, the more she speaks, the more her tone begins to raise, louder and louder throughout the balcony.

“Like...Like with the sleeping bag,” she spits out, finally drawing her gaze back to lock with his. “You refused to sleep in the bed, even though you deserved that, too. And that’s just one example - you do that with almost everything!”

"Entrapta, I do not-"

"Stop saying that! You *do!"* she yells back.

And just like, the dam in her eyes breaks.

She fights to stop it, but it's a losing battle. Tears begin to roll down her flushed cheeks, faster and faster like a never-ending stream. And as her face scrunches up in pain, all it does is squeeze more and more tears out of her glistening eyes. Through it all, her body begins to shake under the pressure, and her hair slightly quivers with her body. She quickly tries to suppress it by crossing her arms over her chest in some form of a self hug, but it truthfully helps nothing.

And all Hordak can do is stare.

He doesn't know what to do. He had never seen her cry so *openly* before. After all, whenever else she had truly cried, she used her mask to conceal her face. But now, caught up in the moment, she seems to have forgotten, leaving her expression exposed and vulnerable for him to see.

And it breaks him.

"Entrapta-"

"I try *so* hard," she interjects, voice shaking, "to make sure you know your value. Because *I* used to struggle with the same things. People didn't always forgive me for my mistakes. People would hold grudges. People would tell me that I was a failure, that what I had to say was annoying or dumb, that I didn't deserve their respect or *anything* like that."

Hordak's heart stops in his chest at her words. And as he looks at her and her tear-ridden face, listening to her strained voice, the more a painful lump starts to grow in his throat. He swallows, but he fails to will it away.

“So seeing you like this,” she continues, words breaking as she cries, “hurts me so much. Hordak, you don’t need to feel this way. It’s not true. You can still redeem yourself, and the princesses are *giving* you that chance. Why can’t you *accept* it?”

“Because I do not deserve it,” Hordak quickly counters.

“But you do!” she cries back. “And you...you don’t…you don’t even *listen* to what I say. I tell you that you matter. That you deserve a chance, too. And it hurts, because why don’t...why…”

At that, her words trail away with the wind. She heaves a shaky sigh, her body shuddering under the pressure, before she finally speaks once more.

“Why don’t you *listen* to me?”

Hordak’s eyes widen, ears flicking down in shame. He opens his mouth to answer; only, nothing comes forth. He doesn’t know what to say or even how to say it, leaving him stuck staring at her. And through it all, she looks so pained, so *desperate* for an answer from him. But, there’s nothing. He can’t find the words to speak back.

And that feeling of guilt swallows him whole all the while.

After a few seconds, Entrapta looks down, sucking in a shaky breath and giving a little shake of her head. She uses the back of her hand to wipe away her tears, but there’s truly no point, for they still continue to trek down her face. So, instead of resolving to stop them, she suddenly flicks down her mask, leaving Hordak blind to her true expression.

“Entrapta-“ he begins.

But instead of answering, she jumps off the railing back onto the balcony with the use of her pigtails. And without saying another word, her hair now weakly dragging behind her, she turns around and heads back into their room.

Hordak watches through the glass door as she goes in and around the bed, heading straight to the sleeping bag on the floor. And to his surprise, right before flicking off the lights with a tendril of hair, she climbs in there to sleep. Hordak's eyes widen in shock, for tonight was her night to have the bed. But here she is, using the sleeping bag instead. Whether it was done truly out of spite or simply forgetfulness, Hordak isn't certain.

Heaving a sigh, he looks back out at the stars, not knowing what else to do. That damn lump is still stuck in his throat, and guilt continues to weigh his body down. And while he's aware that he should get up and off the railing to go to bed, the idea of doing so sounds daunting.

But in the end, he picks his body up to head inside before sparing one last glance at the stars. He can't help but feel that they're not as bright as Entrapta always describes them.

Chapter End Notes

man, i really gotta work on adding the "comfort" aspect to this hurt/comfort story...

but in all seriousness, i wish she ra had more moments where entrapta got angry. normally she's more passive, but i feel like she wouldn't be as much around people she trusts (like hordak)

anyways, thanks for reading! comments and kudos are always really appreciated! (and come say hi on tumblr! i'm beckkii there :))

Tense

Chapter Notes

> back with another update! i had a pretty busy week, but thankfully i was able to find some time to write. again, it's more 1 on 1 entrapta and hordak moments, and i always look forward to writing those :) makes it easier to write for me!
>
> hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak awakes in the dark.

He blinks, trying to orient himself amidst his confusion. It doesn't seem to be working out, though; his mind is too cloudy, too tired, too disoriented to fully grasp his surroundings. All he understands is that darkness fills the place he's in, a hint of pale moonlight streams in from somewhere, warmth and softness surround him between mountains of pillows and blankets, and-

Oh.

He's in bed.

He rubs the sleep from his eyes, groaning a little under his breath. Fatigue aches in every part of his body, and as he turns his head to gaze out the window by his bed, he catches a glimpse of the sky. Twinkling stars and moons still decorate it, sprinkling across the black canvas like spilled glitter. It must still be nighttime; no wonder he's tired. He must've only gotten a few hours of sleep since…

He frowns, for just like that, the memory of last night finally catches up to him with a painful thud in his gut.

...since last night on the balcony.

He huffs out a sigh and gives a little shake of his head to clear his mind - as if *that* will help matters. It doesn't, of course, and try as he might to forget last night, he just...can’t. The memory stays there, imprinted in his mind and refusing to let him go with its death grip.

Shutting his eyes once more, he turns over in bed and attempts to fall back asleep. It doesn't work - his mind is too loud, his brain too scrambled with thoughts and jumbled feelings, and this bed with its blankets and pillows is suddenly so *suffocating.* Huffing in annoyance, he then tries turning on his *other* side while keeping his eyes shut all the while, but this fails to work as well.

Figures.

He growls to himself as he hoists his body up into a sitting position. At this point, it looks as if there’s no point in trying to get back to sleep. Perhaps he could go for a walk around the castle, or perhaps he could head outside for a breath of fresh air? Well, to be honest, he still isn’t sure what he can or cannot do in this castle and what the real terms are on his freedom as of now. He might not even be allowed to leave at these hours without permission.

In the end, he resolves to simply get up and leave this stuffy room for a little while. To where, he isn’t certain yet, but he’ll just have to figure it out. Perhaps he’ll only take a short walk outside for only a moment before heading back inside, and maybe it’ll help put his mind at ease to let him sleep?

Probably not. It’s still worth a try.

With that decided, he turns his body towards the door and begins to peel back the warm sheets. Darkness still blankets the room, making it hard to see where exactly Entrapta’s body lays on the floor. But, as he continues to blink, it becomes somewhat easier to see. He’s certain he’ll be able to make his way around her without waking-

He stops dead in his tracks.

Entrapta's shadowed figure sits upright on the floor.

He pulls back in shock, bringing the sheets over his body once more and reigning himself back in the bed. And as he narrows his eyes, trying to determine if that *is* Entrapta sitting up and not some figment of his imagination, he quickly realizes that it *is* her. It has to be - the pigtails and everything are clearly visible despite the darkness, and he can also make out how her body is turned away from him and curled up on itself with her knees drawn up tight to her chest.

He opens his mouth to speak but hesitates just as quickly. Should he say something, or should he just let her be? Can she not sleep, either? Is that why she's awake? Would it be helpful to say something? He has no clue.

In the end, he gains the courage to whisper out.

"Entrapta?"

Silence.

Immediately, a wave of regret washes over Hordak. His muscles tense up, and he grips hard onto one of the blankets, trying to decide on what to do next. Honestly, he really shouldn't have said anything. He should've just stayed quiet and let her be alone like any sensible person would. But here Hordak is, crossing boundaries he shouldn't despite how she's certainly still upset, despite how morning might've been better to break the tension between them, despite how-

"You were right."

Hordak's blood goes cold at her words.

He blinks, trying to ignore the way his heartbeat begins to pound in his chest. For a long moment, body still as ever, he waits to see if she'll add something. But, she never does.

"...What?" Hordak asks, voice hardly above a whisper. "What do you mean?"

"About last night. On the balcony," she mutters. Her words hold an eerie ring to them, and it sends chills up Hordak's spine.

His clench tightens on the blanket, and a few threads break under the sudden pressure. "I…I am not following you."

"You know. You told me that you hurt so many people from the mistakes you've made, and that you were foolish," she drones on, voice cold as ice. "And so, you deserved to be punished."

Hordak's jaw drops, his muscles tense as ever. He doesn't know what to say. She sounds so strange, so *different,* with all warmness and kindness that's usually in her voice now completely erased. Even worse, her body still faces away from him, entirely still and rigid. Everything about her is so wrong, so unlike her, and it fills Hordak's gut with unease.

He tries, voice helpless, "I…"

"I think I agree. You were right, Hordak."

Hordak entirely freezes, fear spiking through his mind and gut doubling over with nausea. Her words seep into his mind, making home there and filling it with guilt. He tries to block it out, tries to rationalize her words and understand *why* she's saying this, but it's truly no use. And all he can do is sit there, staring at Entrapta with wide eyes that are full of fear, full of guilt, full of so much *regret.*

"I…" he tries once more. However, his words immediately trail off into nothingness, and he can't seem to find the strength to attemp speaking once more. His throat is closed off, mind scrambled and failing to think of what to say, and he's stuck in silence yet again.

"I don't know why I bothered trying so hard for you."

All of a sudden, Entrapta moves to stand. In the dark, her shadowed features are still hidden from him, but her figure is clearly visible as she straightens up from where she once sat. And immediately, without a moment to waste, she turns and begin to move towards Hordak. Each step is slow, but nonetheless, her figure approaches quicker than he could have predicted.

"Entrapta-" he begins, pulling his body back as fear pounds through his body. Her movements are far too proud, far too dignified, and far too *unlike* her usual sporadic way of moving. Now, these movements remind him all too well of someone else that spikes panic in his heart. They remind him of someone not her, of someone...someone like…

"You weren't ever worth it. Not worth my time, my efforts, none of that," she continues, now standing before Hordak and looming over him. Still, shadows obstruct her face, and Hordak desperately searches for her gentle eyes, for her warm gaze that always brings him comfort. Only, he finds nothing. He's left staring at her shadowed, unreadable features as she adds, "You were right. About everything."

Hordak swallows, his heartbeat pounding in his ears and obstructing any rational thoughts. All he can focus on is her as she begins to lean down, movements slow and fluid, with her features still hidden by shadows. A strand of her one pigtail drapes down and onto his shoulder as she leans close, and just like that, she plants a gloved hand on his cheek. It's firm and without any gentless, and he stills in fear.

"Entrapta, I-"

His words cut off suddenly, for the shadows disappear from her features. And when she opens her eyes, they shine with a sickening lime green color.

"You really *are* a failure."

Hordak's eyes pop open with a gasp.

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He jumps up in bed, chest heaving. All he can see is darkness. Rich, black darkness, leaving him blind and confused as his eyes dart about his surroundings like ricocheting bullets. It doesn't make any sense, *none* of it makes sense. Where's Entrapta? Prime? Wasn't he just awake? Is it still last night? It has to be, it has to, but where's Entrapta, where *is* she-

Hordak freezes, for his eyes catch sight of something on the floor.

It's Entrapta, cuddled up in the sleeping bag and body turned away. She's not standing before him, not holding onto his face, not under Prime's control, *none* of that. Instead, she's simply asleep.

It wasn't real.

He heaves a shaky sigh, attempting to calm his nerves and heartbeat that still hammers loudly in his ears. But, despite his initial efforts, his mind is still stuck in shambles, all thoughts gone scattered. Not knowing what else to do, he grips tight onto the blankets with shaky hands and closed eyes, trying desperately to reign everything back in and put his mind at ease.

It was only a dream. It was not real. Prime is not here. This is the first time he has woken up. Entrapta is fine. It was not real. It was not real. It was not-

"...Hordak?"

He freezes.

Of *course* Entrapta is awake.

Just his luck.

Hesitantly, he looks over to confirm. And sure enough, there her figure is, raised up on an elbow and facing in his direction. In the
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darkness, he can just barely make out her eyes - half-lidded and clearly fatigued, but staring him down at the same.

However, the moment they lock eyes, she seems to shrink back. Just a bit.

They still haven't talked about last night, after all.

"Are you okay?" she asks, voice meek.

He looks away. "I am fine. It was nothing."

She's silent at first, leaving them both in a heavy quiet that weighs down on their shoulders. No one dares to move or speak, and the air around them is dangerously still.

But it only lasts a moment.

"I...heard my name. You said it."

"Said it?"

"In your sleep."

Hordak's ears flick down in shame.

"It really was nothing," he mumbles after a pause.

"Then...Why'd you say my name? You sounded upset."

"Entrapta, honestly, there is no need to be-"

"No, you're not being honest," she cuts in, voice somewhat raised and pained all the same. It quickly silences him, leaving the room quiet once more.

He huffs out a sigh of defeat. After all, she's right - he's *not* being honest. And so, given up, he brings his eyes back over to lock with hers, finding that her gaze is still soft. Still tender. Only...worried. It studies him, concern hidden deep in the vibrant rosy color he's grown to adore.

“It...was only an unpleasant dream,” he confesses. “That is all.”

She’s quiet at first, and the more seconds that pass by, the more tension that builds up around them, sparkling like electricity and making Hordak itch with the need to escape. Escape to where, he isn’t certain, but any place would suffice to get him away from her stare, her concerned expression, *everything.*

Why couldn’t she have just been asleep? Now, they’re both stuck here, clearly uncomfortable and *still* not talking about last night. And he’s certainly not going to be the one to bring it up, either.

Shattering some of the stillness between them, Entrapta shifts in place in her sleeping bag. She looks down for a moment and narrows her eyes, taking on that thoughtful gaze she so often does when pondering how to approach something - most usually social situations she isn’t familiar with or is unsure about.

“Do…” she begins, tone low, “Do you wanna talk? About it?”

Hordak immediately shakes his head. “No. It’s really alright, Entrapta. I don’t wish to bother you.”

“Are you sure? It would probably help, you know. I don’t mind.”

“No, you should just go back to sleep-“

“No, no, it’s really alright. I’m coming over.”

Just like that, without another word, Entrapta picks her body up and off the ground with her pigtails. Albeit a bit wobbly out of fatigue, they swiftly carry her over to Hordak’s bed in seconds. And before Hordak can truly process everything, she sits on the edge of the bed with her legs criss-crossed.

Hordak blinks at her. She fully faces him now, expression shy but gentle nonetheless, yet he can still see the unease. He can see the way she starts to fidget with her fingers and the way her eyes dart away every few seconds as they so often do when she’s nervous or uncomfortable.

He isn't surprised, however. Some tension still sparks between them - it's muted and not as apparent as last night, but it's still *there* nonetheless. Truthfully, he knows it'd most likely be resolved if they just talked about last night. Or, at the very least, if they just stopped pretending things were normal.

But of *course* Hordak had a nightmare, and of *course* Entrapta was awake, and now they are here.

"I mean, you don't *have* to talk about it if you don't want to, of course," Entrapta mumbles, eyes still pointed at some random spot by her feet. "I just...I don't know. It might help."

Hordak shrugs weakly. "I...I don't wish to bother you."

"I don't mind. Really, Hordak, I don't."

In the end, he sighs.

What does he have to lose?

"It was...with Prime. Well, not entirely," he begins, furrowing his brow as he tries to recall it. The dream is already starting to blur around the edges despite how the fear it caused still seems to linger on him. It's as if his body refuses to forget, but his mind is already on its way to.

"Prime?" she presses. "He was there?"

"Uh...Yes, but also, no. It was...you. Only at first, though. *Then* it was him. Well, it might have been both of you at the same time. I can not remember," he says with a shake of his head.

"So...You mean to say he had control of me? Is that it?"

Hordak nods. "Yes, mostly. I believe you also had some control, for you were truly the one talking to me, but he was there, as well. You were using phrases that *he* would say, but at the same time, I thought they were coming from you. It was...some strange

combination of both of you. To say the least, the whole thing was…disorienting. And...unpleasant."

"Did I hurt you?"

"No. You only spoke to me."

"What did I say?"

Hordak hesitates.

How does he answer this? How does he tell her that she said things that all related to last night? Especially when they're both *still* not bringing up what happened. He doesn't want to, and she probably doesn't want to, either. In all honesty, he just wishes they could stop talking about all this. He doesn't want to think about what she said in the dream, about his faults, about Prime, about how Entrapta is certainly still upset with him and he's still conflicted on how to feel with all that happend, about how he doesn't know how to fix this and bringing up what happened in the dream is *not* the way to go, about-

"Hordak?"

"Uh, nothing important. You did not say anything worth repeating."

"...Are you sure? Like I said, you sounded really upset. When you were having the dream, I mean."

Hordak pauses.

….There's no point in running from it anymore, is there?

"You were only saying...things. That you wouldn't normally say. That were...negative. And...related. To what we were talking about. Last night."

Entrapta remains silent for a long moment.

"...Oh."

Hordak doesn't answer. He isn't sure what to say.

"Hordak..."

At that moment, Entrapta finally brings her gaze up. It locks with his, and the world stills around them, freezing them both in place. The corners of her lips tug down, trembling ever-so-slightly, and her eyes soften with something gentle. And when she opens her mouth to continue, her fingers begin to fidget faster with each other, tugging at her gloves and wringing her hands together all the while.

"I…" she begins, voice terribly soft. "I want to-"

"Entrapta, it's alright. We don't have to talk about it. It's late."

"No, no, I really want-"

"I said it's okay," he cuts in. "I'm sorry for mentioning it."

She sighs. "Hordak, you don't have to apologize for that. I asked about the dream. And you answered honestly."

"But I fail to see its importance here. The dream was not even that big of a deal. I'm alright."

"No, you're not. And I want be there for yo-"

"Entrapta, I'm fine," he cuts in, much colder than he meant to. In immediate regret, he tears his gaze away, letting it fall dejected to the ground. He doesn't want to start even *more* tension between them, but here he is, biting back at her when all she wishes to do is help him. She clearly isn't certain on how to approach the situation, and he isn't helping matters.

"I assure you," Hordak begins, voice softer this time. "I will be fine. We don't have to talk about any of this now. About the dream or...last night. I can manage fine-"

“Hordak, no, you’re obviously upset. You’re shaking.”

He stops, ears falling in embarrassment. He looks down at himself, and sure enough, his body shudders, if only a little. Immediately, he wraps his arms around himself for some support, but it’s truly of no use.

“Entrapta, I-“

But all words leave his mouth, for Entrapta places a gentle hand on his. The pressure is light yet apparent all the same, settling the tremors there on his hand for a moment, and he looks up at her in shock. She peers at him with her ruby eyes - eyes that seem to bore into him, that are open and honest.

“We don’t have to talk. About anything, if you don’t want,” she says, voice hardly above a whisper. “But, I can just...stay here. If that would help anything.”

And for the first time all evening, she offers him a small smile. It’s sad and weak, but it’s genuine nonetheless. The corners of her eyes crinkle just as they always do, and her features brighten a little as well.

At the sight, Hordak’s heart softens. Regardless, deep down, he knows it’s not fair despite how she offered it. He tries to counter, “It’s late. You don’t have to stay awake sitting here all night for my sake. Why don’t you go back to the sleeping bag?”

“Really, Hordak, I don’t mind. I’m not that tired.”

He narrows his eyes, studying her. If her half-lidded eyes and drooping figure are anything to go by, then that’s clearly a lie. “Are you certain? How long have you been awake?”

“...Uh...Just. Um. Most of the night.”

Hordak frowns. No wonder she was awake earlier.

“Then you should sleep,” he says. “Honestly, I will be fine. You can go back to the sleeping ba-“

“Hey, wait, I have an idea.”

“Hm?”

“Why don’t I just sleep here?”

Hordak’s heart stops in his chest.

“...H-here? With me?” he croaks out.

“Why not?” Entrapta says, tilting her head to the side. “That way I can sleep, and you won’t be alone. And hopefully you can get some sleep, too.”

Hordak simply stares, mouth agape and ears fallen. He doesn't know what to say. She looks so genuine, so set in her ways on being there for him tonight, and her offer is...not a bad one. After all, the concept of not being alone...and instead with *her...*

It sounds...nice. More so then he’d care to admit.

Though, deep down, he knows that they should probably talk about last night first. About all that they said on the balcony, about all the words they passed between each other. They still haven’t truly resolved anything, and all they keep doing is beating around the bush. Eventually, they’ll have to talk about it.

But in all honesty, Hordak just wants to sleep. It’s awfully late, and he’s tired. Even more, here Entrapta is, offering to be there for him tonight and trying to find some way to break the tension.

This is her own little way, it seems - maybe not through words yet, but kind gestures for now. They seem to be careful steps, helping her test the waters on how she wants to approach everything.

And he’ll take it.

He’s exhausted of the tension at this point, anyway.

“...Alright. That would...be nice.”

Her smile widens.

“Okay.”

And with that, Entrapta starts to make her way under the covers. Hordak lifts them up to allow her in, and once under, he covers the blanket over himself as well. They both spend a moment settling between the fluffy blankets and pillows, until finally, they’re both comfortable.

Hordak looks over at Entrapta, finding her eyes to already be closed. She faces him, her body curled up in on itself beneath the blankets, making her figure smaller than it already is. Even more, she’s close by - closer than Hordak was expecting, though not in a bad way - and he can feel her body heat, can almost hear her faint heartbeat thrumming in her chest.

And he only stares. He doesn’t know why. He simply watches her for a moment, taking note of how her chest rises and falls with each breath and trying to match it with his own to calm himself down. Sure enough, he finds that it helps. His nerves further settle, and he relaxes his tense muscles into the plush mattress.

Her presence certainly is…nice.

But, he wishes she was closer.

The realization startles even Hordak himself. He furrows his brow, trying to understand where the thought came from. They already are close, and their goal of making Hordak feel more comfortable is certainly accomplished, but... *Still.*

He wishes she was closer. Despite everything that happened last night, despite how there still seems to be a figurative wall between them, he wishes she was closer. He wishes her body was pressed against his, and he could hold her in his arms, and all

would be okay. To feel her hair against his skin, to feel her warmth around him, to feel *just* as he always does whenever they hug but now when they both fall asleep - he wants it.

But he doesn't know how to ask for it.

There's still that underlying tension between them, and it's not one he knows for certain how to break.

"Hordak?"

Hordak blinks back to focus, startled out of his train of thoughts at Entrapta's quiet voice. She looks at him now, though her eyes are hardly open and her voice is dreary, so he knows she must be barely awake.

"Hm?"

"I...I want to talk. About last night. On the balcony. I-"

"It's alright, Entrapta. We can talk in the morning."

She's quiet for a moment, and Hordak wonders if she isn't going to answer until she finally pipes back up.

"...Okay."

And with that said, she shuts her eyes and seems to fall asleep.

Hordak studies her a moment longer, gaze soft. He knows she wanted to fix things, to finally talk about last night, to stop beating around the bush. She's been trying to do that all night, it seems.

But it's late for both of them, and Hordak knows morning will come soon enough to talk. She isn't going anywhere, and neither is he.

So, with that thought in mind, Hordak shuts his eyes and lets the peace of unconsciousness take over.

Chapter End Notes

ah, a bittersweet ending to this chapter! don’t worry - they will have an honest conversation with each other. but for now, just let them sleep together - they deserve it :)

comments and kudos are always super appreciated! (and come say hello on tumblr! i’m beckkii there :D)

Questions

Chapter Notes

> new chapter, and we're back to some time with some other characters! i think i've said this before, but i have a soft spot for potential friendships between hordak and adora/catra. obviously it wouldn't be an immediate thing, but over time, i like to imagine it happening
>
> so, for now, we get some moments between them! i hope you all enjoy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak's warm.

That's the first thing he registers when he wakes. This pleasant warmth surrounds him entirely, along with a gentle pressure pressed up against his body. Eyes still shut, he shifts a little in place, only to find that the warmth and pressure never leave him. They must not be blankets, then; they must be something else, something stronger that holds onto him.

He blinks his eyes open, dazed and confused. He's not upset at this little "predicament" - not by a long shot. But, it doesn't make any sense. What could possibly be-

He freezes as his eyes land on the source.

It's Entrapta, her body curled up against his side. Her small head is planted on his chest, and her one arm is wrapped over his middle, holding him close. Even more, her one large pigtail now drapes over the rest of his body with the ends curled around his leg; the other pigtail cascades down her side of the bed, out of their way.

His breath hitches in his throat.

He doesn’t know what to do.

For starters, he doesn’t wish to disturb her. She’s still asleep, snoring softly on his chest, and he knows it’d be cruel to wake her. He isn’t even certain how early it is, and she *had* mentioned she wasn’t sleeping at all last night before she moved into his bed. For all he knows, a few meager hours may be all that passed since then. He isn’t too knowledgeable on Etherian needs, but he knows that’s certainly not enough rest for her.

Even more...He doesn’t *want* to move.

Her presence is pleasant against him, and moving away from her to get up for the day sounds less than desirable. He’d rather stay here, wrapped up by her warmth, her touch, her scent. He isn’t certain how she got here in the first place, whether it was something she had done on purpose during the night or simply an accident, but he’s not one to complain. Not at all.

And as he plants a gentle hand on her back to hold her closer, movements slow and careful to not wake her, he decides to just stay here. There’s no reason to get up. There’s no meetings today, no places to go, nothing. She’s here, asleep by his side, and he’s content.

Until his stomach rumbles.

He narrows his eyes, annoyed. He hadn’t noticed much upon first walking, but it’s apparent as ever now - he’s hungry. Terribly hungry, to be honest, bringing on a nauseating feeling in his gut. To be fair, he didn’t eat hardly anything yesterday, for the nerves of the trial and all the initial shock that followed its aftermath were enough to suppress his appetite.

But now?

He *really* should eat.

Her frowns at himself, looking down at Entrapta once more. He wants to stay. So badly, he wants to stay. And he doesn’t want to

risk waking her by moving, either. Perhaps he could just ignore his hunger? He could always wait a little until she wakes up, and they could find breakfast together. He'll manage just fine until th-

His stomach rumbles again, startling him out of his thoughts, and another wave nausea quickly follows. He huffs out a sigh, annoyed at himself and his body's frailty. Why must his body be so *demanding?* Can it not wait a *little* while?

Ah, well. Looks like his moment of peace this morning is over.

As carefully as he can, Hordak pulls his body away from Entrapta and out of her light grasp. Her one pigtail that holds onto him curls in tighter at his withdrawal, seeming to be stubborn on staying. But, by lightly pushing it off, it finally lets him go. And so, movements slow, he's able to crawl out from under covers and move to stand besides the bed.

Once standing, he holds his breath in anticipation. At first, Entrapta shifts in the bed, clearly disturbed from his movements. However, she thankfully settles once more, and her soft snoring picks back up again. Hordak lets out a little sigh of relief before draping the once-disturbed blankets back over her body. He wouldn't want her to be cold, after all.

With that settled, Hordak goes to put on his armor. Having some additional help would certainly make the whole process much faster, but he can make do for now. After several minutes, the armor is finally back on, releasing the tension from his muscles and providing some much-needed relief.

Before leaving the room, he takes a moment to head to the bathroom and take a quick glimpse in the mirror. It's been forever since he's had the chance to see himself face-to-face, and immediately, he frowns at the sight. His eyes are still a vibrant green, despite how he had hopes that they might've turned red by now. Even more, his hair is still white, though that doesn't bother him as much. He'll be able to dye it soon enough. Perhaps, even before his eyes revert back to their red state, he could start

wearing eyeliner again, too. He's certain those little changes would help him feel better, even if only a little.

Now is not the time, however. For now, his only *real* goal is getting some breakfast, and-

He freezes.

Something catches his eye in the mirror.

It's the crystal, glinting in the sunlight that streams in from the window.

He leans closer to the mirror to get a better look. It looks the same as it always has, ever since Entrapta first gave it to him all that time ago. Lightly, he traces a claw over it, feeling the faint ridges of the markings he could never understand.

Though, *now,* he knows that they do say something significant. They're not just decorative markings as he had sometimes predicted - Adora had confirmed as much at the trial. However, she had said that the letterings spelled out only "crystal." But, that can't be, can it? Adora and Entrapta both were acting much too oddly for it to say something as simple as "crystal."

Then...What *does* it say? It can't possibly be anything that special, can it?

And why has Entrapta never told him?

He glances over at her still sleeping in the bed. Perhaps, when she wakes, he could ask her. And this time, they could talk about it in a more private setting. After all, last time it was brought up, they were surrounded by the other princesses. Perhaps that was why she and Adora lied, if it possibly contained something more personal that the others didn't need to know.

But...What? What could be so personal that they had to lie? During a *trial,* even? Sure, it was *Hordak's* trial and the crystal wasn't that relevant to the task at hand, but still.

In the end, he leans away from the mirror and sighs under his breath. He'll figure it out eventually. Maybe…

...Maybe he could even ask Adora about it?

That does sound like a solid plan. Adora would most likely be honest with him, but he is certain that if it was something *really* personal, she wouldn't share it. That might be a good thing, though - he would rather have something personal come from Entrapta herself instead of Adora.

With that thought in mind, Hordak exits the bathroom and heads to the bedroom door. Slowly to mute any sound, he opens the door and takes a peak back towards the bed, glad to find Entrapta still asleep despite his disturbances. And with a final glance, he leaves the room and shuts the door softly behind him.

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It turns out that it isn't too early. For the moment Hordak walks through the hallways, he notices that most doors are open; many of the princesses must be awake by now. Following the faint sound of voices, he heads towards the front doors of the castle. And by further listening through the doors, he realizes most people must be out there in the courtyard. Some part of him wishes Entrapta was with him right now; after all, he still can't help but feel uncomfortable around everyone, and walking out there alone right now sounds less than pleasant.

But suddenly, his stomach rumbles again, almost as if sensing his doubt and urging him on. He knows that food must be out there with the rest of the princesses, if it were to be anywhere. Besides - he promises himself that it'll just be a quick trip. He'll go out, grab some food unnoticed, and head right back in. It'll be painless and over before he knows it, he's certain.

Well, here goes nothing, then.

Swallowing his fear as best he can manage, Hordak opens the front doors and steps out into the courtyard.

Immediately, he realizes that he was right about people most likely being here. Several princesses and others are scattered about the courtyard, each in their own little sections with their own little cliques. They all seem absorbed in their conversations, effectively ignoring Hordak, and he relaxes a bit. This'll be easier, then.

Even better, his searching eyes quickly land on their target - a table of food. It's long and similar in design to a picnic table, and a tablecloth decorates the top. Of course, that's not all that decorates it, for various types of breakfast food and drinks appear there. From what Hordak can see, it mostly seems to consist of breakfast sandwiches, coffee, milk, fruit, and other little pastries. The whole thing isn't too extravagant, but generous all the same.

Before taking a step out the doors, Hordak formulates a little game plan to follow in his mind: walk quietly out, keep eyes down, ignore any possible stares, and grab only a sandwich to avoid wasting time at the table. That's all. That's it. He can do this.

With that settled, Hordak carefully steps out.

As he treks through the courtyard, various voices float and carry on around him, seemingly unbothered with his presence. Though, he isn't *entirely* sure; after all, his eyes are still locked to the ground, and he doesn't dare look up to see if any one has paid him any attention yet. It's not worth the risk.

In what feels like forever, he finally arrives at the table. And not leaving a moment to waste, he stretches out a hand to grab a breakfast sandwich. He almost reaches it, his hand so close, and then-

"Hordak?"

Hordak's heart drops at the sound of a voice.

Perfect. Just perfect.

Eyes wide and body frozen in place, he snaps his gaze over in the direction of the voice. It was certainly familiar, one that he's heard many times before, but thankfully one that doesn't spark fear in his heart. No, it's nothing like that. Instead, the voice is one that's always kind with him - approachable and friendly, even. And when his eyes finally land on the owner of the voice, his initial suspicions are confirmed, and he feels a little wave of relief wash over him.

It's Adora.

Though, that's not all. Right beside her stands Catra, arms crossed over her chest as she peers at Hordak with her vibrant, now-unreadable eyes. Immediately, Hordak tears his own gaze away from hers, unable to meet it. To be honest, he's still uncertain on how to feel about her, and he has no clue where they stand with each other. They're not friends, but he doesn't hate her. He supposes that she doesn't hate him, either. So, what does that make them, then?

"Hey! Uh, surprised to see you out here," Adora says, cutting Hordak off his train of thought. She smiles at him, though it wavers in that awkward way it tends to do. However, all of a sudden, a frantic look crosses her features, and she spits out, "Uh, I mean, not that it's *weird* or anything. For you to be here. To eat. Um, that's totally fine, of course! Just, uh...Usually Entrapta is with you."

"She is still sleeping," Hordak answers. All the while, he tries to keep his voice even and calm, attempting to balance out Adora's unsteadiness in this whole interaction to make it somewhat less awkward. He's not sure if he's doing a good job.

"Still?" Catra says, quirking a brow. "Huh. That's weird. It's pretty late, and it's not really like Entrapta to be lazy. Or you, either. We were kinda wondering where you two were."

Hordak shrugs. "She and I did not get much rest. We had a...late night, I suppose."

Catra smirks at that, and something oddly mischievous sparkles in her eyes. She huffs out a short laugh, saying, "A late night, you say-"

She doesn't even get a chance to finish, for Adora swiftly elbows her in the ribs, cutting off her sentence. She then tosses Catra a bothered glare, but Catra appears unfazed as she giggles back at her. And all Hordak can do is watch the interaction between them with a puzzled gaze, trying to connect the scattered pieces on what they're talking about yet failing in doing so.

"A, uh, late night, huh?" Adora pipes up, words directed at Hordak once more. Her gaze is soft and genuine as she continues, "Did something happen?"

Hordak looks away. How is he supposed to answer that? Should he be honest about his and Entrapta's fight? Or should he just lie to ignore the conversation topic and move on to something else? It's really none of their business, anyway.

So in the end, he chooses the latter.

"...No."

"That sounds pretty unconvincing," Catra counters, tone amused. Hordak snaps his gaze back over in time to watch her pluck a grape out of a fruit bowl and pop it in her mouth; but then, suddenly, she shifts her attention away from the grapes to shoot Hordak a stare. A piercing stare, one that seems to bore into him and see into his thoughts, and almost seems...genuine. Not bitter, not bothered with his presence here, but...genuinely curious. Genuinely wanting to know about what happened.

Hordak isn't sure how to feel about that.

He still isn't even sure how to feel about *her.*

And so, just as quickly, he tears his eyes away. They topple to the floor, studying the plush grass on the ground and taking extra -

and truthfully unnecessary - care to focus on the occasional flower that is scattered about.

"You sure?" Adora pries, voice soft. "I mean, you don't have to answer, I was just checking in to-"

"We had a...fight, I suppose. That is all."

Catra and Adora are both silent for a moment, and Hordak isn't even certain if they'll respond. He keeps his eyes stuck to the ground all the while, too fearful to look up, too fearful to see their expressions. Because the moment the words escaped him, the moment regret struck him. They don't need to know about his personal matters. They don't need to know about *anything.*

Yet, here he is, speaking out without thinking to his former enemy and former second-in-command.

"A...fight?" Adora finally says, prompting Hordak to lift his gaze back up. She furrows her brow in thought, confusion written on her features. "What...What about?"

"Nothing important," Hordak immediately answers. He already dug himself into this mess - no need to dig himself even deeper. "It only...hindered our evening. That is all."

Adora hums under her breath, appearing thoughtful once more. And as much as Hordak wishes she could just drop the whole thing, some part of him is oddly...thankful, it seems, for her genuine curiosity in this situation. He knows as an important leader here that it's only her job to check on everyone, yet…It feels nice, somehow. Nice to have people other than Entrapta who actually wish to talk to him about more personal matters, strange as it is to admit. Truthfully, he's not used to this, and he can't help but feel that it is...pleasant.

"Did you two...make up?" she suddenly asks, looking up at him with hints of worry hidden deep in her eyes.

Hordak hesitates.

Because truth be told, he has no clue.

Technically speaking, he and Entrapta didn't make up. They never passed apologies, never shared words of affirmation to the other that it was okay, that the past was in the past, that they would leave that all behind them. They never spoke about forgiveness, about their feelings.

Yet...On the other hand, Entrapta showed kindness to him in his distress. And he, without hesitation, accepted it. He allowed her to be close, to help him through last night, to be there for him. They slept in the same bed, and there was no pent up resentment, no wall between them that held them back. Hell, he even woke up with her in his *arms.*

So, in all honesty, he has no clue.

"I am...uncertain," he says, ears flattening in some sense of shame. "It is...complicated, to say the least. She was very angry at first, and I was, too. But, as the night progressed, we both were...not? Anymore? I suppose?"

"Huh," Catra cuts in, grabbing a few more grapes to snack on. Between bites, she adds, "It's kinda hard to imagine Entrapta actually *angry.* Like, genuinely."

Hordak can't help but smile a little at that. "Oh, don't doubt it. She can be if she wants to be."

Catra smirks as well, finally popping the last grape in her mouth. She leans against the table, eyes landing somewhere far away as she says, "Come to think of it, I had actually seen her pretty riled up once. It was a while ago, back when she wanted to stop the portal from opening. She was really upset, and then I…"

Her words trail off then, her ears lowering and gaze falling the ground. She doesn't even attempt to finish that sentence, and Hordak is grateful - any chance at talking about the past during the war and that whole portal mess is the last thing he'd like to do. *Certainly* around all these princesses and Adora, as well.

“Well, uh, I’m sure it’ll all work out between you two,” Adora says, voice cheery. It cuts away at the darkened atmosphere Catra had set, alleviating some of the tension much to Hordak’s relief. She adds on, tone calmer, “And with whatever is going on, I’m sure Entrapta will come around, if she hasn’t already. I wouldn’t worry about it. She really cares about you, you know - I don't think she’d let something like this hurt your friendship.”

At Adora’s words, Hordak’s ears flatten, and he can’t help but smile - it’s a small smile, though a smile nonetheless. And he’s just about to say something in response when another voice cuts in from afar.

“Adora! Catra! Are you two coming, or what?”

Somewhat startled, Hordak looks over in the direction of the voice. It’s coming from a corner of the courtyard, several yards away from where their little trio stands by the food table. And as Hordak’s eyes land on it, he spots the possible owners of the voice - Glimmer and Bow, both sitting by their breakfasts on a picnic blanket and waving with wide smiles at Catra and Adora.

“Yeah, I’m coming! Let me just grab a sandwich,” Catra yells back with a quick wave. And just as she had said, she swipes a sandwich off the table before striding over towards them. Over her shoulder, she adds, “Hurry up, Adora, or everyone’s food will be all cold by the time you get over here.”

“I’m coming, I’m coming,” she says, eyes darting back towards the table to scan it quickly. “Just let me get something here.”

For a moment, Hordak simply stands there, waiting. He doesn’t want to get in her way by reaching over to grab a sandwich, and he doesn’t want to ask her to move over, either. So, he resolves to simply standing there idly, aware of the awkwardness of the situation but knowing he has no other choice. Honestly, he still wishes that he had avoided this whole interaction with them in the first place. He probably would’ve been back in his room by now, food in hand, and-

Hordak's thoughts suddenly cut off, for something glints in his vision and catches his eye.

It's the crystal.

He looks at the magenta tech on his chest, eyes squinting at the occasional glint of sunlight it flashes at him. Involuntarily, he starts to trace the patterns with his gaze, mind curious and searching for understanding in its confusing markings. Unrealistically, he wishes he could somehow find meaning all of a sudden, but he knows he can not-

He pauses.

Wait a minute.

He looks up over Adora, still searching for suitable food to put on her plastic plate before she goes to join her friends. And as he watches her, just like that, the realization dawns on him.

Now's his chance to ask her.

After all, they're alone now. They're not at all a trial, not surrounded by princesses and other people of the Rebellion, none of that. No, they're both alone now, and he's certain she could easily tell him. She could even just provide him with some insight to what it says, if not the whole picture. He could ask now. He really could. It would be that easy.

And without a second thought, words start to tumble out of his mouth.

"Adora, may I ask you something?"

She freezes in place, seemingly startled at his sudden question. Eyes wide, she looks over at him, though her gaze quickly becomes intrigued more than anything. Taking a step closer, and with an amiable smile gracing upon her lips, she answers.

"Yeah?"

He looks to his chest. Lightly, he rests a gentle claw on it, feeling the engraving of its surface on the pad of his skin. He hesitates a moment, knowing deep down that he could just let it go, that he doesn't have to ask her. It may even very well be something personal that Adora *shouldn't* share, and it might not be worth bothering her by asking. But, yet…

The burning desire to know is there. Deep, deep within him, these flames of desire spark and grow and urge him on.

So once more, he can't help the question as it falls from his mouth.

"Can you tell me what the crystal says?"

Adora's eyes widen.

She doesn't answer at first. All she does is stare at him, features shocked and jaw unmoving and body frozen in place. She then opens her mouth, though initially, no words come out. They all seem to be stuck there, refusing to move past her lips and just let him *know.*

"...Uh," Adora finally says, rubbing her neck as a sheepish grin tugs up the corners of her lips. "It, uh, says 'crystal,' remember? Like I said at the tri-"

"That can't be true, Adora."

At that, her mouth snaps shut. She tears her eyes away, her smile wilting as she begins to rock anxiously on her heels back and forth, back and forth, on an endless loop. She doesn't answer for several long moments as she does so, and all Hordak can do is watch her rock back and forth, back and forth.

"I...Uh…" she mutters, "Well…"

Suddenly, the rocking stops. She sighs, drawing her gaze back towards Hordak and staring him dead in the eyes. That sheepish

smile returns once more, but this time, it's a bit more sincere, more sure of herself.

"I...shouldn't be the one to tell you what it says."

Hordak quirks a brow. "Why not?"

"It's, uh...personal, I think," Adora explains. "I don't think Entrapta would want it coming from me. She should be the one to tell you instead."

"But, she never has," Hordak counters, tone beginning to rise. He doesn't want to get angry - not in the slightest - but frustration is starting to build in his gut, piling up along with that burning desire to just *know.* "If it's so personal that only *she* can tell me, then why won't she? What am I missing?"

"Maybe she doesn't want to yet," Adora says, her smile softening. "It...uh, I don't know, might not be the right time for her. I'm not sure."

Hordak narrows his eyes. "'Right time?' What does that mea-"

"I really gotta go," Adora says, placing the last of her breakfast on her plate. She tosses him an apologetic glance as she starts to walk away, adding, "But just trust me, alright? Wait for Entrapta to tell you about it, not me. I'm...I'm sorry."

And with that said, she's gone, leaving Hordak alone by the table and even more confused than he was before this whole conversation.

Chapter End Notes

sorry, hordak - you'll figure it out eventually ;)

comments and kudos are super appreciated! and come say hi on tumblr - i'm beckkii there :)

Here

Chapter Notes

> back with entrapta and hordak 1 on 1 time! i really liked writing this chapter - less angst, finally, and much more comfort :)
>
> i hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak knows he can't just stand here forever.

Yet, mustering the courage to open the bedroom door and enter his and Entrapta's shared room isn't working out too well.

It's foolish, really. Perhaps even a tad childish. Yet, the thought of going in and facing Entrapta after all that occured between them sounds...less than pleasant. Sure, they communicated last night, but it was...different. They were both tired. It was the middle of the night. Their conversation was focused on something *mostly* unrelated to the night on the balcony. It all was something more natural, less stilted.

But, now?

Hordak knows that the moment he opens the door, it'll be awkward.

And uncomfortable, too.

Even worse, could she still be mad? He doesn't think so, but there's always that possibility. She could be silent when he walks in, refusing to say anything, mask down so she doesn't have to look at him. Truly, she could just leave him forever, right then and there, and decide not to look back. She could let him do community service alone as she spends time with the princesses, wanting to do away with such a failure as he is. She could-

Hordak sighs. He's overthinking it, he knows, but the tension is still there. His claw grips tighter on the plastic plate of tiny food he had brought her for breakfast - a peace offering, and one that might provide something to talk over if nothing else. Plus, he still hasn't eaten his breakfast sandwich yet. Perhaps they could share breakfast together, and that would provide a moment of respite between them if all else fails?

In that moment, Hordak sucks in a breath and slowly releases it, letting the nerves leave his body. It's fine. He'll be fine. It won't be awkward. It won't be uncomfortable. If there's anyone he feels safe around, it's Entrapta. He can do this.

And with those reassuring thoughts in mind, he opens the door.

Immediately, his eyes locate Entrapta. She's perched on the bed on all fours, seeming to be pulling the sheets up as she makes the bed. Her mask is absent from her head, and her hair is somewhat messy from laying in the bed, so Hordak assumes that she must've just woken up.

However, at the sound of the door opening, her once-focused movements falter. Her head whips in the direction of the door, eyes wide and mouth dropped in surprise. And just as quickly, something akin to fear strikes her features. Worry. A hint of panic. Her fingers clench a little tighter around the sheets she was pulling on, and her muscles visibly freeze up, holding her in place on the bed as she stares straight at him.

And all Hordak can do is stare back. The world stills around them, seeming to hold them both in place for what feels like forever as her lilac eyes collide with his green. Neither of them move, and neither of them speak. All they do is stare, and stare, and stare.

Until, dreadfully so, reality catches up to Hordak. He has to say something. *Anything.* Swallowing hard, his voice finally shatters the glass of tension that once suffocated them.

"Entrapta, I am-"

“Hordak.”

He blinks, somewhat shocked at her voice as it cuts him off. It was only one word, two syllables, yet it held so much meaning with her tone. It was deep, serious even, and Hordak can’t help but realize in that moment how she never seems to use that sort of voice around the other princesses. He’s spent enough time with her around the others to now notice it. There seems to be a subtle difference, a shift, in the way she speaks around him. It’s not a bad thing - not at all. In fact, it feels...special to him.

For when she’s with him, a figurative mask seems to come down. And Hordak can see it, *hear* it now, in her voice. In the way her tone has dropped, has gone less bubbly and animated to please others, has become more *real.*

“Hordak,” she repeats again, looking down. In a flash, her two pigtails sweep her off the bed and place her on the ground. From there, she takes a few steps forward until she stands right before Hordak, now looking up at him. Something kind and gentle hides in her eyes, and Hordak finds himself lost in them, entranced at the way she stares at him.

“I...I’m sorry.”

Hordak’s heart stutters at her words. He gives a little shake of his head, silencing her before she can speak again. “Entrapta, you don’t have-“

“No, no, listen,” she cuts in. The corners of her lips tug down, her features melted in a state of sadness, and her eyes are as soft as ever as they gaze up at him. “I want to apologize. I shouldn’t have yelled on the balcony. That was...really, *really* uncalled for. And wrong. And I’m sorry.”

Hordak’s ears droop. He doesn’t even have to think on how to respond to her words.

“It’s alright, Entrapta.”

At that, Hordak brings his body down to her eye level. It's strange, doing this to be face-to-face with her, for usually she lifts herself up on her pigtails to reach him. But now, it's his turn to adjust. He puts the plate of her food along with his breakfast sandwich on a nightstand nearby, allowing him to face her fully with no distractions around him.

"I should be the one to apologize," Hordak says. "I-"

"What? No, no you don't have to," Entrapta swiftly cuts him off, giving a little shake of her head and one hand all the while. "I was the one who made everything about me that night. What you're going through, and how you're adjusting to all that's going on right now with the trial and new freedom and *everything,* has *nothing* to do with me. And I made it that way. I tried to be a victim when that's the *last* thing I should've done."

"You were upset that night. I was angry at the prospect of being spared punishment, yet you were excited. So, I understand your frustration."

"But that doesn't give me an excuse to guilt you, or to yell," she says, voice stern, almost as if berating herself. "Like I said, I made it about me. And I shouldn't have. I should've listened to you, let you talk more about how *you're* feeling, not...not make it all about me."

Once more, she gazes directly at him, eyes softening as they bore into him. And yet again, she speaks the same words as before, tone gentle as ever.

"And I'm sorry, Hordak."

Hordak ears fall again, a tenderness tugging at his heart all the while. He only gazes back at her for a moment, studying the way she waits anxiously for a response with crinkled eyes and a worried frown and fidgeting fingers.

And without hesitation, he offers her a small smile to ease her anxieties, paired with soft-spoken words.

“It truly is alright, Entrapta.”

At that, the tension in her features diminishes. The corners of her lips tug up into a shy smile, lighting up the rest of her face as her smiles always seem to do, and her hands finally release each other from their nervous fidgeting.

“I just want you to be happy,” she says then, tone gone soft in that rare way that always flutters Hordak’s heart. “Not going through the motions, or just managing with everything, or any of that. I want you to be *truly* happy with where you are.”

She pauses, but only for a moment.

“Because your happiness means the most to me.”

At those words, a sudden lump makes home in Hordak’s throat. He tries to swallow it, get rid of it, ignore it. But, as always, it’s strong and withstanding, failing to leave him alone. And all he can do is look at Entrapta, stunned on what to say, her words echoing in his mind.

“And I know these things take time,” Entrapta says, looking away for a moment to gather her thoughts. “And certain mindsets don’t change overnight. Not at all. But…There’s still always a chance to heal. To get better. And like I said, it’ll take time, of course. But…”

As her sentence trails away, her features become tender, staring at him with those ruby eyes that he can never seem to look away from. And then, she offers him a kind smile - one that now stirs something fierce in his heart.

“...I’m here for you. Through it all.”

With those words, something warm bursts in Hordak’s eyes. It wavers his vision, creates a blur of Entrapta’s figure before him. They build up the tighter the lump grows in his throat, more and more, and he tries once again to swallow. To blink the tears away. To remain stoic and strong and hide his feelings, all from some ingrained instinct in his brain.

But all he can think about is her and her words, in the sincerity in the way she spoke, in the utter desire and hope for a positive change in his mindset despite how he doesn't deserve this, does he? No, he doesn't deserve this or her or *anything* else. Yet, here she is, open in expressing her hopes for him in a way that's all-too Entrapta and all-too endearing.

And the tears stay there in his eyes. They refuse to fall, but he can't blink them away, either. So, he's stuck staring at her, not knowing what to say and-

"Aww, Hordak," Entrapta says, cutting off his train of thought. She chuckles a little, but it's not in a mocking way - it comes across as more of a nervous, kind giggle. "Why're you crying?"

"I am not-"

But his words quickly cut off, for the tears begin to fall.

He looks away, ashamed. Ashamed at his frailty, at his display of weakness. It's only a few stray tears that roll down his cheeks, but they're tears all the same, and he never liked crying at all in front of people. Even worse, he can still sense Entrapta's figure out of the corner of his eye.

And through it all, all he can think about is the tightness in his throat, the hot tears slowly trailing over his cheeks, and the burden of shame and embarrassment . She hasn't moved yet, so surely she must be judging him, must be thinking he's weak and pathetic, must be-

"Aw, hey, it's okay, Hordak."

Before Hordak even has a chance to react to Entrapta's words, a pigtail has reached out to his cheek, gently guiding his face towards hers.

Their eyes lock. Teary green against soft ruby.

And she smiles. So warmly, she smiles, her features lighting up with it.

Hordak's heart lights up a bit, too.

"My...apologies," he says, his gaze tumbling to the ground. He may be facing her now, but at the very least, he allows himself to look away. "I did not wish to-"

"Hordak, you don't have to apologize. Besides, crying is actually good for you - the brain releases pent up chemicals such as endorphins to make you feel better," she explains, words playful but genuine all the same.

The corners of his lips tug up at that. "That still does not make it any less embarrassing."

"It's not, though," she says. "Nothing shameful in expressing your feelings!"

"I...suppose so," Hordak says after a long moment, now using the back of his hand to finally wipe away the drying tear tracks off his cheeks. He then heaves a sigh, steadying his breathing once more and finally clearing that obnoxious lump in his throat. Entrapta is certainly right - he truly *does* feel better.

Well, not to mention feeling better because of Entrapta's reassurance. Just another thing he can't help but feel he doesn't deserve, yet she provides him nonetheless.

And so, with a weak smile, he looks up at her.

"Thank you, Entrapta."

Immediately, she matches the smile, though hers is much brighter. If his was the moon, hers was the sun, her happiness radiating off her for Hordak to reflect. Her joy has always been contagious, hasn't it?

"'Course!" she exclaims, though she looks as if she wants to add something else. However, before she can do so, her gaze wanders to somewhere beside Hordak, landing on the nightstand where he left the food. She studies it for a moment, and Hordak can pinpoint the exact second she notices the tiny food, for her smiles widens even further.

"Oh! You brought food!"

Hordak nods. "Breakfast is being held outside, but I would prefer...not to spend the morning with the other princesses. I was not sure if you wanted to, so I brought food with me in case you wanted to eat here as well. But, if you'd like to go out to be with your friends and eat there, then that's-"

"No, no, I'd like to eat here, too," she interjects. "Honestly, I'm not feeling up to seeing all of the other princesses right now, either. Probably because it's early, or maybe because of all the chaos lately, but…"

"I understand," Hordak says, Truly, he does - especially with the whole "chaos" aspect. He's been through enough chaos with the other princesses to last a lifetime.

"Well, let's eat, then!"

With that said, Entrapta snatches the plate with a pigtail and hops back up onto the bed. Hordak follows suit, sitting before her on the bed, and Entrapta sets the plate of their little breakfast before them both.

As Hordak starts to eat his sandwich, Entrapta uses a pigtail to grab a tiny waffle off the plate. She takes a bite, humming approvingly, before she swallows and pipes up, "You know, Hordak…"

His ears perk up. "Hm?"

"A couple of nights ago, before your trial, I was talking to Perfuma," she says. "She told me that she's offering this thing

where you...talk about your feelings, I believe? And she helps you through it? Something like that."

Hordak's eyes widen. If she's going where he suspects she's going with this…

"And I know Adora's forcing Catra to do it, so you wouldn't be alone in it. I mean, I don't think you'd do it *with* Catra, but you wouldn't be the only one to spend time with Perfuma to-"

"Entrapta, are you referring to...therapy?"

"Yes!" she beams, snapping her fingers. "That's the word I was looking for. Therapy."

Hordak immediately shakes his head. "I am *not* doing therapy."

"Aw, c'mon, I think it'd be great," Entrapta says, her smile fading into a frown. "Honestly, even *I* kind of want to take her up on it. She said it's great for everyone, even if you don't need any serious help. Maybe I'd like it!"

She falls silent for a moment, looking away and seeming lost in thought as she scratches her chin with a strand of hair. She then furrows her brow, remaining quiet for another moment longer, before she finally speaks back up.

"Though, Perfuma and I never were good friends, so maybe I wouldn't like it with her. To be honest, I don't think she likes me very much."

"What? Why would you assume that?" Hordak asks, quirking a brow.

"She kind of...Well, she put me on a leash."

She pauses.

"More than once."

“A *leash?”* Hordak roars.

“No, no, it’s fine! It’s in the past!” Entrapta says with a weak smile, waving her hands to console Hordak. She’s not doing a very good job, however, for anger continues to kindle within Hordak, burning in his gut as hot as ever.

A *leash?* On *Entrapta?* How could-

“She’s still really nice!” Entrapta continues, her smile wavering awkwardly in a fashion that almost mimics Adora. “I’m not trying to turn you away from going to her for help.”

“I am *not* getting help from someone who treated you like a *pet.”*

“Hordak, c’mon, that’s not what I was trying to do here. We just didn’t work well together. That’s all.”

He looks away then, eyes narrowed and a pout gracing his lips. He crosses his arms, mumbling under his breath, “I still dislike the idea. *Especially* with what you just told me. I-“

All of a sudden, Entrapta giggles, cutting him off.

“What?” Hordak questions, his gaze now snapping back towards her. “What is so funny?”

“Nothing,” she says, though her continuous giggles contradict that statement. Her smile widens, and a tinge of pink blush colors her cheeks. “It’s just…”

Her words fall away for a moment as she looks at him. And suddenly, her smile turns into something less goofy, something more sincere.

“It’s cute. Seeing you get all mad. On my behalf.”

Hordak’s ears fall. Heat crawls up his cheeks, and he looks away once more, unable to maintain their shared gaze.

“Of course I am mad,” he growls. “Anyone in their right mind would be.”

Out of the corner of his eye, he watches as she gives a little sheepish shake of her head, her smile and blush decorating her face all the while. She looks to the ground, her brow furrowing as if pondering something, and Hordak catches sight of her hands starting to shake - only a little. And she stays like that for several long moments, hands quivering and brow furrowed in thought and blush growing on her cheeks.

Concern crossing his features, Hordak brings his head back to fully face her. Why are her hands shak-

But he doesn't even have a chance to finish that thought. For all of a sudden, Entrapta leans over, closing the short distance between them, before planting a kiss on his cheek.

His heart stops. Soft. Her lips are soft, *terribly* soft, against his skin, and he hardly has the chance to fully register it before she pulls away. Yet, he can almost still sense it, can almost still feel the echo of her lips against his cheek. And the sensation faintly remains there, failing to fully disappear and allowing him to hold onto it as best he can as the word blurs around him, as his vision seems to fail him, and all he can focus on is the memory of her lips.

He blinks. Tries to reign himself back in, despite how his heart is pounding hard in his chest, despite how his head is reeling and whirring and clouding with fuzziness that he can’t clear. For all he can think about is what had just happened, how it had felt, what it now *means.*

Slowly, he brings his eyes back to focus on Entrapta before him. She’s closer than ever now, half-sitting in his lap, and he can faintly hear her pounding heartbeat in her chest. She looks away, eyes toppling to the ground, though that sheepish smile still makes home on her lips. Even more, that light blush from before is much more apparent now, painting her face a bright red that

accents her scarlet eyes. Her hands, now planted on her lap, continue to shake, though increasingly prominently now.

"S-sorry," she mutters, laughing a little. "I didn't mean to-....I-I should've asked, I just-...I wanted to show you that I-"

She gives another little shake of her head, silencing her own words. And then, finally, she draws her eyes back to lock with Hordak's. The world stills around them, and all he can do is focus on her gaze, his heartbeat still thundering in his ears. She opens her mouth to speak once more, but just as quickly, she shuts it.

So instead of speaking, she climbs fully into his lap and wraps her arms around him. Her arms tighten, making the embrace as close as ever with her face smushed up on his chest and the rest of her body pressed up against his.

"...I'm glad you're here with me," she mumbles. "After everything. With the princesses, and the trials, and...everything. I'm so glad you're still here."

Hordak's ears turn down. Without hesitation, he wraps his arms around her small frame, returning the hug. As he does so, something warm blossoms in his chest. It flutters and spreads out, filling him with a sense of peace he hasn't felt since their last embrace before the trial. And all he can do is take it in - the pleasant pressure of her body, the feeling of her touch, and the comfort of her presence.

And he agrees. Despite everything, despite the dark part of his mind nagging him that he doesn't deserve this, that he still deserves punishment from the princesses, that this isn't where he should be, he agrees with her words.

"I'm glad I'm here, as well," Hordak says back, voice soft.

Entrapta's embrace tightens further in answer, humming contentedly under her breath. And they stay there like that for a long while, holding each other in the morning light. With a sigh, Hordak lightly rests his chin on her head and closes his eyes

before his mind starts to wander. He starts to think about Entrapta nearby, about her warm presence so close, about how he wishes he could find the words to explain how she makes him feel. To show her that he's more than grateful for all she had said today, to let her know that he cherishes her as she does with him. He wants to let her know - so badly, he wants to.

He isn't sure how, however. He could tell her, but something about that seems inadequate now. He wants to show her in a different way, to-

The stars.

The thought of them springs into his head, and they stay there, as perfect as an idea as ever.

He could take her to see the stars.

He had promised, had he not? And they *do* have some time until he has to begin his reconstruction projects, don't they?

Though, deep down, he knows it's a bad idea. He's been ordered to stay in Bright Moon for the time being, yet here he is, wishing to leave with Entrapta for the time being. But, surely they will return before they have to begin the projects. Surely the princesses won't be mad once they arrive back in Bright Moon. So...

It's alright to do this then, correct?

He sighs. He's going to regret this, he's certain. But for Entrapta, it's worth it.

"Entrapta?"

"Hm?" she mumbles against his chest.

"We never went on that trip to space yet, did we?"

At those words, Entrapta's head snaps up. Her features brighten, eyes beginning to sparkle and body already starting to thrum with excitement. And she smiles, wide as ever, in a way that brings color to her cheeks.

And in that moment, Hordak knows that it's worth it.

Chapter End Notes

hey, how can you expect me to write an entrapdak fic and NOT let them go to space together? :P

comments and kudos are always super appreciated! (and come say hi on tumblr - i'm beckkii there! :))

The Stars

Chapter Notes

> oh boy, we're nearing the end here! this chapter is on the longer side, but consider it the climax. the next (and last) chapter will be much shorter as a sort of resolution
>
> i hope you all enjoy! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Whether or not this is a bad idea he'll eventually regret, Hordak knows he can't turn back now.

The night air is crisp and chilly as they push open Bright Moon's front doors with a creak. Entrapta stands right by his side, as she has been ever since they woke in the midst of night and crept out of their room. The entire time, she was practically invisible besides Hordak, remaining silent and moving steadily to not draw any unwanted noise towards them. He remained quiet as well, and he attempted to keep his steps as light as possible. It was somewhat of a struggle with his clunky armor, however.

Regardless, they were able to make it through the castle without waking anyone. But through it all, Hordak still couldn't help but feel that someone had noticed, that someone was ready and waiting to catch them. The whole ordeal certainly is risky - they aren't allowed to leave Bright Moon for the time being, and especially without telling anyone or asking for permission.

Yet, here they are. Running out of Bright Moon. On their way to a spaceship. Not telling anyone. Not asking for permission. *Everything* Hordak knows they're forbidden from doing.

Perhaps this really *was* a bad idea.

"Okay, coast clear!" Entrapta says, a bit too loudly now in the otherwise silent air. "Let's go."

Without saying another word, Entrapta wraps a loose limb of hair around his wrist. And together, hair in hand, they jog through the courtyard. The chilly air whips again Hordak's skin and bemuses his hair, but it feels nice, almost freeing in a way. Technically, there's nothing he's being "set free" of here, but this whole idea of sneaking out with Entrapta is still...well, somewhat exhilarating, he has to admit.

And as he looks down at Entrapta, at her satisfied grin on her moonlit face and lavender hair whipping behind her, his heart skips a beat, both out of excitement and something else he can't quite define.

As if noticing Hordak's stare, Entrapta glances up at him. At the moment of eye contact, her smile then breaks out into something more lively, more genuine. She squeals a little, and as if reading Hordak's thoughts, she exclaims, "Isn't this exciting?"

"'Risky' might be the better term for it," he answers, though he can't help the soft smile that lifts the corners of his lips. He's not wrong in stating it's danger, but oddly enough, guilt or worry aren't weighing him down *too* much anymore. He continues, voice teasing, "I cannot believe I agreed to-"

"Uh, guys?"

Entrapta and Hordak both freeze in place.

Uh oh.

Slowly, Hordak looks over at the sound of a familiar male voice. And there, standing by the edge of the courtyard, are Bow and Adora. They both look at Hordak and Entrapta, eyebrows raised in question.

Great. This is great.

"Uh, hey!" Entrapta chimes, voice cheery. Still, despite her little facade, Hordak can hear the strain and shaking in her tone. "What are you guys doing up this late?"

"We both couldn't sleep, so we came out for some fresh air," Bow says. He tilts his head to the side, adding, "What are *you* two doing up?"

"Um…We…"

Entrapta's words trail off then as she looks up to Hordak for some support. But, all he can do is helplessly look down at her, his heart starting to thrum in his chest. How are they supposed to answer that? They can't exactly lie. Or, can they? How-

"Listen," Entrapta says, turning her gaze back towards Bow and Adora. "Just tell Glimmer that...We'll be back."

"'Be back'?" Adora echoes, her brow quirking further. "Back from where-"

But Adora doesn't even have a chance to finish, for Entrapta's hair tightens around Hordak's wrist, and she urges them both onwards. Together, they continue the rest of their jog through the courtyard, away from Bright Moon and Bow and Adora and *everyone* they're supposed to stick around with for the time being.

"Okay, great talking with you guys!" Entrapta exclaims over her shoulder, voice breathless. "See you later!"

With that, they finally reach the courtyard's exit and make their escape. Bow and Adora never stop them, and Hordak isn't certain if that's a good or bad thing.

He sighs a little under his breath. There really is no going back now, is there?

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Thankfully, Darla seems to remember Entrapta at their eventual arrival. For the moment she stands at the foot of the ship and calls out its name, the ship lights up, whirring to life before their eyes. Immediately following, it lets down the ramp and allows their entrance. Entrapta uses her pigtails to whip her body inside,

as she so tends to erratically move, while Hordak slowly makes his way up.

Oddly enough, it seems Darla recalls Hordak, as well. For the moment he makes his way into the ship's main hull, hearing Darla greet Entrapta, that same robotic voice adds another greeting.

"Hello, Hordak."

He blinks. Should he greet it back? Would that be odd? Entrapta greets the ship, so she clearly doesn't think so, but it's different with her. She's good with technology and AI, while Hordak is not. Perhaps *he* would appear odd greeting the ship because he's not good at-

He shakes his head. He's overthinking it, isn't he?

So in the end, he mutters, "Hello...Darla."

Again, no answer. And Hordak is left staring at everything and nothing in the ship's hull, wondering how he got to this point in his life where he's worrying over appropriate greetings with a ship.

"Alright," Entrapta says from the other side of the ship, digging in the vent and peering at its insides. Her mask is down as she pokes and digs though the exposed wires and panels, making her voice muffled as she continues, "From what I can tell, it looks like the ship is still in great shape for flight! Isn't that right, Darla?"

"Correct. I am at one hundred percent functionality."

"Perfect!"

"Then..." Hordak pipes up, "...Does that mean that we're ready to go?"

At his words, Entrapta's pigtails lift her body up and off the ground, allowing her to stand once more. She walks towards him, flipping her mask up as she does so, before tossing him an easy grin.

“Yup! Though, I still have to make you a suit,” she says, tapping her chin. “But, I already have a design in mind, and I know exactly how I plan to approach it, so that won’t take long at all! Plus, I already have *my* suit stored on the ship, so we won’t have to worry about that. I’d say we’re mostly set, then!”

With that, she squeals once more, her smile shining and fists clenching by her face. Hordak finds himself smiling along as well, softened by her excitement.

“Alright, are you ready, then?” she says, her smile still plastered on her face.

He nods. He had already come this far, and while the threat of getting caught is still there, lingering in the back of his mind, it’s more muted at this point. Now, all he can seem to focus on is Entrapta and her excitement, her hope for their little trip, and her smile.

“Great!”

That said, Entrapta rushes to the control panel. The same purple sphere from before pops out, now embodying Darla in a visible form that Entrapta leans close to.

“Can you take us up, Darla?”

“Affirmative, Entrapta.”

And just like that, the world wavers beneath Hordak’s feet. At first, the ship’s movements are clunky and somewhat unstable as it struggles to maintain perfect balance. Truthfully, he isn’t surprised; while the ship appears to be made of advanced technology, it still looks as if it’s on the older side.

But soon enough, the ship rights itself, and they’re off. Nothing too fast or over-the-top, of course, but still quick enough to take them out of the atmosphere at rapid speeds. Hordak looks down at his feet, recalling all too well the stomach-churning sensation of flight from his years on the Velvet Glove. Oddly enough, he always

enjoyed the initial lift-off, and it was always his favorite aspect of space travel. Though, it was never one he allowed himself to admit. Clones weren't allowed to have "favorites," were they? Regadless, he still did, and he could not deny it.

It seems Entrapta feels the same. For when Hordak looks over at her, her hands are pressed up to the glass as she studies the view outside. Hordak catches sight of dazzled eyes, of a small smile that grows. She giggles a little, leaning closer to the window and breathing fog onto its surface as she watches the world move around her with wonder.

His gaze softens. Truly, he doesn't regret this. Possible punishments and getting in trouble be damned.

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The trip upwards doesn't take long. All the while, Entrapta goes to work on Hordak's space suit. True to her words, she clearly knows what she's doing; within moments, her supplies are sprawled out amidst the main haul, and she's working away. Hordak assists when he can, though work such as this has always been Entrapta's strong suit, and he doesn't wish to get in the way too much.

Once Entrapta says that she can take the rest from here, Hordak takes that as his cue to let her finish on her own. Now, it's his turn to stand by the window and gaze out. He doesn't press up to the glass as Entrapta had done, but he stands close by, arms crossed over his chest and eyes darting about.

The galaxy is as dark and decorative as he last recalls. It's odd, seeing it now in such a different atmosphere than he's used to. Naturally, he'd be surrounded by his brothers amidst the hallways of the Velvet Glove, waiting on Prime's command so that he had something to do other than linger by the windows and gaze outside. Or, on some occasions, he'd be preparing to be sent out for battle on a new planet, taking one last glance at the stars before he'd be commanded to fight and all hell would break loose.

But, now? Here he is, inside a peaceful ship with Entrapta behind him as she works away on the finishing touches of the suit. He listens to her humming, her mumbled words under her breath, and as he steals a quick glance back at her, he catches sight of her body - now hunched over the suit as she works - rock a little side-to-side, yet another mindless movement she does when she's absorbed in her work.

And he smiles, unable to repress the small grin, before he tears his gaze away and focuses back out at the stars.

Truly, he's ready for new memories here. Memories clear of Prime, of his brothers, of wars, of conquers, of guilt and shame and remorse and everything that came along with his past.

He's ready for a new start.

Beginning with Entrapta, it seems.

And he's just about to say something to her when Entrapta breaks out into a fit of giggles, catching him off guard.

He whips around, quirking a brow. "What? What's so amusing?"

"Nothing, nothing, just…" she manages to get out before another round of giggles takes over. He can't see her face beneath the mask she now dons, but regardless, he can still hear the smile in her voice as she adds, "We are gonna get in *so* much trouble for this."

Whatever smile Hordak wore earlier immediately falls. "Trouble...for leaving? I...I'm certain we are fine. I think."

"Hordak, think of it this way," Entrapta says. "Back in the Fright Zone, imagine if you saw two of your soldiers sneaking out in the middle of the night. Then, when prompted, they said that they'll just...be back. Do you trust them?"

"Depends. If they caused disruptions in the past, then likely no. If they did not, then...Perhaps I would take their word for it," Hordak

answers.

"But with *us* right now," Entrapta says, flipping up her mask to reveal a goofy grin, "we're part of the former group."

She begins to laugh once more, smiling from ear to ear. And with a light voice, she continues, "Boy, we're so in trouble for this!"

At her words, Hordak's ears flatten in shame. How is Entrapta so lighthearted about this? *Did* they really make a bad choice? Was this worth it? Could-

"Hordak, don't worry," Entrapta cuts in, interrupting his crashing train of thoughts. Her pigtails lift her up and off the ground then, and they carry her over to where Hordak stands. Still smiling, she adds, "I'm just teasing you! I'm sure it's fine...Probably."

"I dislike the uncertainty in your tone," Hordak scoffs, though worry begins to ease at her reassurance. Only little, however.

"I think being uncertain about everything makes this even more exciting!" Entrapta counters, eyes starting to shine. "Imagine how boring it would be if we went to Glimmer, asked her to see the ship, planned the whole trip down the minute, all that nonsense. This is more fun! More thrilling!"

Hordak shakes his head in dismissal, but despite his facade, the hint of a smile starts to make home on his lips.

"You're insufferable," he teases, though his lighthearted tone and widening smile betrays his words.

Entrapta lets out a short laugh. "I know. Now, c'mon! The suit is finished, so we can get changed!"

With that said, a tendril of hair snakes up towards Hordak, offered as a replacement hand for him to take.

Without hesitation, he takes her hair in his hand, keeping his grip loose to not harm her on accident.

Now holding onto him, Entrapta whips around and races towards the main hallway. Hordak follows close behind, watching as she uses her free pigtail to wrap around the suit, pick it off the ground, and carry it along with her. And together, they pass into the hallway before the door shuts behind them with a whoosh.

Entrapta guides him into the same bedroom as before, back when she first introduced him to Darla. Her pigtail finally releases him from her grasp, as well as her other pigtail's grip on the space suit he made her; she rests it on the bed for now. Following suit, Hordak moves to sit beside it, now watching from the edge of the bed as Entrapta squats down and begins to search through the room's cabinets.

"Hm...It's gotta be here somewhere…" she muffeds, scratching the top of her head with a strand of hair. "I didn't bring it with me to Etheria, so it has to be...Hm…."

"Are you looking for your space suit?" Hordak asks.

"Yup!" she answers. "I gotta say, I'd be really upset if I lost it. It's some of my favorite work, at least as of late! Hm...Where is it, then…?"

Her words trail off then as she continues her little search. Until, suddenly, she pauses in place and straightens up.

"Aha! There it is!"

At that, she dives her hand into the cabinet, pushing through several items and other junk within. She tugs a little and shoves the obstructing objects out of the way, and just like that, she manages to pull it out. Suit in hand, she stands back up and whips around to show Hordak, a beaming smile on her face all the while.

"See! Isn't it neat?" she exclaims, her smile widening with every word. She starts to point at various parts of it, explaining, "This part of the helmet even has open holes that allow my pigtails to slide through perfectly, and they work well enough to keep me

safe from space's atmosphere! And *this* part of the suit was built from high-tech microfibers that I've only ever engineered into one or two of my other projects years ago-"

Hordak smiles a little to himself, allowing Entrapta to explain her suit. Some parts of her explanations are hard to follow, especially with how fast her words get at times, but he doesn't mind. He'd rather sit here and bask in Entrapta's glee then interrupt and ask her to slow down for his sake.

"Okay, enough of that!" she suddenly says. "Let's actually put them on!"

Without a moment to waste, Entrapta takes off her mask and places it on the bed besides Hordak. She then goes on to peel off her overalls and kick them away. Her arm covers and gloves come off as well, leaving her in only her white - and still stained with a grease smudge - tee and black shorts.

Oddly enough, Hordak's eyes widen in shock at the sight of her. He doesn't know why. There's no true reason to be shocked, yet he just can't tear his eyes away. Perhaps it's because he's never seen her without her usual attire, while here she is, dressed down from her everyday get up. She's even without her gloves, as well. And Hordak can't help but stare in surprise.

For one thing, he notices how muscles that are usually hidden beneath clothing are more toned than he'd expected. Even more, Hordak catches sight of several scars and blemishes over her body - most likely results of lab accidents, he guesses. He can see them on parts of her hands, her fingers, her arms, her thighs, everywhere, yet none of them distracts him from her overall beauty.

Beauty.

The word stuns Hordak even himself. But yet, he can't deny it. She's truly beautiful - scars and blemishes and all on her body.

None of them matter. Not at all.

“Uh? Hordak?”

Caught off guard, Hordak blinks back to reality. Only then does he notice that Entrapta has managed to put on her space suit in that time - she now stands before him, fully dressed and holding her helmet in hand.

“Are you going to start getting dressed?” she questions, raising a brow. “You’ve just been...sitting there. Are you alright?”

Immediately, Hordak’s ears fall. Heat spreads on his cheeks, that damn blush, and he looks away while praying she doesn’t notice it.

“Uh, yes, I’m fine,” he stammers before briskly standing up, keeping his eyes locked on the floor all the while. He can still feel Entrapta’s stare as it burns into him, curious and confused, though he tries his best to ignore it as he grabs his own suit off the bed.

Initially, he starts to take off his armor with no assistance. He knows he can do it, and he decides it’d be best to manage it on his own. But, sure enough, the movements become a bit difficult to manage, and Entrapta quickly notices. She helps him take off the armor, leaving him only in his underdress. From there, Entrapta aids Hordak on putting on the suit, as well.

For a moment, Hordak only studies it. It truly is a great achievement for Entrapta, he can tell as much - the entire suit fits comfortably on his body, and the material is soft against his skin. It’s slim and not bulky, as well, which Hordak appreciates. Plus, Hordak notices something on his chest - an empty slot, perfectly crafted in the shape of a crystal. A certain crystal, he realizes.

“How does it feel?” Entrapta asks, knelt down by his side as she expects part of the suit. Her pigtails continue to carry her around here and there as she continues her little inspection. “I didn’t include a helmet because I assumed you don’t need one. Am I right? Your species can breathe in space, can’t it?”

“That is correct. Clones don’t require oxygen as Etherians do.”

“Okay, good, good, just making sure. Also, don’t worry if the suit feels too heavy right now - it hasn’t been powered yet. I designed the suit to be similar to your armor, where the same crystal can power both,” she states. “I know that technically being in space would alleviate any strain on your body, but I still wanted to maximize comfort when you’re still affected by gravity.”

Ah, so he was correct in his observations from before, Hordak realizes. He looks down at his chest once more, tracing the familiar crystal-shaped outline with a gentle claw.

However, a hovering shadow appears directly in his field of view, and he pauses. He looks up, finding Entrapta before him, her body held up to his height with the use of her pigtails. The moment they lock eyes, she offers a smile to him, and Hordak then notices what she’s holding in her hand - the crystal.

“Okay, this should power it up,” she says, moving to put it in.

And just like that, the suit comes to life around him, and immediate relief washes over his body.

He looks at her, finding her studying his reaction with both hope and hints of worry hidden there. Immediately, he smiles at her to alleviate any of her worries, and she matches his smile in relief.

“So, it’s good?” she asks, voice eager. “It works well? Feels alright?”

“More than alright, Entrapta,” he says. “Thank you. Truly, I appreciate the effort that went into this.”

Her smile softens at that as a hint of blush colors her cheeks. She looks down, almost bashful in a sense, and her blush deepens. But before he can study her reaction any longer, her pigtails lower her back to the ground.

However, she’s not faced away from him for long. For almost immediately, she whips back around. And there, she offers her hand out for him to take.

Hordak freezes in place at the sight.

It's not that big of a deal, he knows. It's only a hand being offered, just as acquaintances do in politeness and friends do in greeting and lovers do in showing affection. Yet, with *her,* he knows that it's...different.

Most of the time she uses her hair. Hardly ever her hands.

Yet, here she is, wavering her hand before him. And it waits there, an open invitation for his own hand to hold.

"Are you ready?" she asks, that familiar excitement laced in her voice. "It'd be a shame to never put these suits to use, wouldn't it?"

Hordak nods. "Indeed."

Without another moment to waste, Hordak takes Entrapta's hand in his own. It's warm and small in his grip, his own hand practically swallowing hers, but it feels like a perfect fit all the same.

And together, hand in hand, they head toward the airlock of the spaceship.

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Darla's airlock is very big, at least in respect to the rest of the ship, and its design is overall pretty simple. Hordak's gaze darts about as he studies the grey walls, the interior structure, and the door he now stands before - the very same one that separates him from the rest of the galaxy.

Entrapta stands beside him as well, now donning her helmet on her head that allows her pigtails to protrude out and cascade down behind her, right by her tether that attaches to the wall. She doesn't say or do anything, but yet, Hordak can practically feel the excitement radiating off of her. And as if hearing his thoughts, she looks up at him then, a grin plastered on her face.
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“Ohhh, this is gonna be so fun!” she says, squealing a little at the end.

Hordak smiles softly back. His hand, still held in hers, squeezes in reassurance.

“It will.”

“Well,” she says, “let’s not keep waiting around!”

And then, without allowing another moment to pass, her one pigtail snakes out behind her to tap on a control panel in the far back of the room. Now activated, the door in front of them begins to move. It goes slowly at first, but sure enough, it begins to pick up speed. Before long, the door is fully opened.

And the entirety of the galaxy stands before them.

Hordak’s eyes widen, taking in the sight. Sure, he’s seen this view several times before over the years traveling with Prime. But, *now,* however, it feels...different. Perhaps it’s because he hasn't truly been given the chance to admire it for a long time, or perhaps it’s because Entrapta is beside him with her hand held firmly in his, or perhaps it’s some combination of the two.

All he knows is that he’s in awe, and a certain lightness makes home in his heart.

Suddenly, Hordak feels a light tug on his hand. He looks down, and unsurprisingly, Entrapta is trying to urge him on and coax them out into space.

“C’mon!” she says, tone high-pitched with anticipation. “Let’s get out there!”

He nods, and at the very second of his confirmation, Entrapta leaps off the platform, consequently taking Hordak with him. Before long, they’re both soaring through space; their tethers are the only things that keep them from completely flying away from the ship.

As they soar, Hordak's eyes bounce about, taking in the sight that surrounds him. Blinking stars, shining planets, splashes of rich colors, *everything.* It's all so stunning, so captivating in this moment, and Hordak simply breathes it all in.

Never has he appreciated space this much, but Entrapta's presence remains by his side, and Hordak can't imagine a better feeling than this.

Finally, Entrapta releases her loose grip on his hand. He looks over in time to watch her bring her clenched fists to her cheeks, a look of wonder on her face with wide eyes and a dropped jaw. Her fists then start to rock by her face, a wordless expression of joy, before she starts to kick her feet and whir about beside him.

"It's just as amazing as I last remembered!" she exclaims before her words trail off into a high-pitched squeal. A round of true laughter soon follows, her fists rocking and feet kicking all the while.

And Hordak can't help but break into a matching smile as well. He simply stares, watching her in her glee, with his gaze fond and heart soft. She looks...well, *beautiful* besides him. Her cheeks are rosy, and her vibrant eyes reflect the glow of the galaxy before them. All the while, she continues to laugh as if she has no other way to express how she feels. And as they both continue to float about, Entrapta's hair follows suit, forming wild rivers of soft lavender that cascade around them both.

Truly, against the backdrop of rich blackness speckled with stars, Entrapta is the most vibrant. A being of color and joy and all things beautiful to Hordak.

In the entire galaxy, she's the brightest star among them all, and Hordak can't look away.

"Oh, thank you for taking me!" Entrapta yells, turning to look at him. "Really, thank you!"

Her words cut off there she erupts into laughter once more. She rocks her hands yet again, another burst of joy and another wordless expression of how she feels.

Until, finally, she speaks once more between laughs.

"Ah, Hordak, I love you!"

Hordak's heart stops in his chest.

Entrapta's eyes go wide, her body stilling.

And those last three words continue to echo around them. For a long moment, they remain there, floating between them both.

Especially one word in particular.

Love.

He realizes it then. It's only one word, yet it fits all of the scattered puzzle pieces in his brain together. It forms something whole, something understandable. It describes every burst of warmth, of tenderness, of longing for closeness that Hordak's felt with Entrapta for all of this time. Just one simple word, spoken between them, and it all becomes clear in his mind.

He loves her.

"I...I…" Entrapta stammers, a deep blush forming on her cheeks. Her body curls in a bit on herself, almost as if trying to protect herself from shame or embarrassment. Her eyes dart away, adding, "I shouldn't...I shouldn't have-"

"I love you, too."

Her gaze immediately snaps back. And the moment they lock with Hordak's, the galaxy seems to freeze around them both. His breath halts in his throat, his entire body numb, and all he can do is stare and stare and stare back at Entrapta.

Until, suddenly, that shocked expression on Entrapta's features breaks. It breaks into something soft, something warm, her eyes full of tenderness and cheeks colored with rose. She smiles at him, her eyes crinkling at the corners as they always tend to do, and she reaches her hand down to hold his. It slides perfectly in place, and Hordak revels in the feel of her touch, of the zap of electricity it shoots throughout his body.

And together, they both stare back out at the galaxy before them. Hordak allows himself a second to steal a glance at Entrapta, and sure enough, there's still the trace of a smile on her lips. Her eyes are dazed, dreamy even, and Hordak finds himself entranced in their beauty.

He loves her. He truly does. Never has a word made so much sense, felt so perfect passing through his lips.

And she loves him back.

As unbelievable as it sounds to admit, it's true, spoken between them both.

And he's left wondering how he got so lucky.

Breaking the peaceful stillness between them, Entrapta turns to face him. Voice soft, she says, "We should get back, huh?"

Hordak nods, and hand in hand, Entrapta leads them back to the ship. Their tethers guide them as well, and before long, they're both floating back inside. Once their feet are both somewhat secure on the platform, the door falls shut, and gravity takes control once more. Automatically, they both fall to the ground, laughter on both of their lips at the clumsiness they couldn't control.

Entrapta now kneels before him, taking off her helmet and allowing her lilac hair to sprawl around them both. She giggles softly as her laughter starts to finally die away, Hordak's as well, before she looks up at him.

“That was something,” she says, a cheesy grin making home on her lips.

“Indeed,” Hordak chuckles. “That was...something.”

The world calms around them then, and Entrapta’s grin falls into something less cheesy. It’s still there, however, only it’s now soft and fond on her lips as she stares up at Hordak. She doesn’t move at first, and neither does he, simply allowing them a moment of peace.

Until, all of a sudden, Entrapta’s hand begins to move. With slow movements, she brings it up to Hordak’s chest. And there, it hovers over the crystal for a second before she finally rests her fingers lightly on its surface.

“Can I tell you something?”

He nods immediately. “Of course.”

“The crystal...it says ‘luvd.’”

Hordak’s breath hitches in his throat.

“‘Loved?’”

“Well, it doesn’t say that *directly,* per sé,” she explains. “Technically, it spells it out. L-U-V-D, the phonetic spelling of the word ‘loved,’ written in First Ones’ symbols. When I first made it, I wasn’t sure if you could read First Ones. But, since you never said anything about it, I figured you couldn’t read it. So, I just...never brought it up.”

She looks away. “I probably should’ve told you, I know. But...I was scared of your reaction. Besides, I didn’t want to overwhelm you or anything. I had rather just stay quiet about it all then make a big deal over it.”

Her words end there, and she keeps her gaze locked on the ground all the while. Her hand finally drops from his chest, falling

onto her lap along with her other hand, where she begins to wring them together. In nerves or apprehension, Hordak isn't certain.

"So...Yeah. I'm sorry for never telling you sooner. I wish I had."

For a moment, Hordak only stares at her, eyes wide and breath stuck in his chest. He doesn't know how to respond, all words waiting in his throat yet failing to be spoken aloud, as her words reel around him and cloud all judgment in his mind.

And so, without giving himself a moment to think, he leans down and places a gentle hand on her cheek. She looks at him, startled, and he uses this chance to lean down and kiss her on the lips.

It's only for a moment. Only for a split second of contact. Until, as quickly as he had kissed her, he pulls away, gaze falling to the ground in shame.

"M...My apologies," he mutters. "I should have asked first. I-"

But he doesn't even have a chance to finish. For Entrapta's hand plants on his cheek, and he's pulled back in for another kiss - a *real* kiss, firm and confident and all.

In his daze, the first thing he realizes is that her lips are just as soft as he recalls from yesterday - back when she had pecked him on the cheek. Only, now, they're locked onto his lips. The contact sends courses of electricity throughout his body, filling him with a feeling of passion he has yet to experience, and he deepens the kiss further. Entrapta's hands trails down to his neck, holding him there, and Hordak follows suit with his own hand, except he plants his on her waist.

And they stay like that for a long moment - or perhaps a very short moment, Hordak isn't too certain. All he knows is that his heart is pounding in his chest and all feelings have gone haywire inside of his body.

Eventually, Entrapta pulls away to breathe. And the second they lock eyes, she laughs lightly.

“Oh. Wow. I liked that more than I thought I would,” she says, words somewhat breathless as she still recovers from the kiss.

Hordak chuckles. “What? Did you have low expectations?”

“No, no, that’s not what I meant!” she laughs louder, shaking her head. “I just mean, well, I’ve never kissed someone before, to be honest. So, I wasn’t really sure what to expect. But, I actually really liked that!”

She giggles a little more, rubbing her neck all the while and allowing her gaze to topple to the ground. Hordak simply stares, admiring the way her cheeks still glow a soft pink that accents the vibrant color in her eyes.

But soon enough, she looks back up and breaks the silence between them.

“I...Hordak...Thank you.”

“Hm?” he asks, raising a brow.

“For taking me here.”

Hordak smiles, his heart light as ever as he stares down at her. “Anything for you, Entrapta.”

It’s true. Deep down, in the moment, he knows that he’d do anything for her.

Anything for the one he loves.

Chapter End Notes

> oh man my poor shipper’s heart had so much fun writing all that :)
>
> comments and kudos are super appreciated! (and come say hello on tumblr - i’m beckkii there!)

also, dae-stuff on tumblr and twitter made amazing art inspired by this chapter! check it out here! - https://dae-stuff.tumblr.com/post/645674971238137856/the-contact-sends-courses-of-electricity

Hand-in-Hand

Chapter Notes

oh boy, this is it! the last chapter! don't worry - no more angst, just lab partners in love as i finish this fic :)

(and some little obstacles, but you'll see...;))

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The plan was to return sometime during the day. That way, they could arrive back in Bright Moon in a less suspicious manner. No sneaking inside the castle, no hushed voices and careful steps to avoid making noise, no creeping throughout the halls just as they had left. Instead, they could arrive in the light of day, hiding any initial fear and being as open about their return as possible. Perhaps that way, the princesses may be less angry about how they had even left in the first place.

That was the plan, anyway.

But plans never work out the way they're supposed to, do they?

For by the time Entrapta and Hordak reach Etheria's surface once more, night has long since fallen, and stars like decorative jewels now blanket the dark sky. The moons are particularly bright as well, reflecting a faint golden glow across Etheria - one that they use to guide them through the otherwise pitch-black Whispering Woods. Though, unlike the night of their departure several nights ago, the air now is hot and devoid of any pleasant wind.

Well, on the plus side, at least no one appears to be awake as Bow and Adora were that one night. For when Entrapta and Hordak finally reach the courtyard and survey its landscape, no people or movement can be found. Bright Moon's castle appears to be absent of any activity, as well - the lights are all off, and no sound comes from it.

“Okay, I think we’re good to go in,” Entrapta says, voice hushed. “I don’t think I see anyone here. Do you?”

“No. Though, I still wish we had arrived sometime during the day. Going inside the castle now feels...invasive, somehow.”

Entrapta shrugs. “Nothing we can do about it now, is there?”

Hordak sighs. Because no, there isn’t, but that doesn't make this thing any less nerve-wracking for him.

But he hardly gets a chance to dwell on it any longer, for Entrapta whispers an urgent “Let’s go!” before beginning to race through the courtyard. And Hordak is left watching her pigtails fly behind her, dumbfounded at the way she always jumps into action without a second thought or care. No planning, no careful consideration about what awaits them, nothing. He gives a little shake of his head in disbelief before racing behind her, having no other choice than to follow.

Before long, they reach Bright Moon’s front doors. Entrapta freezes at the door, hesitant, before drawing in a breath and tugging on the handle. The one door opens, a loud creak echoing from the movements, and Hordak silently prays that no one will hear it from within the castle. Finally, Entrapta manages to open it fully, and they both slip in as silent as they can manage. The door shuts softly behind them with a *click,* and just like that, they’re in. Seemingly unnoticed, too.

Well, for now, anyway. There’s still the possibility of people being awake amongst the castle that they just haven’t seen yet. But, from what Hordak can tell from here, the castle is just as lifeless and silent as he suspected. The hallways are devoid of any sound, and any light is sucked from them, save for the faint glow of stars and moons that spill pale light across the walls and floors.

“Hm, I don’t see anyone yet…” Entrapta whispers under her breath, her pigtails lifting her up and carrying her about as she surveys the front of the castle. “I don’t think, at least…”

With her words trailing away into silence, her pigtails finally carry her back down to the ground. And just as before, without any thought or consideration, she begins to race down the first hallway. Her voice, hushed yet urgent, floats over her shoulder for Hordak to hear.

"Come on! Let's get to our room!"

Hordak gives another shake of his head, biting back a smile at Entrapta's sporadic ways. But as always, he follows behind.

He catches up to her soon enough, and together, they trek briskly through the hallways. By now, even with the dim light, they're both familiar enough with the hallway layout to get through - the very same layout that once was a maze to Hordak. It wasn't even too long ago; he can still perfectly recall his first night here and how nervous, how anxious, how overwhelmed he felt. How he had run into Catra, how he had to awkwardly maneuver his way around these princesses, how all he longed for was a moment of respite with Entrapta. Someone who, even then, he was unsure of how to approach. Not in the sense of friendship, but in the sense of something...more.

He looks down at her now, and a fond look graces his lips. They've come a long way in this short time, haven't they?

He wouldn't trade any of it for the world.

"Wow, looks like we got pretty lucky," Entrapta says then, her voice startling Hordak out of his thoughts. She looks up at him, adding, "Everyone must be asleep, I guess."

"We may return unnoticed now, but it still leaves the question on what we plan to say to them in the morning," Hordak says, finally speaking aloud the very question that's been plaguing his mind this entire time. "You are aware that we still have to face them sooner or later, correct?"

Entrapta's lips quirk up into a guilty smile. "Yeah, I know, but at least *now* we don't have to."

"Still. I'm worried for-"

Hordak's words quickly cut off, for he misplaces his footing and looks down just in time to watch it land right on the tip of Entrapta's one pigtail.

And in a flash, but of them are soaring towards the ground.

On instinct, Hordak squeezes his eyes shut and tenses his body, preparing for the cold floor's sharp impact. But, to his surprise, it never comes. Instead, within seconds, soft hair is felt wrapping around his waist and back, paired with a study hand that grips onto his side and a sudden warm pressure that presses up against his body. The world stops around him, and in his confusion, he blinks his eyes open, finding now that his body never did collide with the ground after all. No, he's hovering over it, his body a few mere inches away from collision.

And only then, eyes open now, does he notice the shadow looming above him. Not only the shadow, but the *body,* too. For there Entrapta is, her body pressed onto his. Even more, her one hand still grips onto his side, while her free hand is planted on the ground right by his head for stability. All the while, both pigtails are still wrapped around his body, keeping him off the ground. Slowly, they finally lower him onto the ground, and Entrapta and Hordak both stay there like that for a long moment, hitched breaths trying to calm into even ones.

The initial panic eventually passes, and her eyes lock with his. All he can do is stare back, mouth open yet failing to produce words. For she's so close, so much so that he can feel her heartbeat thrumming against his chest. Only then does he notice his own heartbeat - it pounds in his ears, paired with a sudden awareness of a burning warmth spreading across his cheeks. *That cursed blush,* he realizes.

Immediately, Entrapta smiles. It soon becomes something more sly, more amused, and she narrows her ruby eyes as they bore

into his. Now, they almost seem to glow in the moonlight, the vibrant color of her irises reflecting the magnificent moons' rays.

"Oh, hello," she says in a low voice, smiling all the while.

Hordak glances away for a split second, unable to hold his stare with those intense eyes, as his ears fall in shame. Even worse, he can feel that damned blush as it spreads across them, as well. Finally, he looks back at her, and he swallows to clear his throat before speaking, hoping his words will come out as even as possible but knowing with certainty that they won't.

"...Hello."

Entrapta giggles then, soft and amused all the same. And Hordak's just about to say something back when something touches his ear - something rough yet familiar. His eyes dart over, and sure enough, Entrapta's one gloved hand is rubbing his ears, her soft laughter accompanying the movements.

"Aww, your ears!" she cries out, smiling wide. "I love when they do that. You know, that little turn-down thing they do when you're embarrassed."

Immediately, his ear flicks away from her hand on instinct, and Entrapta only laughs further at Hordak's shame. Heat spreads over his whole face now, and all he can manage is a mumbled growl, trying to remain stoic despite the shame that suffocates him.

"Entrapta-"

"Aww, they're so fascinating," she continues. Her eyes now sparkle as she continues studying his ear and rubbing it, much to Hordak's horror. "They convey so many emotions in such simple gestures! Though not a unique trait to your species alone, they're still so interesting! *And* cute."

"Entrapta, I swear, I will-"

She laughs loudly once more, completely ignoring him. Now, her smile is as wide as ever, eyes crinkled in the corners in that way they always tend to do whenever she's truly happy. And despite his fiery embarrassment, in that moment, he isn't thinking about any of that anymore. He's only focused on her, on her delight, on how her laughter ripples throughout the hallway in such an erratic yet such a familiar way that makes Hordak's heart burst with a pleasant warmth.

With a feeling of love, he realizes.

"Sorry, Hordak," she finally says, her voice light with the edges of fading laughter, "I'm just being-"

"Uh, guys?"

Hordak's heart stops dead in his chest.

Oh no.

In a panic, his gaze snaps over from his spot still on the ground, eyes wide and frantic. And there, standing before them amidst the hallway, are the last people he'd like to see right now.

Bow, Glimmer, Adora, and Catra.

Oh no.

In a flash, Entrapta is up and off of Hordak using her pigtails, now standing besides him instead. And all Hordak can do is watch from his spot on the ground, helpless and cursing how he's unable to move as quickly as she can with her hair. As fast as possible for him, he moves up into a sitting position, though he makes no attempt to fully stand.

So still on the floor, he looks back over to the group before him. They all just stand there, eyes wide and expressions unsure. Even more, they're all dressed in sleep wear - tank tops and shorts - with eye bags drooping from their eyes, and Hordak realizes then that they must've all just been asleep. Well, not until they dragged

themselves out here at the sound of noises in this hallway, most likely.

At that realization, guilt of accidentally waking them seeps in amongst the horror he already feels. *Had* he and Entrapta woken them up? How long have they been standing there? How much have they seen?

And how did he never even *notice* them?

But he doesn't have a chance to ponder on these questions any longer, for Catra is the first one to break the silence between them, a sly smile curling up her lips.

"Hey."

That's all she says. So curt, yet so amused nonetheless, as if she's enjoying the awkwardness that's settled between them all and the shame that must be evident on Hordak and Entrapta's faces.

"Uh...Hello," Entrapta answers quietly, the usual boldness in her voice now completely gone. She gives a little wave paired with a meek smile, yet it's awkward and terribly stilted. And so, without another word, she looks away and begins to wring her hands together.

No one says anything for a long while, and the air falls heavy around them all. Hordak watches as Glimmer, standing in the middle, tosses Adora besides her an incredulous look, almost as if speaking something between them both that Hordak can't understand. Adora smiles awkwardly at Glimmer's gaze, her smile both too wide and too uncertain, and she seems to understand what Glimmer's trying wordlessly to communicate. And finally, Adora pipes up, widely gesturing both hands in Hordak and Entrapta's direction.

"See," she says, her cheery voice too loud in the otherwise quiet hallway, "I told you they promised they'd be back!"

Glimmer doesn't answer. Instead, she only looks back out at Hordak and Entrapta, her expression unreadable. Silence befalls them all once more, and Hordak itches to say something, *anything.*

But he doesn't even get a chance, for Bow finally speaks out, his tone a mixture of awe and disbelief.

"Did...Did you guys go to *space?"*

The words hover between them. Hordak looks over at Entrapta, watching as her skin pales and eyes widen.

"How did you-?"

"Adora and I tried following you after you left Bright Moon," Bow cuts Entrapta off. "When we finally caught up, Darla was gone."

Entrapta snaps her mouth shut at that, and she looks over at Hordak. They share a wordless stare for a long time, neither of them saying anything and neither of them making a move. Hordak knows that they couldn't avoid this, but being *caught* somehow is worse than allowing them a chance to explain. And Hordak can see the panic in her eyes now, can see the way that she feels the same.

The hallway is silent for only a moment more, for Entrapta finally tears her eyes away from Hordak's and speaks up.

"It was my fault."

"What?" Hordak counters, voice risen. "No, no, it wasn't."

"Yes, it was-"

"No, *I* was the one who took you. The blame is entirely on me."

Entrapta shakes her head and looks out at the group before them once more. "No, really, I was the one who pushed Hordak to go. Don't be upset with him - it was all me."

“Entrapta, stop, it was my fault. Punish me, not her,” Hordak snaps back, jabbing a finger at his chest.

“Hordak, no, we never would’ve gone if I didn’t keep pushing you.”

“Stop, this isn’t your fault. It’s-“

“No, really, I was-“

“Enough!”

Hordak and Entrapta both fall silent, for a new booming voice quickly cuts them off.

Glimmer.

She stands there, fists clenched by her sides and wide eyes darting between Hordak and Entrapta. Back and forth, back and forth, back and forth - an endless pendulum swinging between them both that’s unsure on where to land. Her body is tense at first, but finally, once they both quiet and resolve to only stare at her in shock, she relaxes a little. Fists unclench by her sides. A tired expression makes home on her face instead of a strained one. Eyes finally land on the ground.

And she doesn’t say anything. All she does is look at the ground, features still unreadable in a way that fills Hordak with unease, that makes him shift side-to-side on his feet as if that would settle his nerves. It doesn’t.

“Are you…” Entrapta begins, her voice meek, “...mad at us?”

Glimmer doesn’t answer at first. Instead, she simply gives a little shake of her head. It’s so quick, so small, that if Hordak had blinked, he would have missed it. She sighs as well, her shoulders hanging by her side in defeat.

“No, I’m just…You two are…I don’t get why…”

She shakes her head again, much more obvious this time, as she drags a tired hand across her face. But then, much to Hordak's surprise, he catches sight of something strange - a smile on her lips. It's small and discreet, but it's there nonetheless, hidden beneath her hand. And as her hand finally leaves her face, her smile widens, tired and wavering yet growing all the same. She huffs out a laugh, short and quiet, her smile withstanding.

Hordak and Entrapta share a look then, confusion clear on their features. Are they missing something here? Why is she-

"I'm tired," is all Glimmer says before turning on her heels. She starts to walk away, adding over her shoulder, "I'm going back to bed."

For a long moment, everyone simply watches her as she leaves. No one moves, and no one says a word. All they do is watch her disappear down the hall as they listen to the soft patter of her footsteps on the ground. Eventually, Bow, Adora, and Catra all look at each other, shrugging in wordless confusion. And finally, they last look back at Hordak and Entrapta, the awkwardness draping between them all once more.

"Well, uh," Adora says, words awfully cheerful and far too loud amidst the once-heavy silence, "guess I'll get going to bed, too!"

"Yeah, um, same," Bow adds, his tone stilted. He offers a small smile - hesitant, yet genuine all the same - to Hordak and Entrapta before looking towards Catra, saying, "Catra? Are you-"

"Yeah, yeah. I'm coming."

With that said, they all turn around and head back down the hallway in the direction that they came. Hordak and Entrapta simply watch them go as their bodies become smaller, and smaller, and smaller with each step. Eventually, they reach the end, and they round the corner and disappear from sight.

And Hordak and Entrapta are finally left alone again.

He stands up from the floor before looking over at Entrapta. She rubs her neck, gaze still locked where the group once appeared and brow furrowed in confusion all the while. She finally looks up at Hordak, saying, "I...guess they're not mad at us?"

"I suppose so," Hordak says, words drawn out as if he can't quite be certain in what he's saying. "They would have punished us then if they were planning to at all, wouldn't they?"

She shrugs. "I mean, I think so. Looks like the trip to space was worth it after all, huh?"

She smiles up at him at that, her grin soft and eyes gentle. And there she stands, bathed in a moonlight hue, features seeming to reflect the light's faint glow. Warmth makes home in Hordak's heart as he stares down at her, his stomach fluttering with butterflies and ears flicking down. And just like that, he finds himself smiling. He smiles truly as ever, unable to hold it back and unable to fight the way her pure happiness has *always* been contagious.

"The trip would still be worth it even if we *did* get punished," Hordak answers, his tone soft.

At that, Entrapta's features light up. She nods in agreement, her smile widening all the while.

"You're right!"

And then, just like that, Entrapta's pigtails carry her up to Hordak's level. She doesn't waste a moment - in a flash, a soft kiss is planted on his cheek, the sensation tingling there long after her lips disappear. She lowers herself back down just as quickly, though Hordak still catches sight of the fond smile on her lips, on the way soft rose lights up her cheeks as she blushes.

She then offers him a hand, gentle eyes locked on him as she waits. Hordak doesn't hesitate to take it; he places his claw in her small hand, reveling in the warmth of her touch and the perfect

way her fingers fit between his. And together, they begin their walk back towards their bedroom.

“So,” Hordak pipes up after a few moments, “Do you want the bed tonight and I take the sleeping bag, or-“

“Hordak, why don’t we just share the bed instead?”

“...Oh. You’re right. I’d certainly prefer that.”

“I would, too.”

Chapter End Notes

anddd it’s done! thank you all so much for reading! your comments, kudos, bookmarks, and overall encouragement has all meant so much to me - i appreciate every single one of you while i wrote this :)

also, i definitely hope to write more for these two, so stick around if you’d like! some part of me is tempted to write more in this story’s universe since i still have a lot i would’ve liked to add, but i’m not sure! i definitely will be writing more entrapdak though, based on this story or otherwise!

(one more thing - come say hello on tumblr! i’m beckkii there :))

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!